Catra of Brightmoon, She-Ra of Brightmoon

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42756732.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M, Gen, M/M

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), She-Ra: Princess Of Power (1985)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra/Being Conflicted

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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Part 1 of Catra of Brightmoon

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by Runeless

Summary

Catra ends up with the sword. Everything is different from that point on.

(Or: an abused child finds a sword and a new home, a new people, and a new family, and rises above all things to become a legend.)

Notes

I will always owe Feynites on Tumblr for inspiring me to write this series, which has went so much, much farther than I ever intended.

But as I have grown in my writing, I've grown increasingly uncomfortable with certain aspects of that inspiration, both in the sense that it no longer fits with the version of these people that I have now written, nor with the cultures I've elaborated on.

While I am generally reluctant to engage in retcons, I feel I get a pass on this one, given that I've advanced so much as a writer. I mean, hell, if DC can get away with doing it every single year, I feel like I get ONE freebie. :D

I will not be rewriting the other two parts- upon review, they mostly still hold up, and I do not want to do that thing so many artists and writers do, where they endlessly update their old works without making new ones. I will engage in this ONE time, and no more.

More chapters coming, as soon as I can make them.

So, still inspired by Feynites' AU, Cat-Ra, located here: https://feynites.tumblr.com/post/180157286719/cat-ra-part-one, but no longer so devoted to the entire "mind control" thing, and with Etheria in the shape it will be, I present to you:

The first story of Catra of Brightmoon, as it should have been.

The Door Opens (The Path Less-Traveled)

CATRA OF BRIGHTMOON, SHE-RA OF BRIGHTMOON

Chapter One:

The Door Opens

(The Path Less-Traveled)

The argument on the skiff goes wrong, the way it always does.

It doesn't always happen, of course. Time is a river of many courses, and while each winds somewhere safely to the sea, the courses can take many forms.

Some things never change; there is not an infinite stream of possibilities. Some routes are closed off. Adora, for example, is always taken to Etheria in the year 1013 ID, if Light Hope is still functioning by that time. If she is taken, then the little First One will always found by Hordak, who has been waiting for another portal, who is watching for one with his tech- and who, due to that watchfulness, is the one person on Etheria who will know of the portal, popping open in that little grassy field in Plumeria that the Horde had so recently conquered. Hordak will always be the one person in a position to save Adora from death by exposure, for Light Hope used her energy bringing her to Despondos, unable

to do anything else... and no one else was in the area, having fled the Horde's arrival a week before. Only Hordak will ever stand over a child, faced with a choice.

And to his utmost credit, no matter who he is when he reaches this point- be he hero or monster- he will always do so. No timeline exists in all the spiraling chaos of reality in which Hordak, seeing that little child in that field of grass outside southern Plumeria, decides to leave her there to die. There is no world in which Adora's bones decorate that grassy field, even if it isn't Horde territory at all.

In every possible world- in every permutation wherein Hordak is alive, where he stands in that field, where *this* choice gets to be made at all- his coin only ever spins once, and only idly at that. He never seriously considers any other option; he *always* chooses to save her.

(Because, looking at her- having no inkling then of what she is- he knows that she, too, is the only one of her kind on an alien world, and in being like no one else, they are alike- and that empathy will lead him to care for her.)

He will take her to safety. But it is not always the Horde, or even the Horde as oppressors; worlds exist where, due to changed circumstance, Hordak changes, too.

In some worlds, he is King Uinta's strong right hand, defending the Fright Zone's ruler from assassins as the King makes the changes needed to tear his nation's corruption out by the root- a battle that, in every permutation, will require outside help. In some worlds, chasing his duty, Hordak goes about the world with

the exiled King and his family in tow, begging for aid; in every version of that timeline, it is Plumeria that will finally agree, and Hordak will fight alongside its Princess as civil war consumes the Fright Zone, the nobility and the commoners going to war, the King picking the latter, and both beloved and besieged for it. They will win, and forge a friendship that will last after death, for when Plumeria's princess is killed by one last spiteful noble of the old aristocracy years later, Hordak will personally watch over the extremely young Perfuma, and protect her in the memory of his friend.

In those worlds, he finds Adora soon after, and she will grow up in the reforming Fright Zone, taking her place as Hordak's adopted daughter. Perfuma will be her childhood playmate, and when she meets Princess Hadru D'Ream, hidden away to protect her from assassins... well, Adora will fall, and fall hard, for the woman who would be called Scorpia in most timelines. The Princess' friendliness (and muscles) will attract Adora, and Adora's bravery and kindness will attract Hadru; the eventual marriage, presided over by Perfuma, will be seen as almost a fairy tale ending, that Hordak's daughter will marry King Uinta's granddaughter, that the man who saved the kingdom will have descendants involved in the running of it. Hordak will weep at the wedding, and forget the face of his creator, his desire to prove himself to his maker, finding peace at last.

In other worlds, Hordak builds a Horde that goes as far as it should, and not an inch farther, that draws a line in soft sand and treats it as unbreakable steel. This Horde conquers the Fright Zone, conquers Vargon, conquers GaleBreath, conquers Green Thatch... and stops, for those were the nations already in revolt, whose people had already risen against evil. Hordak will not invade a nation that is not already crying out for help; he is no conquering overlord, but a liberator. He will lead the oppressed to

victory thought impossible, and for this he will be hated in many corners...

But he will be absolutely loved in many others. In particular he will be loved in Brightmoon, who will adore him utterly. There is something of the purest Silver in such heroism, as Angella knows, as she will state publicly when Brightmoon becomes the first nation to recognize him and his new nation. Her people's fascination with him becomes almost endemic when stories circulate that he has not visibly aged in all the years he has been on Etheria. They will begin to think he might be like their own Queen, an elemental thing, and rumors will circulate that, just as Angella is the Moonstone made manifest, perhaps Hordak is the Black Garnet's own soul, that he is lightning and power that walks like a man.

Maybe that is why he is strong enough to do as he has done- and wasn't lightning always associated with new things, with sudden ideas, coming like bolts out of the blue? No wonder he is an inventor, a maker of things, be they tech or nations; it is part of his very nature.

(The author who, in other timelines, wrote the *Pummeling Princess* series will do a different set in these worlds, based on this idea, starting with Hordak's birth from the Black Garnet- books that Hordak collects so he can set them on fire, enraged as he is by the misunderstandings and mistakes in the text. Angella collects them too, mostly for personal amusement.)

These Hordaks take their Adoras home to *this* Horde, to be placed in an orphanage, eventually to be adopted by a Hordesman named Shakra, who has wounds from the Vargon campaign and works for Hordak in intelligence. Shakra, who all unknowing

shares her First Ones' name with the girl, was not tuned to family work... but she knows Hordak sees something special in the baby, and so she will adopt the girl, naming her Tara after a young Desert Elf Force Captain whom she's friendly with. Hordak will run his nation, stumbling sometimes when it comes to domestic issues, for he is a thing built for war and not peace... but he is a sentient being, and he can learn. In time, he will correct his failings, and the faltering steps will become the running of a great nation; Tara, as Adora is named in these worlds, will be a proud Hordesman, growing up in one of the world's leading lights, Hordak ruling not as tyrant but as liberator and visionary.

But those are rarer worlds. Even amongst infinities, there are concepts of less and more in terms of commonness, in terms of percentage; and in most worlds, Hordak builds his Horde as no free nation but as the war-machine of a tyrant, his hunger for a thing that does not exist- his creator's love- driving him to desperation. He will take Adora to be part of the grist for that soldier's mill, inflicting on her the harm his own maker inflicted on him, a chain of hurt long years in the making.

(It is the thing that unites him and Catra; on both their hearts are written similar sentences, of pain, of longing for the love of one who should give it freely- and while it does not excuse the evil both do in so many worlds, it *does* explain it.)

And so in most worlds, this comes to pass: there are two girls on a skiff in the northernmost parts of the Horde, in the year 1013 ID, the way Etheria marked the years it was In Despondos. Two soldiers of the Horde, both raised by Shadow Weaver, both halfway between childhood and adulthood, fighting over the controls in a fit of childish playfulness and spite. One makes a mistake, a mistake that sends them tumbling over the side, to hit the ground and destiny both with a world-shaking impact.

But in *this* timeline... it is not Adora who falls.

Catra falls, and wakes up to find herself near a sword. No, no, that is wrong, she knows that even in this moment when she knows nothing; she wakes up to find a Sword, there is a Capital on this one. There is... weight, here, to this discarded blade, which sits as though it has been *waiting.*

Swords are not Catra's thing. If she must wield a weapon, she honestly prefers a staff, since she doesn't really need an edged weapon. It's not like she hasn't had five swords on the end of each hand all her life, after all, she's positively *overloaded* when it comes to swords, she has ten of the damn things.

But this Sword is not like her ten swords, for a million different reasons, reasons she almost knows the shape of even as she stares at it in uncomprehending wonder. There's just... *something* about this blade...

Still, even her amateur eyes can see that this Sword is perfect, obviously worth something, and somewhere in the back of her head, she thinks that, while it's not really for her... maybe Adora would like to have it. Shadow Weaver wouldn't let Catra keep it anyway, would steal it from her- as she takes all things of worth Catra cannot hide from her- but Adora would get to keep it, and she's always really liked swords, and... and maybe she'd like it as a gift.

Just a gift.

(Catra tries not to think of the warmth inside, when she thinks of doing that, she forces herself to pretend that it doesn't light up something inside. Some part of her resents Adora so much it almost chokes her, but some other part feels... something else. Something so warm and gentle that it would shatter Catra to admit it, water wearing away a mountain inside if she admits to it; a terrible sweetness that she cannot grasp, not without shattering like ice exposed to the sun.)

So Catra touches the Sword, and all the world breaks around her.

(A moment, a second- resistance- the Sword doesn't want her, but then something as big as a planet weighs on it *hard,* pushes, pushes, pushes, until the Sword *must* relent and accept her; and Catra sees, in a split-second she will never remember, the image of a brown-skinned woman, putting a hand to her shoulder, as though passing down a legacy.)

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Catra returns to base that night.

She's back out within the week, hunting the Sword.

She has to.

The Sword... it's something *special* and it is *hers,* she knows that down to her bones. It's *hers,* the way nothing has ever been, a thing that *belongs* to her. It is not a hand-me-down or castoff or gift from Adora, one of the many mercies Catra must begrudgingly accept out of necessity, nor is it one of the many things Catra steals or bullies or cajoles out of others, manipulating them to get what she wants; it is something unique, something that she chose *that chose her back.* Nothing in her life has ever done that before, save Adora alone; Catra knows the Sword is *hers,* somehow, and the bones of her hand ache with the want of holding it.

So she goes to find it, and does, having almost a mental compass to direct her. When she puts her hand back on it, words come to her, unbidden, words that are so cheesy, so ridiculous, even thinking of them feels dumb as hell. What's a Grayskull? She doesn't know that word. Sounds like a place, or maybe a group.

Honor, of course, is meaningless. She hears Hordesmen talk about it, about honor, and she knows what that means. It means *obey,* it means *do as you are told,* it means *serve until you break.* It's one of the many pretty things they throw on top of the truth to make it look better, a favorite practice in the Fright Zone. Words are the main way they do it- words like honor. Duty, that's another favorite, along with responsibility; loyalty, now, that's the capstone, they save it for the *big* stuff. Bullshit they sell about cadet classes sticking together, loving each other, united through thick and thin.

Catra knows that's bullshit. No one in her cadet class have ever saved *her*, after all, or loved her- only Adora.

(The Horde's society had failed Catra before her adult teeth had come in; no one knew how vile the place was like one who'd

fallen between its cracks.)

Still, she says them, because it feels like she *should*, and...

Holy fuck.

What the *hell* did it do to her?

Oh fuck, fuck, *fuck,* Hordak's swinging ballsack, what is she?

She's eight foot tall, powerful, well-dressed. Not sure where the clothes- which fit perfectly- came from. She's a massive tiger, striped and majestic- and she likes the color design. Purest white, shimmering gold... she's *magnificent,* and the effect is only enhanced when she realizes that these colors are the opposite of Shadow Weaver's blacks and purples, a thing that quietly pleases her.

Hell, Catra always *did* like lounging in the sun.

But there is a mild disconnect, she feels a bit weak and sick; apparently this transformation has a cost, and she's paying it now. The dizziness comes at the worst time, because Catra's luck is fucking shit; she's found by a Rebel scouting party, consisting of a glittery brute and an archer.

Not a surprise- Catra *was* on the northern edge of Horde territory, after all, well into the zone that the Great Rebellion patrolled- but unwelcome, and even as Catra attacked them, she wondered if she'd get strung up on a noose if she lost. Rebels did that kind of shit, and worse, if you believed the rumor mill...

She loses. Her dizziness- this disconnect in her forms- and her sheer unfamiliarity with fighting in her new form gives them an opening, which the archer exploits by tangling her feet with an arrow that bursts into ropes; as she's falling, the glittery brute teleports into what Catra, even mid-fall, must admire as a truly *beautiful* uppercut, which punches her into a concussion with record speed.

Thus, the first impression the Princess Alliance makes on Catra is fist-shaped.

By the time she wakes up, she has been dragged at incredible speed- born of multiple teleports and a fast Brightmoon hoverskiff- many, many miles. From the north of the Horde to Brightmoon Castle itself, almost instantaneously, a trip that *exhausts* the glittery brute and apparently burns out the device the duo were using, something the archer made that he claims is "undergoing engine meltdown", a lot of words that mean the damn thing explodes right as they reach the Castle. They abandon it beforehand, and Catra, still blinking away her own confusion, observes with calmness as the hovering vehicle falls to the ground almost gently before violently tearing itself apart.

After a long conversation with the guards that buys Catra time to finally wake up, she and the glittery brute are both dragged before a Queen; odd. She'd heard that Rebels strung people up on trees and did weird shit to the bodies, not drag them to what

looks, to Catra's Horde eyes, like a court-martial. |Maybe they wanted somebody in a crown to tell them what to do. That's what people in the Horde said was wrong with the Runestone Kingdoms; slaves to uncaring Princess masters, shaman-queens they worshiped in their ignorance, placing crowns on unworthy heads.

Brightmoon's Queen is a... bird or something, the bitch has wings. Wild. Her face emits a gentle kind of concern, an expression Catra has never seen before and is much frustrated by as the glittery brute and archer man drag her chained self forward. Why is this woman looking at her like that? She's never seen that kind of expression before, that odd crinkling of the eyes- maybe she has vision problems.

(Catra doesn't know that it is motherly concern, that Angella sees how young she is, and worries for her, even as she recognizes the threat she represents.)

The Queen calls her daughter out- apparently the glittery brute is related to the angel, which is odd, they don't seem much alike- not until Catra, now behind the younger for the first time, sees the two little useless wings on her back, fluttering anxiously. Huh. Those wings looked useless; how could they lift her up? That didn't look like big fancy wings so much as like, a tumor, or a growth that was oddly wing-shaped. Not big enough for much.

Still, bizarre as all that is, the situation itself is still pretty familiar to Catra. Shadow Weaver's face slips over the Queen's for a minute, as she chews her daughter out, and Catra feels a moment's sympathy for the brute... Glimmer, apparently, given the Queen's ranting. Glimmer, who does not run away or cry, but stands firm.

Catra cannot help the part of her heart that's actually kind of... impressed. She wouldn't have done so well if Shadow Weaver had been in such a mood. Oh, Catra will backtalk whenever she can... but she knows there are... limits. Catra knows she will flinch away from them on instinct before she gets there, has learned through the school of hard knocks- and Shadow Weaver's cruel magic- just how much line her leash holds.

But Glimmer doesn't seem to have a single flinch inside her; in the face of the Queen's rage, of this being that is just Shadow Weaver in an angel's costume, Glimmer stands firm.

So Catra does her a surprising kindness- she pays attention to what she's saying.

" This is the She-Ra! She has the Sword!" Glimmer said. " She's supposed to be a hero, right?"

" This is a *Horde Soldier,*" the Queen says in return. Catra wonders if she should point out that technically she's a few months short of full military service, of being a proper soldier; she's still just a recruit, as Hordesmen like herself put things.

(Well, she *assumes* she's a few month's short. She doesn't know how long she has been alive, how old she is, or even how long she'll last; she is unique, as far as she knows, has never met a being like herself, that is something human and something feline at the same time, and in the dark of her heart she privately suspects that she is one of Shadow Weaver's experiments, spared termination at her creator's hands only by Adora's kindness.)

“ Destiny is never wrong!” Glimmer replies. Catra, staying silent for now, wonders what the *fuck* she's talking about. What's a She-Ra?

“ You had to punch her out to bring her here!” the Queen points out, and Catra mentally chalks one up for the bitch on the throne, that's a good point.

“ She just doesn't know any better!” Glimmer protests, and Catra can't help the frown she shoots at her. “ The Horde- the Horde must have screwed with her head. She'll come around!”

There's more fighting after that, more harsh words, more shouting. Catra doesn't say a word; there's no hooks here, she doesn't know these people, and she finds herself surprisingly reluctant to speak up. Part of that is probably the ongoing head wound, really- though that's lessening, she's healing pretty fast. She knows almost to the moment how fast she usually heals; Shadow Weaver, awful as she is, was excellent for teaching Catra how long it would take her to heal a broken ankle, a twisted wrist, a joint that was screaming in pain from being pulled too far in direcitons it was never meant to go in.

But... a big chunk of it is simply that this is... familiar. A repeat of her own relationship with Shadow Weaver.

She is taken away, first to be seen by a healer- who reports that she is healing quickly, and that she fears to interfere with

whatever Catra's body is doing- then to a “prison” cell that is better than any room Catra has ever slept in; these people are soft, soft, soft and weak, and their mattresses are even worse. She mockingly asks her jailors- a pair of guards dressed almost like owls in their armor- if they have a harder bed, or if she has to drown in the covers. Catra resorts to the floor, which is actually pretty comfortable, compared to some of the places she's had to sleep.

(Shadow Weaver likes to awaken her by hurting her; it has made Catra cautious about where she sleeps, about only resting her eyes when she is somewhere out of the witch's casual reach.)

But they bring food, real *food*, not ration bars; Catra has heard of this, even if she's never eaten it before, learned of it from eavesdropping on older officers from other nations; and her first bite, it is heaven, *this* is what food can be? She eats, and asks if there is more to be had; and to her surprise, they bring it, the guard explaining “letting a prisoner starve is beneath us.” It is... something nice and warm, she's not sure what it is, but it tastes *amazing.* Something hot and savory with this deep rich brown sauce over it. There is a little bundle of something spongy and hearty next to it, with a little crust that crunches pleasingly when she bites into it.

(Chopped Bundas beef with gravy and a bread roll, as she will learn later.)

Even the water that accompanies it is better than she's used to, doesn't have the iron tang all Fright Zone water has, and she can have as much of it as she wants.

The room has a little bathroom to the side that she can use, with a door she can shut and lock. There's a shower- which she doesn't

use, given how much she hates showering- but there is a big tub in there, and it turns out that the faucet has *water,* she can fill the tub with water and just... sink into it.

She fills the tub with warm water and sinks down into it- which makes a mess, it splashes fucking everywhere, she hadn't accounted for how much water she'd displace- but she doesn't *care,* this is so *nice,* she sinks into the warm water and feels the heat seep deep into her skin and soothe tightness and wounds she didn't even know she'd had. She feels...

She feels good.

She panics after a few moments, mind flashing to Shadow Weaver- she never gets to have *anything* that isn't poisoned- but after she leaps up, suddenly and viciously awake, she remembers that she is in *Brightmoon,* that if this place has a single redeeming feature, it is that an *army* sits between her and Shadow Weaver. The witch would have to fight all Brightmoon to reach her here.

So, after a moment, she sinks back down into the tub, into the warm and soothing water, into this thing she has no name for... and she is, for the first time, relaxed and...

Well, not happy. She misses Adora, and she misses her Sword.

But she's *content,* and that's more than she usually is, so she sighs and leans back in the good warm water.

That's how things go for a week, and she can't... well, she can't say it's the worst experience of her life. She would even dare say that it is, perhaps, one of the *least* worst experiences of her life; she misses Adora so fiercely it's like a knife in her side, and she wants her fucking Sword back- it's *hers,* it chose *her* and she wants her damn Sword back!- but...

Well. She sleeps in a place Shadow Weaver cannot reach, she gets to have real food... she gets a bath... no, this...

This isn't so bad.

(Something inside her trembles, at this... safety, this place where, for all that she is contained and locked away, she is nonetheless full, and sleeping peacefully, and experiencing joys she has never had before. Trembling, as an idea begins to form- not ready to be born yet, but gestating in her mind.)

Perhaps that trembling is why, when Glimmer comes by to ask her for help- to ask that she assist in defending a village that Brightmoon's limited troops have effectively abandoned- Catra agrees.

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She goes with Glimmer and the dude with the bow, whose name is, as it turns out, Bow. Descriptive, Catra supposes- though she has little room to talk.

(She wondered who had named her. Was it Adora? Maybe Shadow Weaver- the dismissiveness of her own name, the simplicity of it, yes, that fits, if she really *is* one of the dark witch's experiments gone rogue than Catra strikes her as a name her maker would give her.)

They sneak out of the castle, because Glimmer's eyes are full of some distant fire, this idea that Catra will shift the War in their favor; the Sword in her hands, Catra almost debates just attacking the two and calling it a day, until Glimmer mentions that it'll prove to her mom that she's right.

" I'm right!" Glimmer insists, and Catra almost rolls her eyes until she follows it up with " and she'll know it when we save this village! I'll prove her wrong!"

Catra, remembering Glimmer before Angella- still seeing herself and Shadow Weaver in that interaction, as she cannot help but do so- is... caught, for a moment. If she betrays Glimmer right now, as she had planned to, then Angella will be right, and Glimmer, who was so brave before her, will be... diminished. Embarrassed and hurt, the way Catra so often is in front of Shadow Weaver, ashamed- because the worst hurt Shadow Weaver dealt her was not just with her magic, but with her words, with her relentlessly drilling into Catra's head that she is weak and worthless, that she is nothing before Adora, most favored child.

Catra finds she cannot bring herself to do that to Glimmer.

Oh, she won't help the Princess- a fucking Princess, holy shit. No, she's not going to help. She's a Hordesman still, after all, and their whole thing is that they hate Princesses. Catra's not soft and weak, she's not a traitor to the Horde, even as much as she doesn't really think the Horde is worth all that much. The Horde's full of lies and bullshit and nobody knows it better than Catra.

(The Horde's vaunted loyalty never saved her from Shadow Weaver, after all.)

But she decides *not* to betray Glimmer, too. She decides to... wait and see. Yeah. That's what she'll do. Wait and see. That's the *smart* thing to do. She's just being practical.

That's all.

(And yet, when Glimmer smiles at her when she marches alongside them, she feels that trembling inside again, something that is almost terrible in its sweetness.)

Glimmer talks the whole way, and wow, Catra would *not* share half the shit Glimmer's slinging, and definitely not with an enemy (because Catra is still a Hordesman and still Glimmer's enemy, or so she tells herself.)

Bow knows this and tries to pull her back, which earns him a bit of Catra's respect; but Glimmer can't stop herself, her whole life seems to fall out of her mouth. She talks, and talks of how no one respects her, of how her mom keeps holding her back, about how she'd win the whole goddamn War all by herself if someone would let her, but Silver's tits, no one *will!*

Catra gets that, she knows that, she understands; the Horde held her back, too. Lonnie and Rogelio and Kyle are part of her cadet class, but instead of celebrated family they are almost hated strangers; they have rejected Catra every time she has tried to become part of them. Only Adora is different. Only Adora...

(*Only Adora gives me a reason to stay,* Catra thinks, but then denies it, because that is a traitor's thought, and for all her disconnect with her own culture, she is just Hordesman enough to feel a little ashamed at that idea... but it does not stop her from thinking it.)

So when Glimmer says that Catra will defend the village and prove her detractors wrong... well, Catra doesn't have the heart to tell her otherwise, that she'll run back to ~~Adora~~ the Horde as soon as she can.

She'll just let the Princess believe it just a little bit longer.

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Horde troopers attack her, because of course they do; she's standing next to a Princess and an obviously armed Rebel archer. They run forward, and she starts swinging with the Sword, trying not to kill- Adora would never forgive her for it- but that's easy when even a blow with the flat of the blade hits like a truck. She breaks a few bones and Glimmer cheers, and so do the people in the village, and that- that feels-

Well, she doesn't have words for it, except *good*, and that feels a little simplistic for what is going through her heart.

(that trembling again, inside, and another taste, another little dip of her tongue into something terrible and sweet)

She goes She-Ra, to the sounds of more cheers- for her, cheers for *her*- and her throat closes up and she can't talk as she picks up a tank and tosses it aside like a broken toy. She's not dizzy, now, whatever issue had plagued her first transformation nowhere to be seen; she strides the battlefield as a giant, and the Horde flees before her.

Which is weird. Why is the Horde retreating so fast? Sure, Catra's dangerous, but surely she's not *that* dangerous.

Still, they run, and the people are cheering, cheering, *cheering,* for *her,* and when she turns back to face them, the cheering just gets louder.

It's... good.

But from behind her comes the one voice Catra has been waiting for.

" Catra?"

She turns, a smile lighting up her face entirely unconsciously, and there she is- Adora, it's Adora, Catra's only friend- but the smile dies as she sees Adora's face, conflicted, the way she is... keeping back. Protecting herself. *Reserved,* the way Adora has never been, not with *Catra.*

" What's wrong?" Catra asks, and Adora shakes her head.

" This isn't... this isn't a base," Adora muttered, shaking her head. " I ordered a retreat. This isn't- this was supposed to be a major Rebel outpost, guns, traps, but there's not... it's just people..."

" Uhh, yeah," Catra said. She took a step forward to Adora, but Adora took a step back, and that hit Catra in the heart so hard that the giant stopped where she stood, words faling out of her from the impact. " It's just a few homes and farms."

" Why... why are we attacking it?" Adora said, and there are *tears* in her eyes, tears which make Catra's own eyes prick- tears, in a Hordesman? " Is there- is there an army here? Does the Princess Alliance keep troops here?"

" No," Catra said. " There's nothing. The Alliance didn't even *have* any forces in the area. Glimmer only came here *because* it was being attacked."

“ To defend it?” Adora asked. “ From us.”

“ Duh,” Catra said. “ The Horde's a bunch of bad guys, Adora, I've always told you that.”

“ You have,” Adora responded, and her tone sounded so hopeless that Catra felt no pleasure, no vindictive joy at the obvious *I told you so* that she is now entitled to. “ You.. you always knew, didn't you?”

“ Yeah,” Catra said, because, well, she had.

“ Oh,” Adora said, then shook her head. “ No, no, I refuse!”

“ Refuse what?” Catra said.

“ This!” Adora shouted, spreading her hands out. “ We're not- the Horde *isn't* this! It's... there must have been a mistake. We did something *wrong.* There was a mistake... someone screwed up. Intelligence got it wrong. We're not supposed to be here.”

“ This is what the Horde does, Adora,” Catra snapped, annoyed that the old argument is starting up again. “ It conquers! Why does that surprise you? They straight up told us that the Horde was going to take over all Etheria, that was the whole *point!* The whole world in revolution, remember?!?”

“ You're wrong,” Adora spat. “ And you... what *happened* to you, Catra? You're fighting the Horde, you're a... a *Princess* now...”

“ They attacked me first!” Catra protested and goddammit, *no,* this feels like every discussion every argument every *fucking* time she had to defend herself for defending herself, nobody ever listens to her- except Adora, so she leans on that. “ Adora, you *know* me, I'm no traitor-”

“ But you *are* a Princess,” Adora said.

...Catra didn't have a good argument against that. She had a tiara and everything.

“ I'm still Horde,” Catra said, but Adora shook her head.

“ You're lying,” she accused. “ You're trying- it's like training, you're trying to trip me up. Confuse me. I... dammit, something is *wrong,* I have to go back and find out who ordered this attack.”

“ The Horde did!” Catra protested. “ That's what it does!”

“ Shut up!” Adora yelled back. “ You're wrong! We're the good guys! You've *always* been wrong, and you've *always* wanted to leave! You've *always* been a traitor!”

Traitor? She's not a traitor- but the words catch in her throat, to *immediately* assume she's betrayed them, to not even give her a chance- she's a Hordesman just like them, why don't they trust her? She's lived there her *whole life,* they *know* her, so why do they always... always assume the worst?

(*Why don't they love me?*)

Something very small breaks in Catra's heart- something like a hope, in Catra's heart, a hope of being loved, and accepted among her own people.

It hurts. It hurts. It hurts. And the worst part is, it's *Adora* saying that word to her, it's *Adora,* who alone of all the Horde Catra had hoped would... would believe her, *Adora,* who has kept her alive, and now throws her away...

She knows, before she does it, that what she's about to do is stupid, and mean. She knows that it's a really emotional situation and clearly Adora's already a mess from seeing firsthand what the Horde is, and she's always been such a golden child, of *course* Adora's *always* believed in the Horde, in all the shit the officers spout so the grunts will go die on Alliance spears for the cause. She knows this, she knows all this *so much* and it's not *fair* to Adora and Catra should be more rational about all this, calm down before she says something she shouldn't, not do what she is about to do.

But Catra, even knowing it's not the right thing, can't help herself, can't stop herself, she's *never* been able to do that- she cuts and

scratches when she's hurt, she fights back, it's all she's capable of, it's all the world has ever rewarded, that willingness to strike back because the world has been striking first against Catra all the days of her life.

So she does what she has always done.

(Later, she will wonder what might have been, had she not.)

" Maybe I am!" Catra screams back at her. " Maybe I *am* a traitor! It's not like the Horde ever gave me a damn thing!"

And that's the wrong thing to say, because no the Horde *hasn't* given her much but the Horde *did* give her *one* thing, one thing only, and that thing is *Adora* but Catra's just hurt her, Adora's eyes flash with pain and Catra wants to take it back but before she can, Adora flees, following her troops into the woods.

Glimmer makes it over at about that time, and so does Bow, and some part of Catra that is still a Hordesman knows shame at the tears in her eyes... so she hides them, and lets her rage take over.

So she's a traitor?

Fine.

She'll be the *best* fucking traitor anyone's ever seen. The Horde never gave her a damn thing, after all.

(Just Adora, and Catra's already pissed all over that herself.)

So she smiles, and celebrates with the townspeople, and there is more of this *food* thing, food that isn't ration bars and water, and Catra is discovering the magic of alcohol by the time Glimmer grabs her and starts the trip home, slower than the way they left; she ran out of juice to teleport, apparently, so they're just riding a skiff back, a trip that'll take two days. Catra's fine with that, because Catra has discovered that the more she drinks, the less she thinks about Adora, and the town is *full* of this wondrous concoction called "mead" that she downs heartily to the cheers of the people.

Catra is a bit sick the next day when she awakes at their makeshift camp, something called a "hangover"; she nearly murders Glimmer when the Princess greets her in her loud and cheerful way, but she misses with her claw swipe and instead just stumbles up and out of her tent, vomiting the whole way. The archer is the one that helps her with it, even as he quietly comments that Catra didn't really drink that much, not for as sick as she's gotten; when Catra accuses him of snooping, he protests that he was keeping watch on her, because she's a friend and that's what he does.

Catra finds that funny- she can't even remember the guy's name- but apparently he cares more for her than she cares for him; he cleans her up a bit, gives her water to wash the taste out of her mouth, and finally gives her something to let her sleep it off. When she lays down to sleep, she shivers a bit- this is farther north than the Horde, and the skiff is open-topped, letting the

wind rush down over her- and the archer has something for that, too: a cutesy little blanket, and even a small pillow, kept in a pack.

It's ridiculous and silly... but it's warm, and she takes it with only a little grumbling, snuggling in to sleep the rest of the trip away.

(And even under all her hurt, under *Adora,* some part of her is full of a good, warm feeling that almost cuts, so sharp is its edge inside her forever-unhappy heart.)

Adora doesn't know what to do. She *just* got promoted, and someone in intelligence fucked up, it's just a village. The Horde defends itself, grows its territory by taking in volunteers and those who hunger for freedom from Princess oppression, they don't... they don't burn down villages.

Right?

Shadow Weaver rolls her eyes at Adora, disappointed in her golden child for the first time in many years... but only a little disappointed, because she knows how to fix *this.*

She places hands, so cold, they have never been so cold when she touches Adora before, against Adora's temples and then

And then

And then and then and then and then

(everything into the dark)

****

The Queen's pissed as hell at Glimmer for the stunt, for the risk, is shouting at her in a language Catra doesn't even know; it sounds a lot like Perfect Speech, the Horde's official tongue, but not quite as musical, with fewer trills and more long vowel sounds.

Whatever it is, it's not Mountainflower, which is the only language Catra shares with the others; not the Horde's own tongue, but it's one that most people speak, so the Horde teaches it to all the cadets. Just in case they have to negotiate with outsiders.

Their foresight was paying off for her, now that Catra was considering turning her coat; or, at least, playing along. Without the hot fire of her confrontation with Adora, without all her relief running rancid at that look on Adora's face, without... well, all *that* mess, and thinking clearly after her little misadventure with Mr. Booze as her copilot, Catra realized that maybe she didn't *want* to be a traitor; no, that was the deepest and first sin, that was the *worst* thing a Hordesman could be. A traitor was lower than low, was...

Well, the best example Catra could think of was that, for all the curses and insults thrown at her in the Fright Zone, no one had ever called her a traitor before. Even with how much everyone hated her, *hated* her, still had no one accused her of betrayal. That was too far.

(But now *Adora* had called her traitor and Catra's heart *aches* and it *aches* and she *hurts*)

When the Queen is done screeching like a harpy, and Glimmer's done yelling back in those same delicate tones, it is the archer who speaks- at first in the same tongue, but then, after a glance at Catra, in Mountainflower.

" We should speak like this," the tech master says, " so Catra can follow along."

And that's a kindness, it is, since it lets Catra do something other than stand there and be bored... but not *much* more. There's a bit more yelling and a bit more arguing, but the gist of it is that Glimmer's in trouble and Catra... is only going to be watched?

Angella doesn't trust her- and honestly, that's fair, it even raises Catra's opinion of the woman a bit- but she agrees that, perhaps, they have been a bit... hasty. Catra will be allowed a small guest room and, so long as she has a guard with her, can go basically anywhere.

The tech master- whose name Catra hears the Queen say and commits to memory, *Bow*- finds the loophole immediately, and volunteers to be her guard.

" I'm a Rebel soldier, after all," he said, tapping his bow for effect. " I can keep an eye on her- and she'll be fine. I trust her."

He really, really shouldn't; but remembering his little blanket, and his assistance... well, Catra can't find it in her to be *too* angry. It's... useful.

(She almost says *nice* in her head, before she stops herself; no one has ever watched out for her before like this, save Adora...)

The next two weeks passes like that. Glimmer is in trouble, confined to her room- which strikes Catra as the most incredibly minor punishment imaginable, a thing she tells Glimmer with a smirk. Catra ends up in that room for most of those two weeks, mostly so she can annoy Glimmer, who is easy to rile up and kind of... fun... to be around. Bow is with them, and watching him try to keep everyone on an even keel is even funnier than bothering Glimmer, so Catra sets to it with a will.

Angella comes by, from time to time, or sends a runner to check on Glimmer; and that... that's odd, because Glimmer doesn't flinch the way Catra expects her to, when her mother comes by. Sometimes she acts surprised or caught out, but she never...

She doesn't quite react as strongly as Catra expects, and Angella's words- even as often as they devolve into more shouting matches

in that incomprehensible language, mostly at Glimmer's insistence- are... softer, than Catra expected.

It makes her wonder what's going on there, and the image of Shadow Weaver in an angel's costume begins to be... less certain, in her skull, even if she never much likes it when the Queen comes by to visit Glimmer in her isolation.

(Glimmer never notices how Catra draws closer to her when Angella comes by, as if *protecting* her from her mother; Bow does, but says nothing, aware he doesn't know enough to draw conclusions, not yet.)

It's not all chatting, though. Catra trains, too, every day, playing with her new powers- and oh, Hordak's teeth, *the power.* She's so fucking *strong* now! She was strong before, but this... oh, *this?*

No wonder Shadow Weaver was obsessed with power. Power is awesome! It feels *great!*

Catra trains, which is work, but oh, it feels like play; she dances with the Sword, letting it spin across her hands, changing back and forth and just straight-up experimenting with what she can do, taking joy in the power available to her now. She launches attacks that begin as her greater self and end with her turning small, using her off-hand claws as a weapon in conjunction with her blade, learning its range and her own reach in both forms, the ins and outs of her strangeness. She tests her strength until there is no more weight to lift, she is strong, strong, *strong!* Even Grizzlor, great and mighty Mane that he was, has never been as strong as Catra is, and in contests of speed, she's faster than

everyone but Glimmer, can outrun anyone who's not mounted or in a vehicle.

(The argument about whether teleporting counts takes two days and ends inconclusively; Catra chalks it up as a victory for her when Bow, forced to pick a side by the two feuding girls, equivocates before agreeing that teleporting "feels like it defeats the purpose of running?" which sends Glimmer off on a tangent.)

Speaking of mounts, during her fun, Catra makes a person, which is... well, certainly unexpected at best. She was just transforming and a horse was nearby, and halfway in, light shot out of the Sword and...

Well, he's something, he is. He talks constantly, is overly dramatic, and names himself Swift Wind midway through their first conversation. It's certainly better than his old name- apparently he was originally named Horsey, which strikes Catra as the laziest possible name for a horse.

(She is aware of the irony, given her own name, but it's not like she picked the damn thing herself.)

Still, Swift Wind can *fly,* and flying is fucking awesome, too- and it occurs to Catra she could just... leave, fly away, that they cannot stop her from doing so. She could escape, right now, run back to Adora...

But things are nice here in Brightmoon, she's having *fun,* here in Brightmoon, and... and Shadow Weaver is down there. Shadow Weaver, who some part of Catra fears will take the Sword away,

and give it to Adora- because, as Catra realizes all of a sudden, *this shouldn't be happening to her.*

She's not the right person for this. She's not supposed to get the Sword. Adora should have gotten it, she's the golden child, she's the best one, the special one; the Sword should be for her. Swift Wind should be for *her.*

So Catra stays, lands, comes back to Brightmoon, because here, there is no Adora to steal all that she has, and no Shadow Weaver to reinforce the world the way it *should* be.

And... and maybe she likes the food, and the bed.

(and the people? That's... maybe, but she puts it away. She's not a traitor... right?)

Bow helps, too, while he is not training himself, and sparring with him is... okay, Catra guesses. They're no gentler in Brightmoon sparring than in Horde sparring- beating the hell out of each other for practice kind of sucks no matter where you're at, apparently- but he's certainly more encouraging, and nobody gets mad at her when she wins. Glimmer cheers them both on and trains herself- it's the only reason she's allowed out of her room during her punishment- and Glimmer's fun to fight, too, though she takes losing hard. Catra's a sore loser, too, so she gets it, and the two start a competition that Catra wins, to her delight- she wins three matches to five, Glimmer's teleports and sheer willingness to fight dirty compensating for Catra's greater everything else. Glimmer's not as dirty of a fighter as Catra is, but she's trying, and Catra admires the effort, knows it from having been in the position of fighting a superior warrior herself.

(Catra is only *really* mad at her for the crotch punch- that had just been uncalled for.)

So when they're done, and Glimmer is swearing eternal vengeance, Catra holds out a hand and tells her she did alright; and that seems to work, it eases the tension, and Glimmer gladly takes the hand and swears she'll kick Catra's ass next time before asking her if she wants to head back to the room. Glimmer's not mad at her for winning and neither is Bow, nor are the other soldiers on the training field, some of whom were taking money from bets made- people who had bet on *Catra,* whom no one would have ever bet on in the Fright Zone.

It's nice, to be allowed to win, for once. To not have it taken away.

Catra recovers really fast from all the training. She thinks she's healing faster, and Bow tells her that all the stories of She-Ras talk of how they could not be kept down. She's picking some of that up, too, now, as her powers acclimatize to her body, and she's excited, wondering how mighty she will be when all this ends.

Many watch her, amazed at the warrior of legend now practicing, though none approach; order of General Juliet, according to Bow, Brightmoon's highest ranking officer, whom Bow points out to her one day. The scar-nosed warrior apparently doesn't trust Catra and keeps an eye on her whenever she can, with glares so strong that they actually compare favorably to some of Shadow Weaver's off-days, when she wasn't so bad; it's impressive work for a soft non-Hordesman like her. Juliet wants her forces kept separate from Catra as much as possible, so she can't use the awe her

power generates to subvert any of them- again, according to Bow, who admitted that he was guessing at her motives.

(Entirely accurately, as Catra would find out later; but that was Bow for you, the sharpshooter a heartseeker too, who read the souls of others as an open book.)

Given that Catra was debating betraying Brightmoon, that was just fair- so Catra goes out of her way to wave at her when she can, to the stone-faced woman's clear irritation. Catra can nearly hear the grinding teeth from a mile away, and it puts a big smile on her face, to act so friendly to someone who looks like she wants to pick Catra up and strangle her.

Thus pass some of Catra's first free days in Brightmoon- well, free *enough*, at any rate- and they are... nice. Good. The food continues to be things that *aren't* ration bars, the company's totally bearable- even Swift Wind is kind of fun, if in *super* small doses- the restrictions light...

She even gets a good bed. The bed she had was too soft, a thing she mentions as a joke when Angella comes by to Glimmer's one evening; she hadn't expected anything to come of it, was just poking fun at how damn *soft* everything is, here, it's like the mashed potatoes she gets served a few days in. Everything's just... soft.

But by the next day, a new, harder bed had replaced it, and Catra slept better.

It was a kindness, and Catra wasn't totally sure what to do with it, so she tried to put it out of mind.

(But it never quite left, this... gentle feeling, this sense of speaking, and being heard. This idea, alien and beautiful, that someone older than her actually *cared* what she said, cared to listen, a thing Catra has never had; it touches raw and bleeding parts of her soul, and she doesn't know what to do with this somehow-wonderful salt in her wounds, that stings with the clean, healing hurt of alcohol on infected wounds.)

The two weeks end when they are called before the Queen, who seems less... less *something* than she had been, seems a bit better to Catra's eyes. The Queen is sending them on a mission, which causes Glimmer to pump her fist; Catra is famous now, and another nation wishes to see the She-Ra.

Apparently when Catra, as She-Ra, defended that village, the news had spread fast- and to everywhere, apparently, since a lot of the townspeople had fled the town, despite its successful defense. They knew that only the appearance of a hero of legend had saved them, and like rational folk, had assumed that miracles were much like lightning, and did not strike twice.

So in fear of future attacks, they had taken the opportunity to pack up and flee- but they'd spread the tale as they went, of the woman who had kept them alive, of the team of three who had appeared and thrown back an army. Stories of a great swordswoman, a heroine who had appeared out of myth to save their lives... a She-Ra.

People had listened, which surprised Catra; Bow claimed that it was because people desperately needed hope, these days, and that's what Catra was- hope. They hoped that Catra could turn the long war around, and save them all.

Catra demurred, snorted when the idea was brought up... but later that night, she couldn't stop thinking about it. People she'd never met, thinking of her as some great hero...

But she wasn't a hero. Adora was the golden child, the great one. Catra was just... an accident. Unloved. Unwanted.

(Save by all these people. All these outsiders, whom she's never met, who nonetheless believe in her anyway... and that, too, is terrible and sweet in equal measure.)

Regardless of Catra's own thoughts, the story was still spreading, and information was drifting into Brightmoon Castle from Runestone Kingdoms and the Crownless both- that was a thing, apparently? Some political divide between those who had a Princess and a nice big shiny Runestone and the poor bastards who didn't. Kind of an east/west thing, apparently, Brightmoon was as far west as Runestone Kingdoms got save the Fright Zone, which had went under decades ago.

Hmm. Catra wasn't sure what it was all about, though it sounded important. Maybe the Horde hadn't taught them, though honestly the catgirl hadn't paid the most attention during conscription and education. Wasn't a point; good marks weren't rewarded, and she got punished whether the marks were bad or decent, so why put the effort in?

She'd still gotten the gist of it, which was this: there was the Horde, and then Everybody Else, whom the Horde would crush in time and bring into its benevolence. Adora had been *enthralled* with that idea, with that new horizon, when the Horde would rule all and peace would reign over Etheria... Catra had never entirely had the heart to break her of it.

Maybe she should have. Maybe then Adora wouldn't have been crying, after that village, maybe then Adora would have...

….Would have what? Catra wasn't sure what she wanted, all of a sudden, as she pondered the idea one night. She wasn't sure whether she wanted Adora to take her back to the Horde... or for Adora to come back with *her,* to this Castle, to Glimmer and Bow and all this good food and safety, and what the hell did *that* mean?

So Catra put that back into a box in her mind, and locked it, and threw away the key. She wasn't a traitor, no matter how the idea had struck like a bolt from the blue, no matter how much she wanted to be one in the wake of Adora's rejection and insults and accusation. She... she wasn't a traitor.

(*Is it betrayal if they betrayed you first? A cadet class is supposed to be a family, but you were never let in... Shadow Weaver hurt you and no one saved you, even though the Horde is all about loyalty... is it betrayal, if you are betrayed first?*)

She didn't have an answer, so she put the questions away.

(*Or do I have an answer, and I know what it is?* but no, that went back into the box, too.)

The Queen calls them to a conference soon, mostly to talk about the ripples Catra's presence is having. Phlax in particular wants to meet with her- they have a Church, apparently? Whatever that is. Something about a Good Woman. They want to meet her, though they're not ready to come over yet- this is just feelers, preliminary stuff.

Other places had sent queries to the Queen, too, asking what was going on, including one that Catra had actually heard of- Salineas.

(She'd heard because she paid attention to Horde sailors; Octavia was still pissed about Catra taking out her eye, and sailors on leave had tried to jump Catra more than once, hoping to bring a prize back to their boss.)

Catra's not sure what to do about all that, and neither is the Queen. But Glimmer has an idea, and given how well the last one worked, Catra's almost eager when the living glitterbomb suggests it- to head to Plumeria, and meet its Princess. Plumerians love the She-Ra, Glimmer claims, and they really need help!

That's true, but the Queen is the one who interrupts by pointing out that it's *dangerous,* too. Horrifically so. Plumeria was the most beleagured of all the former Princess Alliance nations, all its land more than half-conquered already, controlling so little of what had once been their own. Formerly a mighty merchant nation, Bow told Catra, who'd made their money by being the land route through which goods flowed from west to east, north to south, and vice versa, sitting in the continent's middle and thus able to

extract magnificent tolls from outsiders. It had been a big country, too, encompassing much of the Whispering Woods, which were- according to Bow- the largest geographical feature on Etheria other than the world ocean.

(*Nerd,* Glimmer had teased in a friendly way, and Catra had laughed, and been surprised by it, by how... how nice this was. It wasn't Adora, but it was... it was nice.)

But the Horde had eaten both of Plumeria's major ports, Rosewood and Glass Lake, early in the War, and consumed much other territory besides. Plumeria would have fallen already if it weren't for the Great Rebellion, a group that Catra finally got some explanation about- apparently it was made up of deserters from the Runestone Kingdoms, political anarchists, and others who had kept up the fight after the first Princess Alliance collapsed.

(*When my dad died,* Glimmer said, with an awkward shrug, eyes distant as if watching half-remembered things. *Like half of Brightmoon's army left when that happened, went down there to fight anyway...*)

The Rebels had taken over Plumerian territory to keep fighting, which was easy, because Plumeria had no ability to contest them, and the Horde had been surprised by the fierceness of the Rebel assault. The Great Rebellion had even reconquered Glass Lake, which was now the main Rebel port. The Rebels had held that territory for *years* now, doing more to defend Plumeria than its own Princess had. Their last Princess had been a total badass, but she'd been caught out and killed, and the current holder was apparently something of a pansy.

(Bow had cracked up when Catra made that comment, mostly at the pun- and then had to take five minutes to explain why it was

funny, since Catra had no idea what a pansy *was.*)

Catra actually knew that story, and out of a weird sense of... obligation, and trade, she told the story to them. They'd told her their own stories, after all; it felt... right to be the one to talk back. That was how duty worked, right? Reciprocation.

(At least, that was how it was supposed to work, even if the Horde had never worked like that for anyone in it, Catra least of all.)

So she told them how she'd heard the tale- it was one of the big ones in the Horde, one of the history lessons they made sure you learned. A story of the Horde triumphing against all odds.

For the last Plumerian Princess had come upon them clad in the body of a great botanical abomination, a hedgebeast like a vast lion, carried inside a rib cage made of oak and hickory and locust, a creature so vast it could bowl a tank over with a single lazy swipe of a claw. But the beast was not a threat just by its size and strength, but because every step it took turned the world itself against the Horde; everywhere she walked, the plants came, crushing vines and bursting spines and pollen so thick and choking that those who breathed it in were strangled by it, drowning to death on dry land. Few lived long enough to fight the great warplant she'd made, much less to make a dent in it.

So after retreating from her initial attacks, they'd come up with a plan. They'd sent a wave of soldiers at her, mostly made up of Hordesmen who were dying for one reason or another, those terminally ill or suffering crippling wounds or, very quietly, those who had lost all the other members of their cadet classes, those

who had given up hope of life but had strength and loyalty enough not to pull a Force Captain Tara and kill themselves like traitors.

This wave had not been intended to survive, and did not; but they sent valuable data back through their equipped optics, and they died with honor, loyal to the end.

The second wave, made up of a more normal Horde force, had orders to fight for a time, then fall back, to limit casualties as much as they could. The point wasn't to die fighting; the first wave had died to convince the Princess that this was a real fight, not the trick it was. They had done that, and so now death was to be avoided; they were to act as though orders had come through to make a fighting retreat in good order, giving up ground as the Princess continued on.

It was Vultak's plan, born of his study of Plumerian Princesses throughout history; a habit of overextending themselves and arrogance was noted, mostly because Plumerian Princesses really *were* that damn powerful, and he'd made his plans around that fact.

(Catra realized halfway through her retelling that the Horde's education did not say the Princess' name, and felt an odd moment of... sorrow. She was someone whom no one would remember the name of, either, when she died; a nobody, meaningless, just one of Shadow Weaver's experiments. For just a moment, Catra's heart ached for this nameless Princess as she recalled the tale... but she shrugged it off and kept going.)

So back, back, fighting harder as they got closer to the “camp”, which to all appearances was a normal Horde encampment. The Plumerian Princesses had always neglected the basics of warfare in favor of simply crushing invadies armies under the weight of their might; and so the Plumerian Princess had not scouted ahead, had not realized the *real* Horde base was considerably farther back.

No, she charged in, and that was when the fighting retreat turned to a “rout”, the Horde fleeing, running as fast as it could, and she had followed at her own lazy pace. She'd figured she was winning, and had no need to hurry. She had felt invincible in that moment, most assuredly.

But when the Horde's troops were clear, and she was in the middle of their abandoned base, Vultak sprang the trap. With the press of a button, the clever Force Captain detonated the massive numbers of explosives he'd ordered buried in the camp, and the nameless Princess ate the full force of the biggest blast Etheria had ever seen.

(“ Not the biggest,” Catra heard the Queen mutter, “ the Flame Kingdom was...” but then she trailed off and Catra just kept going.)

The Plumerian Princess had not died immediately, for Princesses were unnaturally tough- the alien nature of her endurance emphasized by her Horde educators, pointing out how *wrong* it was for any living being to be that goddamn durable, even with the armor of her great warplant all around her. It had been mostly vaporized, and she was clearly hurt, but she had not been dead immediately, had strength enough to keep fighting and killing- but

at a slower pace, a weaker pace, and eventually, by weight of numbers and clever plans, the Horde had overcome her.

Her death had been the end of Plumeria. The rest of the nation had no concept of how to fight, had never needed to do so for generations; the Horde had rolled right over them. Vultak had gotten a hell of a lot of respect for it, even from Hordak himself- especially when it was proven that Vultak had kept actual losses in the operation to less than half of what they'd expected to lose.

He'd done good.

(Maybe too good- hadn't he been sent to the siege in the south? Maybe Shadow Weaver had gotten nervous over her position... not that Catra knew what was going on in "the South", people said it like it was taboo to talk about. Some siege or another that never ended, so anyone posted there never came home.)

So that was that, basically, and when Catra trailed off- not used to telling stories, not sure how to end it- Glimmer had leapt up and said that was *exactly* why they should go. Plumeria needed help!

The Queen told them no.

They were on a skiff and out the door within a day.

(It is very, very difficult to lock up a teleporter.)

Origin Story (Heroes and Villains)

Chapter Notes

Considered title for this chapter: Rewards of the Just and the Unjust Alike

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Origin Story

(Heroes and Villains)

Catra is introduced to the Plumerians as a Princess herself- the Princess of Power. That makes her both want to laugh herself sick but also maybe just *be* sick, because a Princess is the *epitome* of what the Horde is *not,* the Horde is *not* the Princesses, it is for the common person and the common folk. Princesses, magical elitism, the glorious and few who get to lord over everyone else with gifts they didn't even have to earn, but were just handed by the unfair chaos of the cosmos.

...Bizarre, that Catra, who was never much of a Hordesman, finds so much of her former culture just... stuck, stuck to her insides, clinging like a parasite. Maybe it's because Adora called her *traitor* and some part of her is so...

(*hurt*)

Offended by that. Maybe she's channeling more of her natural Hordesman tendencies, or something...

Regardless, she stays quiet and does her best not to just do the first thing which comes to mind, which is to punch all these peaceniks in the face and steal their lunch money. Seriously, even with all their oohs and ahhs, and clear hero worship of her- which, okay, that was kinda nice- these people grated on her every nerve, including a few she didn't even know she *had.*

But she held back. She couldn't say why, except that Glimmer seemed to really, really, *really* want this to work, and the Queen would be pissed at Glimmer if she failed, and Glimmer is...

Well, she's tolerable, so Catra can't quite bring herself to fuck this up for Glimmer.

It's like the closest thing ever, though. At one point, Catra grinds her teeth so hard that she thinks she's about to turn into She-Ra without saying those stupid words, ascending out of sheer frustrated rage.

(But when they show her the art, tell the story- she is meant to save them all, they say, with love in their eyes- something in Catra trembles.)

That's probably why, when the Horde attacks- and oh thank fuck, Adora's not with this group, it's just Grizzlor, who Catra barely knows- Catra doesn't bother trying to come back to them, or working out her other, more complicated feelings.

No, Catra just says the dumb words and starts beating their asses stupid.

(And maybe she turns the blade, a few times. Maybe she strikes with the flat and not the edge, shows mercy that no one would have expected back in the Fright Zone... maybe she wounds, but does not kill, her former countrymen- *former?* No, no, no, that thought goes back in the box.)

But halfway in, she catches sight of the Plumerians, who are just staring at her with those wide eyes and adoring faces and *god dammit,* Catra has fought her entire *life* for everything she *has,* had to claw out of the world every gift she's ever gotten but this fucking Sword, and... and they just look at her like she's a *hero* and she knows she's *not,* and something half contempt and half desperate plea pours out of her mouth.

" Fight, goddamn you!" Catra bellows at them, as she hurls a Hordesman into others. " Fight!"

" But that's what you're doing!" their Princess says, flowers in her hair. " Fighting! For us!"

" And what happens when I'm gone?!?" Catra yells, all her frustrations boiling out of her at once, because don't they get it? These people, who look at her; don't they know she'll let them down? She *always* fails at anything she tries, she can barely get anywhere with all her desperate efforts, don't they know how cruel the world is? " What if I die?!? What if I'm just fucking

busy?!? If you won't fight, how can you expect to get anywhere?!?”

“ Yeah!” Glimmer says, pumping her fist in the air. “ Fight, Perfuma! You're a Princess, we're made for battle!”

“ Even before I was a Princess, I fought!” Catra hotly insisted, as she blocked with her Sword an attack that would have hit one of the Plumerians. She knew how to manipulate people, and really, wasn't that all this was? She was trying to... to get them to fight, she supposed, to stand up, and inspiring was just manipulating someone in a good way, right? Her mind raced and she settled on her next words. “ If I could do it, so can any of you! Fight, goddamn you!”

“ She's right!” Bow yelled as his shot took out a trooper behind Glimmer, the arrow going right through the guy's chest armor. “ I'm no Princess, but I'm here, fighting!”

“ Fuck yeah he is!” Glimmer cheers again, uppercutting a woman so hard that she literally knocked her out of her boots- damn, Catra was holding back, but the other two sure weren't.

Still, with the roar of adrenaline in her veins, it's hard to focus on that, and easy to look at all these Plumerians who look at her and- and *love* her, and if they don't fight they'll get *hurt* the world will eat them alive...

“ Come on!” Catra exhorts, one last time. “ Don't you want to fight alongside the She-Ra?”

And that was it, as she'd hoped it would be; leaning on their semi-worship of her is enough, it is just enough, and suddenly the world itself rises up to help them. Vines and plants and flowers, the rage of the green against the red meat of animals; the Plumerians rush to join their Princess.

“ For the She-Ra!” they yell- and that means they are rushing to join Catra, too, and her hands are too clumsy to hold all of what that means, so she keeps them turned towards violence and does not try to catch the hot dollop of something burning and bright as molten steel in her heart.

The Plumerian Princess is terrifying, and while the Plumerians are an uncoordinated mob that has no merits but size and enthusiasm, they *do* have the Princess of Power, alongside Bow and Glimmer, to lead them. It is enough to chase the Horde back to their camp and burn it to the ground, Grizzlor fleeing with his forces.

“ Loot it as you go,” Catra suggests to the Plumerian Princess in the aftermath. “ You guys need weapons.”

“ And training,” Bow suggests quietly, but respectfully.

“ And experience!” Glimmer suggests rather more rudely. “ You guys throw punches like you don't know how!”

“ We don't!” the Plumerian Princess says brightly and perkily, and there's a splash of blood red as roses on her cheek from some unfortunate savaged by her thorns, and her face is *alight* and *alive* with a beautiful, if dazed, smile, almost punch-drunk (albeit Catra can't see a wound on the girl.) “ Is... is it always that good?”

“ What, fighting?” Catra asks.

“ Yes,” Perfuma nods. “ That... oh, that was fun! If Plumeria rejoins the Alliance... can I hit more Horde soldiers with flowers? That was... wonderful.”

Oh hell, Catra's created a monster.

“ Sure!” Glimmer says, just smiling as Catra- and Bow, she notes a moment later- quietly take a step back. Either Glimmer didn't see the obvious warning signs... or her natural bloodthirst meant she just thought it was awesome.

“ Glimmer can probably get somebody in Brightmoon to train your people,” Bow says, focusing on the practical matters.

“ Yeah,” Catra snarks to the archer at her side. “ Not like General Juliet has anything better to do than glare at me.”

“ Mom'll work out all the details!” Glimmer responds cheerfully. “ I'm no good with that kind of stuff. But welcome aboard, Perfuma!”

Perfuma- Catra keeps the name in her head. She's one to watch; Catra had meant too many people who had pleasant facades and ugly undersides before. She didn't trust this plant-wielder as far as she could throw her skinny ass- well, all things considered, that was probably quite a distance in She-Ra form, but the point still stood.

“ I'm glad to *be* aboard!” Perfuma said, clapping her hands. “ Oh, we're going to be such good friends!”

Fuck no we aren't, Catra swore to herself. *My only friend's Adora, and she's a lot less scary than you are, lady.*

Still, for all that Catra is now worried that she will someday be eaten by a rhododendron, the praise and joy of the people is terribly sweet to her ears, and she ends the night a celebrated hero.

The only damper on it was a nagging thought in the back of her head: *where is Adora?*

Catra hoped she was alright.

****

Adora understands, now.

She'd been wrong. There had been a military installation, not a village, there.

(why does her head hurt so much)

She'd been fooled. Tricked.

(dark fingers at her temples)

And... Catra, Catra, she'd... *hurt* her, with her last words, she'd seen it on her face, because she was the one person Catra showed that face too, told her worries and her doubts, her fears...

(no darkness here, to snuff out the bright memory; Shadow Weaver cannot take what she does not know exists, and so has not touched the greatest treasure of Adora's heart.)

How could she have been so cruel?

...The light, the pressure of thinking of Catra, it seems to burn away the dark inside her head, it seems to... warm her, melt the

ice... her mind feels frozen into patterns of thought, but thoughts of *her* warm the nerves again.

Catra. Her friend. Her... her something *else,* something she only ever looks at sideways, this thing she is afraid to touch. They both have it and they both *know* they have it and they both know to keep it secret, because that is how they keep it safe; pure instinct has taught them to keep it from Shadow Weaver, this thing they have, born of needing each other for so very, very long, and being denied that time and time again. It's not... it's not sisterly, which it should be, right? Raised by the same commanding officer, after all. Cadet classes are meant to be a kind of family, everyone in the Horde agrees on that.

And yet... yet something is *broken* within her cadet class, has been broken all of Adora's life. There's distance with Catra even as she's one of them, and Adora's separate, too, placed above and not below but still placed *separate,* and it affected the others, too, Kyle and Rogelio have something between them that most cadets don't have within their own class and Lonnie's never entirely been a friend to Adora and was *never* a friend to Catra...

And then there's this... this want, this desire, born of not having Catra in her life enough, this endless *wanting,* because Shadow Weaver keeps them apart whenever she can.

But she has built her life on Catra, on knowing that Catra would be there. They've skipped all the in-betweens; they don't have the big questions, anymore. They *know* the answer to the question "who is your most important person." It's settled, its over with, it's *done.*

Without Catra... life is worth less than it had been. She needs her back.

...She feels defenseless without her. She *is* defenseless without her, she has no one else she can trust, trust to talk about this with. The others in her cadet class are friends, but she doesn't trust them to defy Shadow Weaver for her; if she speaks of the spell she was put under, one of them will talk.

So she pretends she is still under the spell, spends two days terrified out of her wits, because Adora has never lied before for her own sake- only for Catra's- and it is uncomfortable, it is awful, this first experience with lying.

But it works, and for two days, as she acts like the perfect Force Captain, no one suspects a thing.

She gets orders soon- to attack Salineas.

****

Salineas is next on the list, because they've always been friends with Brightmoon, and so they want to meet Catra now. They are sent to be picked up by a sea captain, supposedly close with the

Princess- though Catra doesn't like how the diplomat giggles when he says that.

They go to Crystal Falls, which is Brightmoon's biggest city, and it's just... wow, this place is busy. They're preparing for a siege; it hasn't happened yet, but the city, built in concentric rings, is getting ready for it. Horde forces are apparently on the march to besiege the place.

But at the docks, Catra is greeted with two things. The first is the boat captain, who is an idiot, and Catra almost kills him on reflex when he comes too close. She desperately wishes to go back home in his presence, because someone like Sea Hawk would have been shot after the first sea shanty back in the Fright Zone, and Catra suddenly realizes a major flaw in Brightmoon: it *doesn't* shoot people like Sea Hawk on sight.

There's also the matter of all the *water.* Staring out at the infinite blue from the docks, Catra's mouth drops open. Oh wow, Catra hates this... this whole thing! In the Fright Zone, she never saw large areas of water that weren't part of the sewer system, which she'd hated for being, well, full of shit; but this...

It's huge. It's fucking... it eats up the horizon, it's as big as the fucking *sky.* Holy shit.

" The fuck is this?" Catra asks the group as they stand at the docks of Crystal Falls, staring at the saltwater that just *goes on forever.*

“ The beautiful seeeeaaaa~” Sea Hawk begins, and it is only the fact that he immediately springs onto the mast of a ship that prevents Catra from landing the haymaker she throws at him. “ We've miles to cross to get to Salineas!”

“ No,” Catra protests.

But yes, actually, as it turns out; Catra's on the boat, mostly because Glimmer- and to a lesser extent Bow- beg her to agree, which is just barely enough to convince her to get on the boat instead of immediately betraying the Princess Alliance, setting Crystal Falls aflame, and escaping.

This proves a horrible decision, because she spends the first day of the trip sick, which alleviates itself in time to hear some info. The seas belong to the Horde, apparently; they're about to attack the Sea Gate, which is Salineas' main defense.

(*The nation or the capital?* Catra catches Bow asking in-between vomit sessions; *the capital,* she hears Sea Hawk respond before she starts puking again. Glimmer assists, holding her hair back, and offering a handkerchief to wipe her mouth, which Catra takes gratefully. Glimmer's alright, in her book.)

Eventually she recovers from “sea sickness”, but she is still sick to death of water by the time they reach Salienas; she's mostly relieved when she gets a chance to murder a sea monster with her bare claws- well, bare claws *and* the Sword, but the Sword doesn't feel like equipment. It just feels like it's part of her.

They meet the Princess, and Mermista she likes immediately. She's as irritated to be here as Catra is, and Catra doesn't have to fake much enthusiasm at their meeting, bonding almost instantly with the disgruntled mermaid over both shared disdain of Sea Hawk- though Mermista's is tinged with something else that Catra's not interested in examining right now- and general snarky personalities. She controls water, which Catra hates, but Mermista uses it to save her from some splashing at one point, and her opinion of the woman improves.

Really, the Princess would do well with the Horde! She's got the right attitude. Mermista doesn't fit in with the pretty little princesses, with this Alliance idea. She's as different from Perfuma as... as Catra is.

But Perfuma's bloodthirsty, Catra reminds herself as she has the thought, remembering that last conversation with the Plumerian, that spot of blood on her cheek, never wiped away. *And Glimmer's a Princess, too, and she's tough as shit...*

Maybe Catra has the wrong idea about Princesses.

(*Maybe I could be a Princess* but that thought goes away quick, even as it fills her with something sugary and awful as arsenic, something wonderful and poisonous both.)

She meets Adora again when she brings the boat to fight, alongside a scorpion woman whom she doesn't get to deal with much. Adora, who seems to be trying to... get them away from the others? Lonnie and Kyle and Rogelio are here, too, though Bow handles pretty much all of them, damn, the archer's

competent- and Mermista's just overkill. Adora only brought one ship... why? A fleet would be needed...

But events at the Sea Gate happen *really* fast and Adora ends up retreating, and Catra never gets a chance to talk with Adora, to figure out what was going on there.

Still, she's sure Adora's okay. She's the golden child.

What could possibly go wrong in *her* life?

****

Adora's failures at the Gate lead Shadow Weaver to berate her- and that feels wrong, all over again, she's getting the back of Shadow Weaver's hand and not the gentle touch, now.

This is what Catra was raised under...

She is no golden child any longer, her image tarnished now; she is lessened, the idol of her existence melting, she is... less.

Without Catra, she is so much less.

Thankfully, Shadow Weaver spares her more dark touches at her forehead- even muttering that *magic is wasted on you*, to Adora's hopefully-hidden relief.

But even as Adora flees Shadow Weaver's office, to go shake and shiver in the locker room in privacy, she is *not* spared her own thoughts. She has this growing sense of... *horror,* as she realizes exactly what she *is.* The Horde spoke of heroic revolutionaries standing against abomination; but... Adora's not that, is she?

No, Adora was at the Gate to attack a nation that was just trying to repair itself, that the Horde had *already* kicked around the Sea of Sighs like a football. And the village she'd been ordered to take... just an innocent village. Not a military installation.

The Horde... the Horde is *evil,* and that means Adora herself is...

Evil.

Doesn't it?

But even if that's true, what's she supposed to do?

No answers come to her, and she sleeps fitfully.

(And in the morning, Shadow Weaver orders her to annihilate the village.)

****

Salineas decides to rejoin the Alliance- and part of the deal is that Catra must stay and help. Salineas' navy has been pushed back, *hard,* and they've requested the help of the She-Ra to deal with all that's going on, at least for a little while.

Queen Angella's response is that *the She-Ra has proven herself; she can go where she pleases.*

(Catra tries to stop the warm feeling inside at those words.)

Bow and Glimmer are staying, too, despite orders to return home.

" I can't just abandon you!" Glimmer says. " All by yourself in a new country- yeah, that would suck! You need your friends with you!"

" We're friends?" Catra snarks.

“ Of course we are, you big dummy!” Glimmer says, and smacks at her; Catra dodges, and Glimmer falls over. “ I mean, I have to go back to recharge every now and then, but I can slip in and out, no problem. The Best Friend Squad stays together!”

“ We need to get you like, a travel battery,” Bow opines as Catra quirks an eyebrow at that name.

“ We are *not* the Best Friend Squad.”

“ Of course we are,” Glimmer says, turning around to Bow and hearing none of Catra's complaints. “ But hey, I've got a few teleports in me yet! Let's get rolling!”

“ Aren't you a commander?” Catra asks; she'd heard that in Brightmoon. “ Won't you get... you know. Court martialed?”

“ I'm not a *real* commander!” Glimmer explained via whining. “ I don't even have any troops! I'm a *Commander* because Mom forgot to change the old law about a Queen's daughter getting a military rank! SSide note, thank you for finding that for me, Bow.”

He shrugs.

“ Eh,” he says. “ You really wanted to help the Rebellion, and... well, my dads don't approve of what I'm doing either. And you're a friend!”

Glimmer smiles, and Catra wonders if there's something maybe under that smile, something she can see a little bit at the sides of Glimmer's grin; an eagerness, a care for Bow's opinion that goes a bit... further.

(*Like me and Adora,* she thinks, and the part of her that has come to see Glimmer as a friend gets a bit stronger. *She's a lot like me; got one friend in the world and she loves them.*)

" Well, I won't turn down the help," Catra says, throwing an arm over Glimmer- before transitioning into a headlock. " If you guys want to be my human shields, go for it."

" Hey!" Glimmer complains as she tries to break out of the headlock. " You're invincible, why would you need us to take a bullet for you?"

" Because I think it's funny!" Catra says, giving her a noogie, and the two wrestle like big dumb kids for a minute before they are interrupted by Sea Hawk and Mermista.

" So..." Mermista says. " I've got a mission for you guys. I've been studying the Logbook, and I think I've got an idea... here's hoping my forebears were as smart as everybody thinks they were."

" We'll be joining you as well!" Sea Hawk said. " Striking at vulnerable targets- supply depots, that kind of thing. We'll cut the Horde navy off at the knees!"

" Best Friend Squad, ready to serve!" Glimmer announces as she hops up.

" Best Friend Squad Plus!" Sea Hawk announces cheerfully.

" No," Mermista and Catra say in unison before sharing a look.

(And that is how Catra became friends with the water witch.)

****

Shadow Weaver has made it clear to her: no more failures.

I would tolerate them from someone less qualified, the witch had sneered, *but not from you.* Adora's status as the best cadet in her generation is no longer a throne, but a trap... or maybe it was always a trap, and she has only just now realized it.

Was this why Catra always slacked off? Did she know that being the best was no reward? She always tried to tell me the Horde was evil...

That thought makes something ugly settle in the pit of Adora's stomach, but she simply salutes and says nothing else. Adora does not know how to say no, has never learned how to do anything *but* live up to the expectations of superiors, has no guide for this in her life. Catra alone was the thing Adora had strength to disobey for... and Catra is not here.

So with an army behind her, Adora goes out to that first village, her first failure. The place where the She-Ra came back into being, where the Horde's endless rolling tide of successes was- momentarily- halted.

For that insult, it must pay. Adora's orders are clear, and Shadow Weaver made them *very* specific: she must burn it to the ground. No survivors.

She'd emphasized that last point.

(Unbeknownst to Adora, a change in Hordak's orders; he wanted the village burned, but had said nothing about survivors. That was *Shadow Weaver's* idea, a test to see if Adora was still under her control or not.)

Adora's return proves a few things- that she was right, that no matter how Shadow Weaver tried to mess with her mind, she'd been right at the first. It's a peaceful farming village, nothing more. Shadow Weaver's gaslighting was just that, gaslighting- lies.

Not that it matters. Adora's orders remain the same; she must wipe it off the map.

As she stares at it, that ugly thing in the pit of her stomach boils over, and she wants to puke.

...What is she doing with her life? The Horde kills. The Horde conquers. The Horde *knew* this was a peaceful village, and still they attacked; there was no mistake in intelligence. This is just... what they do.

Catra was right.

The Horde's the bad guy.

Adora is the bad guy.

...

Oh.

(Something very small in her heart breaks.)

She is expected to follow orders. She is expected to *give* orders; her troops are behind her. If she falters, they will kill her; that's

why the others aren't here. Lonnie, Rogelio, Kyle, none of them are present; unusual, to send someone out without their cadet class, almost unheard-of, but Shadow Weaver probably gave this army orders to follow of her own. If Adora relents, she'll be killed...

Not that she can. Some part of Adora cannot *imagine* saying no, defying orders, even in the face of all this. She has never done so in all her life, save for Catra. Without Catra here to show her the way, to give her a *reason,* she defaults to what she is, and what she *is* consists of being a good little Horde soldier...

So now, when it matters, she stumbles, cannot think of what to say, some clever method that would *technically* fulfill her orders without killing all these people, or just engage in outright defiance. She doesn't have the tools she needs; no, she's further back than that, she doesn't have the tools she needs to *build* the tools that would give her those options. She is less than a beginner, she is bereft of even the basics of rebellion, has nothing firm to build on.

She only ever had the strength to defy orders- to defy expectation- to defy what others want of her, and do what *she herself* wants, when it came to Catra, and *Catra is not here.*

...She was not wrong; she is less, without Catra.

Catra, who had always known, whose teasing had disguised deeper truths. Adora had been blind, thought she was part of an honorable nation, and she'd thought Catra too cynical- but she'd

had the right of it, hadn't she? Adora's whole life is a lie, and Catra had told her so, time and time again.

Add onto it Shadow Weaver's manipulations.... can Adora trust *anything* she remembers? Anything she thinks she knows? Can she trust her own mind?

No, no, the only thing she could ever trust was *Catra,* and she's *gone...*

Gone to be a hero, her brain supplies. *To join the forces of good. The way that you serve evil... Catra always knew what the Horde was. Did she always know what* ***you*** *were, too?*

Is that why she left you?

Her eyes tremble with tears as she realizes what she is going to do.

She is going to order this village destroyed, and everyone in it killed.

Maybe it would be easier if it was simply a case of trying to stay alive- and that part's not wrong. If she wishes to stay alive as she is, if she doesn't want to be a dead body in a ditch or- somehow worse- to feel cold fingers at her temples, changing who she is, if she does not want to be made a slave of Shadow Weaver... then

she must not fail. She must bring a victory back home, even one as ugly and pointless as this one. The path of failure is the path of a corpse, either for real or in the sense of the walking dead, because whatever is *Adora* will be alive only under Shadow Weaver's control.

She could... she could run. She could flee. Just escape. Steal a skiff, maybe- it was a skiff that started all this, after all. Maybe if she'd been the one to fall off instead of Catra...

...But no, no, the Sword would never have accepted her. She's evil, after all. Catra's good, that's why the Sword took her. Maybe the Sword had known she'd fall there, someday, and had just been... waiting.

What is she supposed to do? She can't oppose Shadow Weaver on this; Hordak would not back her. The Horde's lone spellcaster is more valuable than Adora has ever been, more valuable than *anyone;* that's why rumors spread for so many years of Shadow Weaver killing those Hordesman who threatened her position... or who just drew her eye. Hordak allowing her sadism and cruelty due to the demon named necessity.

Adora can barely trust her own mind... she can trust that Shadow Weaver can manipulate her mind. Shadow Weaver wouldn't want her thinking about that if it was true, so that was... that was true.

Other thoughts, with the flicker of *rage* behind them, which was not cold and dark but hot and bright... yes, she could trust those.

...How blind and how stupid has she been? Did she think Shadow Weaver's favor *protected* her? Shadow Weaver has never protected anything in her life, especially not from herself. And her fellow cadets- they're friends, but they never really congealed the way other cadet classes do, there is something fundamentally *broken* in their family.

No, Adora could only ever truly trust Catra... she needs her back.

Once she gets her back, she'll figure out... something. Maybe Catra being She-Ra means she can fight Shadow Weaver...

But to get Catra back, she needs the Horde. The Alliance has Catra, after all, and Adora... Adora refuses to believe that she's there of her own free will. Catra... Catra is her... her something, that thing they've never named.

Catra felt it too, right? She... she felt for Adora the way Adora felt for her, surely.

(*Please,* Adora prayed- to whom, she did not know. Perhaps anyone, any*thing,* that was listening.)

Or maybe Catra didn't? Catra is She-Ra now, and when did that happen? *How* could that happen? Catra had been obsessed with that damn sword since she touched it... did she know, somehow? Had Catra known it was there, was she using Adora too? Shadow Weaver used Adora and maybe Catra was, too, used Adora as just

somebody to keep Shadow Weaver off her back, a shield for just long enough for her to get to the sword...

No, no, no. She has to trust. She'll... she'll lose everything if she doesn't *trust*.

Adora is, for the first time in her life, alone, and scared, and there is no way out but through. She must go forward. She needs the Horde to get Catra back, and... and she cannot quite stomach the idea of leaving, even knowing what they are. The Horde *are* her people, after all, and what is she to do? To go from Force Captain to... to some nobody, on the other side, just another person, a peasant serving the Princesses...

She's not a Princess. She'll never *be* a Princess. She's nothing unique or special. Just a human grunt, like so many. She has no unique powers or special abilities... if she goes to the Alliance, what would she be worth?

...No, she's meant for more, she can *be* more. Her whole *life* has been preparing her to be *more!*

...A life Shadow Weaver led her to...

...She doesn't know what to trust. She doesn't know what to do.

She knows only this:

It is evil, what she is doing.

Scared, alone, lost... Adora says the words that will haunt her for the rest of her life.

" Burn it to the ground," she orders.

And as she orders, so is it done.

(Damnation can be so simple.)

When she gets home, feeling cold and numb and empty, head full of screams, Shadow Weaver compliments her. She accepts it with the accidental grace of one moving on autopilot.

She goes to her bed, and she cries until sleep claims her.

(*Catra, please, be ok, please save me*)

****

They're about a week into their five-man assault on what appears to be the entire Horde navy... which is going far better than it

should. This would take a platoon or even a brigade of Horde soldiers to pull off, but apparently it only takes three Princesses, a tech master, and a pyromaniac captain to equal a small army.

(Catra does not notice how it has become easier to think of herself as a Princess, does not notice how that trembling thing inside grows.)

They're getting it done faster, too, because moving their small squad is easy compared to moving all those troops; Mermista's powers assist, as does the fact that Sea Hawk overclocks the engines on every boat he drives. He figures it's fine, since he's going to wreck the boat soon enough, so it doesn't matter how much wear and tear the engine suffers first- which, fair, Sea Hawk has wrecked every boat he's gotten on a Horde destroyer after setting it ablaze, a bizarre strategy that nonetheless keeps working for him.

Kind of ironic for a sailor to be a pyromaniac, Bow commented once during the last week, which Catra had to agree with (once Bow explained what a pyromaniac was). Mermista seems to alternate between finding it charming and finding it enraging, which is kinda funny, and normally Catra would tease- but Mermista gave her pills that keep her seasickness down, so Catra keeps it to a minimum. Mermista's kinda fun, anyway, salty and snarky, and Catra likes her tremendously.

(The pills, admittedly, help- Catra does *not* miss puking.)

They're currently parked on a beach, with a campfire going, fish roasting- and oh, *fish,* Catra loves the taste, and Mermista's promised her some *real* Salinean cuisine when she goes back- *No wonder the Horde was always terrified of Princesses,* Catra thinks as she sits a bit away from the group. The island they're on is a

bit away from a Horde resupply dump that no longer exists; Sea Hawk set the fuel canisters ablaze and the entire place went up like beautiful fireworks. They escaped on a boat Sea Hawk is calling the Dragon's Daughter... X? She thinks it's ten, they're up there.

Catra's sitting a bit away because Glimmer's gotten into a habit of needling her about Adora and she hates it, so she sits away from them; not that it helps, because Glimmer saunters over anyway.

" Umm, Catra?" Glimmer asks, kind of quietly. She's speaking Orgel; Bow and Glimmer are teaching it to Catra, and while she doesn't reciprocate- she doesn't have the patience to teach anybody anything, much less an entire fucking language- it doesn't seem to stop them, and she's getting a pretty good handle on the language. " Are you... mad at me?"

" What gave you that idea?" Catra growls back- in Mountainflower, since she's better at it- holding onto the Sword like a security blanket.

" Because you're... mad at me?" Glimmer finishes lamely. " Umm... why are you so touchy about that Horde soldier anyway?"

" Because she's my only friend!" Catra snaps at Glimmer.

" Only friend?" Glimmer asks.

“ Yes,” Catra replies, sighing. She shouldn't have said that; she's admitted a weakness to an enemy, but her frustration with Glimmer and anger over the situation with Adora have boiled over. She pauses in her rage, stills herself, waits some snide or cruel comment that she is already preparing a retort for.

But Glimmer instead sighs.

“ Hey, I'm... I'm sorry, okay? I didn't know,” Glimmer says. “ I get it, you know? Bow's my only friend too. Or was, until you.”

“ I'm not your friend,” Catra replies, less heated than she'd expected to be. Glimmer's too... *sad,* and... empathetic, or something. It makes her feel bad to yell at her.

“ Yes you are,” Glimmer protests casually, moving on and paying it no attention, even as Catra could not help but fixate on it. “ So I guess we've only got Bow and each other- and you've got Adora. No *wonder* you looked like that... hey, I'm sorry to be a dick about it. I'll quit.”

No one has ever been sorry to Catra for anything they've ever done to her before, except Adora, and she has never been forgiven anyone anything... except, again, Adora, but that statement is true for so many things that Catra shouldn't even bother adding it anymore.

(Adora is always the exception.)

So she doesn't know how to forgive either, how to let others be forgiven, and so just awkwardly shrugs.

" It's... it's fine," she says.

" It's not," Glimmer says. " Hey, let me fight her next time, okay? Or Bow? You shouldn't have to fight your friend. And we'll- we'll capture her! Take her to Brightmoon! That way you guys can be friends again!"

The idea is... attractive, as Catra sits there, on the beach, with the campfire behind her. Sea Hawk is saying something and Mermista's trying not to laugh and Bow's just blushing because he has a bit of a crush on the older captain, and...

And it's nice, it really is.

" I'd like that," Catra says, and Glimmer punches her gently in the shoulder.

" Then you get it," Glimmer said. " That's what friends do!"

Catra says nothing, just heads back to the fire as Mermista waves a finished stick at her.

" Fish's done," Mermista announces in Skimmer, a language Catra is *also* picking up, and as Catra munches on the offered stick, she thinks to herself *this is alright, this is okay.*

I could live like this.

****

They spend two months helping Salineas- the Queen apparently mollified by communications from Salineas that her daughter is alive, at least as far as Catra knows- before returning, Glimmer all bright eyes and daring smiles, Catra dreading the return, dreading the Queen yelling at Glimmer.

But the Queen does not yell- or, at least, it is not the first thing she does. She runs over and... and *hugs* Glimmer, first, and Catra is more taken aback by that than she would be if the Queen had walked up and laid her daughter out with a punch.

But no, the Queen *hugs* Glimmer, and gives thanks that her child is safe, and Glimmer's protests of annoyance strike Catra as vilest heresy, because how could *anyone* protest *that?* Catra just stares for a minute as Angella goes from this... this *something* that grabs at a part of Catra's heart and just *squeezes* it, makes something hurt in her chest with that look of worried oh-thank-fuck-you're-

alright, this look that says she would trade all she had to make sure her daughter was safe.

Catra keeps staring as the Queen switches to the more-expected yelling, promising to ground Glimmer forever- a promise she can't keep and that everyone *knows* she can't keep, because no force on Etheria save death can stop a teleporter on a mission- seeing not Shadow Weaver in an angel's costume, but... something else, something she has no words for. She can hear it, this thing she does not know, hear it in the *absence* of what she expects. She expected spite and contempt, which slither through all Shadow Weaver's words, but the Queen has something else in her voice, something...

Better.

Catra wants it, even as she does not know its name; something in her keens from want of this nameless, beautiful thing.

(She cannot name what she has never known; but as a body can starve for an unknown nutrient, so too can a soul...)

Bow is the one who defuses the situation, with Catra too stunned and Glimmer too used to falling into a rut when it comes to arguing with her mother. Bow is the one who convinces the Queen- *Angella* to listen, to let them try again- they are two for two, after all. Two Princesses, back in the Alliance.

Catra defuses herself that night, in her room- and it's *still* bizarre to have a *room*, all to herself, they were so *wasteful* in

Brightmoon, not housing cadets twenty to a space- laying awake in bed. Angella's concern for her daughter... it has to be fake. Or Catra saw something that wasn't really there. She knew what the Queen *really* felt for Glimmer, right? She'd seen her yell at her often enough.

...What she's looking for isn't real, it isn't *there.*

(She has to believe that. If what she wants doesn't exist, if it's just a fantasy she made up, then her lack of it doesn't hrut as much.)

The next mission is to continue doing more of the same- recruiting more Princesses back to the old Alliance. Mermista is apparently doing well down south without the Best Friend Squad- though they'll need to hop back down there soon, the assistance to Salineas is apparently going to be a kind of on-going thing over the next year as their naval build-up continues- so they've got time to do some more recruiting.

So the next mission is to the West, to the Crownless nation of Dryl- part of the first Alliance, alongside Blackmoor, Phlax and Mystacor- to ask the Wild Princess in charge of the nation to join them. Entrapta is her name, and few know much of her; she is reclusive, a tech genius who does not deal much with others.

Her people love her, though, a thing they learn as they journey through the dry, rocky terrain. Dryl is a land of little that manages to make much; there are robots *everywhere,* and anyone who they ask will cheerfully tell them the story. Princess Entrapta, leader of Dryl, who lives up to the example of the Princes and Princesses of her family line, who provides for her people. She has

instituted many changes, many quality of life improvements, all free of charge; she is a maker of things, a queen among smiths, and she spreads the bounty of her brilliance to all her land.

Look at this! An old man tells them, laughing, as his wheelchair moves at his direction- his wheelchair itself a many-legged robot, something like a friendly spider, helping the lame be mobile regardless. *Not many leaders would make something for a poor cripple. She's the best damn leader we've ever had!*

Catra listens to his opinion, because she is a Hordesman, and no one grows old in the Horde without being a total badass of some kind; as the saying goes, fear the old in a profession where most die young. In the Horde, whose only profession is war, respect for the elderly is common sense; so she pays him more heed than her compatriots do, and has high expectations when she reaches the Crypto Castle.

They cannot prepare her for what is to come- the infection that renders her weak, and broken.

She is useless in Entrapta's castle, pathetic, pitiful. But Glimmer carries her through. Bow carries her through. A kitchen staff she has never met carries her through. Entrapta, even, carries her through, despite it all being her fault in the first place, despite the Drylborn owing Catra nothing, having naught with her, even friendship.

Catra... disoriented, weak, hallucinating... it's one of her own private nightmares. She's always been afraid of being out of it,

even for a short while; it's why she never once wanted to try any form of hallucinogen or alcohol. To weaken herself like that, to lower her guard that way... it would be just asking to be struck down in a moment of weakness. She must be on-guard, at all times, or be hurt. No one protects her but Adora, no one has ever comforted or saved her before. There has only ever been one person who thought Catra worth the time and effort to protect, in all her life in the Horde.

But now, there are strangers, even, who wish to save her life, here, in this place outside of the Horde.

It's just another new thing, and she hates it, and she puts the castle of the scientific princess out of her mind as soon as they are done. Entrapta joined, all went well, and she can pretend it *never happened.*

(But that part of her that trembles grows, on the cusp of a revelation that would change everything, if she let it.)

****

Afterwards, instead of a new mission, Angella takes pity on Catra's obvious discomfort with the Dryl mission by sending her to Mystacor for a... “vacation”.

Once Bow explains what that is- and *wow,* a Horde upbringing left Catra without a lot of what the rest of the world viewed as common knowledge- she agrees. Fighting Adora and being helpless in Entrapta's labyrinth were both experiences that haunt

her, though she would never admit it; but Angella seems to see it anyway, her old eyes piercing a youth's defenses.

But where other Hordesmen might see her as weak, this ancient queen sees only a soul in need of rest. She does not castigate Catra for being rattled, but merely gently suggests that time off will do her well.

The kindness from Angella does... something, to Catra, is a reflection of the way Angella treats her daughter... and to be the target of that concern makes Catra acquiesce with more meekness than even she herself expected. Than anyone expected, apparently- Glimmer is openly surprised, while Bow keeps his own reaction more subdued.

Catra shakes it off soon enough. It's a trick, it has to be. It's all a trick. Her mind is making a fool of her, or Angella has seen that she has a weakness and is exploiting it.

...But it's such a *nice* trick. She might even miss it, when this is done, when she... goes back.

(She'll go back, right? She's not a traitor... or is she?)

She keeps her sighting of Shadow Weaver at the journey's start to herself, tells them nothing, though Glimmer guesses much. Catra's a bit surprised, but only for a moment; she assumes Glimmer to be like her, after all. Some part of Catra still cannot quite comprehend a good mother, a decent one, cannot understand that Glimmer's mother, for all her faults, is still and yet a loving

mother; and so she assumes Glimmer has particular insight into her pain.

(The truth is much simpler: as simple as Glimmer paying attention to her friend, nothing more.)

Castaspella is fun, and Catra amuses herself via making fun of Glimmer through the medium of her aunt, at least for a little while. Mystacor is kind of wonderful, but also kind of stupid, from Catra's perspective; a hell of a feat, to float a city through the air... but what was the point? It felt like it'd be easier to just build a city on the ground. It'd sure make trade simpler, if nothing else; half the mages she saw were busy just floating things in on transports, jobs that a wagon and a donkey could do if the city was on the ground.

(Unbeknownst to Catra, she had made a point that Castaspella herself had made back in her school days, on a paper that she'd received top marks on... and a comment from her teacher that she "didn't understand the need to prove magic's superiority, despite your excellent points.")

Castaspella takes them on a tour, and even shows them Mystacor's fancy defense array, which is so mindbogglingly stupid of her that Catra almost reminds the Mage-Monarch that Catra *is,* in point of fact, a Hordesman, out of a sense of fair play Catra was genuinely surprised she had. Didn't they know she was Horde? Glimmer should have told them, if nothing else, but she says nothing, so Catra doesn't either... but still.

(*Am I a Hordesman, still? Was I ever, given how they treated me?* but those thoughts hurt and this is a vacation, so Catra ignores them.)

Really, the only weird part is a statue. Lightspinner's statue... it's familiar, but it can't be. It can't be her...

She shakes off the past. They go to the beach to relax, and it works, even though she hates the ocean; she lays down on soft sands and warm towels and she sleeps, peacefully at first. Sleep is her favored relaxation, as she never felt like she got quite enough in the Fright Zone; too much like the cats she resembles, she supposes. She has ever felt a call to nap in the warm blanket of sunlight. She naps, her two... companions (*friends?*) at her side, and the day is peaceful.

She awakens to Shadow Weaver driving nightmares like nails into her skull.

The day continues in that vein, Shadow Weaver wearing faces, but Catra is wise to her, recognizes her even if the face is Glimmer's or Bow's. The day is the worst in recent memory, even as it is so terribly familiar; Shadow Weaver is hurting her again, the way she always does, though she calls herself Lightspinner at one point and some of the clues start coming together.

But things are different, the story skips a beat, her tone is... strange; the witch keeps starting and restarting, as if catching herself, trying to act towards Catra the way she acts towards Adora. It's almost comforting, at least, when Shadow Weaver can bother to remember not to snarl at her. All kinds of promises from the black pit of her commanding officer's face; promises and promises. Force Captain, her support, extra training.

It all rings awful and hollow in Catra's ears, and she cannot help but compare it to Angella, to the way the Queen's voice sounded when she saw Glimmer after two months of absence, a comparison her mind leaps to for reasons she cannot admit to herself; and in the echo of those words, of the way they had sounded, of that nameless thing underlying them, Shadow Weaver's falseness does not tempt Catra, but enrages her instead. When she gets her Sword to turn into a shield, she doesn't even say anything to Shadow Weaver, she just banishes her, tears her away from Mystacor, blasts her with waves of glorious light. There is glory in it, catharsis sharp as a knife; she takes bitter and beautiful satisfaction in making the story go off the rails, just this once, biting back against her tormentor. It is sweet and spicy both, it is good on her tongue.

Mystacor hails her as a hero once Castaspella figures out what was going on, Castaspella putting in the effort to make sure people know that Shadow Weaver was at Mystacor, and that Catra defeated her. Shadow Weaver is apparently a legendary monster up here, a cautionary tale told to the youngsters, half bogeyman and half ultimate evil, the woman who made *the* deal with devils- and like all true evil, it was everyone around her who had paid the price.

Defeating her- casting her out- makes Catra an almost prototypical legendary figure, and the group pays for nothing else in all their stay in Mystacor. Catra even receives so many freebies from the mages that she has to have Bow keep track of them all.

(It feels better than good, to be praised, to be awarded all this- and for defeating her greatest tormentor, too! Even as her heart aches for Shadow Weaver's love, she relishes Shadow Weaver's defeat, ever at odds with herself; but the drug of their praise helps, it is a spirit so addictive she grows drunk on it with just a drop. No one has ever told her how *good* she is, those are words

for Adora... but now they are words for her, andood she is. She partakes in it in only the tiniest way, still too untrusting, too much a Hordesman... but she still takes a few sips, nonetheless, and some part of her famished soul sucks in needed nutrition from the feast.)

Catra spends the rest of their time off soaking in warm spring waters, sleeping, and eating everything in Mystacor, even attempting food from the Kingdom of the Snows, which burns her tongue and clears out her sinuses something *fierce.* It's some good shit, though she favors Salinean food- so much fish!

It's good, and she feels... rested, afterwards. Vacations were good, apparently.

The only blemish are Shadow Weaver's last words as Catra was sending her off, words that bother her from time to time. The old witch claimed that it should have been Adora who found the Sword... and perhaps she just meant that she would have preferred if her golden child had gotten the blade, but Catra wonders if there is not deeper meaning. Was *this* the source of all her childhood pain? Was she so cruelly dismissed by the witch because Shadow Weaver thought that, one day, there would be a Sword... and Adora's hand to wield it? If so, that would explain why she saw Catra as just the hanger-on, just the pet, not... anything more.

(*why does my mother not love me, I am her daughter too*)

...If that's true... then maybe it's an accident she got the Sword at all. Was this why she was so sick at first? Because it's not hers?

Maybe Adora's hand is meant to wield it and Catra is just... keeping the handle warm. Maybe someday Adora will steal the spotlight, like she always does, and take her Sword from her, and be the true She-Ra... and then there will be no more place for Catra in all the world but as Adora's pet.

The very idea horrifies Catra, and so she puts it away, banished just like Shadow Weaver. No reason to ponder it now; it's been a while since she saw Adora, and perhaps they will never know if the Sword is truly hers or not.

(She hopes Adora is okay, that she can come to her anyway, that the Sword isn't Adora's but that *Catra* might be Adora's...)

****

Adora stumbles through her days like a furnace without fuel.

She is choked, smothered, the fire of her soul turned down. Too much death. So much death. All on her hands...

She has done something so horrible, so terrible... and done it perfectly, she even got *praise* for it. Awful things, done perfectly, the way Adora does everything perfectly. Who knew her talents extended to atrocity?

(Something like a laugh wants to crack her open, but she keeps it inside, knows somehow that if she starts laughing now she'll lose *everything,* if she laughs now it will blow her to rags and atoms at a blast, and she will be lost to the bright fury of hopeless joy, same as she would be to cold dark fingers at her temples)

The other Hordesmen see only the “done perfectly”, not the “awful.” They compliment her, they boast of their “badass” Force Captain, even though it was nothing more than farmers and the innocent. Adora finds herself full of a vicious hatred for them, for her soldiers, for these cowards in armor, who uphold no honor- and an even deeper hatred for herself, for not seeing that the honor and glory she had so long spoken of was just a lie fed to her as a child. Catra was always smarter, she saw through it years ago. Adora, though...

At least some of it has to be the simple fact that Shadow Weaver has been digging in her skull like a gold mine for years. This Adora *must* believe, she *must* believe that some of it is Shadow Weaver's fault... because Adora cannot forgive herself if this stupidity is entirely her own fault. It's hard enough to live with the crushing guilt that's eating her alive as it stands; if it turns out that Shadow Weaver was innocent, if Adora's foolishness was all her own...

It would kill her.

It *is* killing her, to realize what she is. She is a bad person, who serves more monstrous souls, and she is Evil with the capitals intended.

She always has been.

Only Catra ever questioned the Horde, only Catra ever thought the whole thing pointless. And she'd been... she'd been right. All this time, Adora had thought she was the superior one between them, morally speaking; Catra never had time for morals, or at least, she never held to the honor of the Horde, never held to the Horde's truth.

And now Adora realizes the hilarious irony of it all, something that's so funny she laughs, even as she sobs; Catra, not her, was the morally superior one. Trouble-making *Catra* is the one between the two of them who might be Good, with the capitals intended; and doesn't that just fit? Of *course* Catra, so Good, caused trouble in the Horde; they are all bad people, they are all Evil, with the capitals intended.

Especially Adora herself.

She's the worst.

(And a flicker of jealous hatred grows in her heart, so unfamiliar to Adora, so alien, so foreign, so strange that she misses it entirely, misunderstands it- this tiny green spark, that is the beginning of a hatred for Catra, who is now the thing Adora wishes she was. It is an unfair hatred, but it feels better than hating herself, so in secret she nurses it. It is tiny... for now.)

****

The next mission is not one Angella gives them, but one that is requested *of* them, to the mutual surprise of all three. The Snows is calling on an old custom, and is seeking to host the Princess Prom.

It's apparently short for the Princess Promotional. It's something a Plumerian Princess came up with a century or so ago- a truce meeting between the Runestone Kingdoms and all available Wild Princesses, a way for "the mightiest among us to meet in peace and resolve our differences." Something like a combination of a ball and a meeting, according to Angella, who grimaces like a *motherfucker* as she receives her invitation.

(Catra can't entirely help her amusement as Glimmer wears the exact same expression. Bad blood between Brightmoon and the Snows indeed.)

They've even- apparently *graciously*, a word Angella makes into an insult even as she says it with perfect politeness- decided to finally acknowledge Glimmer as a Princess, which they've apparently never done before. She's getting an invite- though Catra isn't. Apparently the Snows doesn't believe she's the "real" She-Ra, which pisses Catra off; she's the Princess of Power, why the hell doesn't *she* get an invite?

" Probably because you're from Brightmoon," Glimmer tells her.

“ No I'm not, I'm from the Horde,” Catra reminds her, to which Glimmer rolls her eyes.

“ I mean, you're from Brightmoon *now,*” the shorter girl replies, and she means it so much that Catra simply doesn't have the heart to tell her otherwise. She's no Catra of Brightmoon, she's Catra of the Horde.

(*No matter what I want*, and that thought just... nope, nope, box.)

Regardless, apparently that bad blood between the Snows and Brightmoon is playing a big chunk of why they don't want to acknowledge her. Glimmer is momentarily torn about who to invite- every Princess gets a plus one, and she initially wants to use it on Bow, before he reveals that apparently Perfuma already asked him. They're apparently going on a date.

“ Well, resolves our problem,” Catra says, and Glimmer has a moment of anguish that passes over her so quickly that it could easily be confused for a seizure. “ Though couldn't your mom take me along?”

“ I'm not going,” Angella says. “ The *last* time I tried to go to one of these in the Snows, they tried to assassinate me. Poison- it made me violently ill for a *month.* I'm not entirely flesh, so it wasn't fatal, but for most of that month I wished it *had* been. And the time *before* that, they *also* tried to kill me. That was an avalanche attempt, which failed because, well.”

She flutters her wings; ah. Avalanches probably weren't too dangerous to someone who could just fly over them, not if they had time to get airborne.

" My escort wasn't so lucky; I was able to save a few, but not many," Angella said, eyes far away for a moment, flashes of sadness and anger both crossing over her face. " We ended up going to war for a short time over that. I'd rather not have to fight yet *another* war with the damn Snows, not while we're still trying to put ourselves back together for a war in the south."

Wow, there was some *history* with the Snows there; it was *weird* to hear Angella be so openly hostile to *anybody.* The only group she acted worse towards was the Horde, since apparently they'd murdered her husband, Glimmer's dad, according to Bow.

(And it was weird but Catra felt a little bit guilty for it, somehow, even knowing how irrational that was.)

" Shit, should Glimmer go?" Catra asks. " If things are that bad."

"...I'm torn," Angella admits, looking at Glimmer with that... that look, her voice full of that thing that Catra *has* to be imagining. " It'll be dangerous."

" Never stopped me before," Glimmer says, grinning that audacious grin that Catra has come to know so well. " Or ever."

" I know," Angella says, and she smiles this... this odd smile, this small, sad smile. " And you going gives us a chance to bring in the Snows, and that would be tremendously valuable... but... be careful, please?"

And Glimmer rolls her eyes and acquiesces, and Angella leans over and pulls her daughter into a protesting hug. Catra's heart hurts and aches, all of a sudden, and she looks away; Bow draws a little closer, and maybe, just maybe, she leans against him.

Just a little.

But it's gone a moment later and she stands up, straightens. She's not weak. She doesn't *need* support.

(But it had felt so very, very nice, it was so... terribly sweet.)

Angella is sending them with a hell of a guard, whose main job will be to get the trio out if all hell breaks loose; she also cautions them not to eat anything they haven't seen someone else, preferably a Plumerian or a Snows, eat first.

That, and she reminds them to try and see if the Kingdom of Snows might be convinced to join in the new Alliance, when they'd stayed out of the old one. Angella doubts it, what with the history between the Snows and Brightmoon, but hey- why not?

“ I've fought them often enough to know they are no pushovers,” Angella says. “ Though I've also thrown them out, each time- often enough that their Church declared me an immortal demon sent to tempt the weak away from the Distant God. I've rarely been so pleased by someone's contempt."

She makes a rather smug grin right then, for the first time looks not unlike Glimmer, and it makes Catra wonder about these people. She'd thought Brightmoon soft, but she was learning as she stayed here that the softness did not preclude hardness, that the gentle and the fierce were not opposed in this land but worked as one. This was a land of mashed-potato beds and hardened soldiers both, Angella was a fluffy little angel and a warrior queen at the same time... and her daughter, Glimmer, she's just like her mom in that much, too. Glimmer's just glitter and fists, but that's the thing, she is glitter **and** fists, not one or the other. Bow, too, who is so nice, so kind, so friendly... and so deadly with his arrows, so smart with his tech.

(Some part of her even- with *great* reluctance- adds Sea Hawk to the list; dramatic and silly as he is, the man *is* a swordsman, and she's never met anyone better with fire. She *still* wasn't sure how Sea Hawk had set some of those fires; she'd been pretty sure some of those things weren't flammable until the pirate captain got his hands on them.)

There is a duality here, things she associates with weakness next to things she knows to be strength... and she wonders if that might not make them impossibly mighty, that they can have both these things within themselves, instead of having to pick one or the other. If it was a sign of *real* strength to be both gentle and harsh when needed, instead of sticking to one or the other come hell or high water.

Are these people truly strong? she thinks, and some part of her wonders if that means the Horde is weaker than they are, in some way, a thought she would never have believed was her own until this very moment.

(More of that trembling; revelation, just an inch away, if she had but courage to reach out to it...)

They've got two months; they spend three weeks of it helping Mermista down in Salineas again, more supply routes exploded, more relief ships sunk, more fuel and ammunition lost. Octavia's *got* to be hurting for supplies by now.

Then they return home to rest up and get dressed. Catra ends up with a snazzy suit that Glimmer and Bow help her pick out, going around to various tailors until they find one that actually makes them- the place is damn near *dusty* when they walk in. The manager, a blue-furred Mane, is excited to take the She-Ra's measurements and *insists* that she pay nothing for the gorgeous suit he ends up making her.

" I got to design for the *She-Ra*," he gloats, pleased with himself. " And in this day and age! I barely get any orders at all anymore, and suddenly the Princess of Power herself walks in!"

" I mean, I can pay," Catra said. " Queen Angella gave me money for it."

" No, no," the man insisted. " Knowing that you, the hero of our times, is wearing my work... that's worth more than even the

Queen's silver.”

Apparently suits are rare in Brightmoon these days, the style for almost two centuries has favored dresses for both genders; Glimmer jokes that she might start a revolution in Brightmoon fashion, which Catra can't claim she'd been thinking of doing when she settled on a suit. She just liked them better than dresses.

Eh, Glimmer was probably blowing it out of proportion.

(She wasn't; that blue-furred Mane's free gift to Catra ended up making him a rich, rich man when suits became the ultimate fashion in Brightmoon within a year's time.)

Catra jazzes it up with a small tiara.

“ I'm a Princess, too, after all,” she says with a grin. “ Even if the Snows won't accept it.”

“ Yet!” Glimmer promises.

Catra still wants to go back to the Horde- for reasons that are growing less and less clear as time goes on, as she spends longer here- but she is pleased at Glimmer's faith in her, that Glimmer wants her recognized as a Princess in her own right.

The trip to the Prom itself is kind of boring, really, after all that buildup. Catra was expecting assassins, avalanches, *something;* but nothing happens while they travel in a cluster of Brightmoon soldiers on hover skiffs. Bow's not with them, since he's apparently going with somebody else? Weird, Catra didn't know Bow actually *knew* anybody else... but Glimmer claims he's always been kind of a private person. Swift Wind, who is with them, agrees; he's apparently tried to get Bow to open up, but he's tight-lipped about his personal life. The only thing Swift Wind knows is that he's been corresponding with someone in Plumeria.

When Catra asks why Glimmer didn't just order him to accompany them, Glimmer responds that he's not a soldier. He's not beholden to Brightmoon's military at all; he's a Rebel soldier, apparently. He's working with Glimmer of his own free will, mostly because they knew each other as kids, not because he's been ordered to. It's why Angella never bothers to punish him for whatever antics Glimmer gets up to; it's part of a deal he worked out with her. He rides herd on Glimmer and keeps watch on her, and Angella doesn't try to pull rank on him.

(When Catra expresses disbelief that Glimmer's okay with this, the short girl just rolls her eyes, and claims Bow can't stop her; Catra, remembering all the times Bow has convinced Glimmer to do things his way, isn't convinced- and then wonders how often Bow has convinced *Catra* to do things his way, a thought she puts aside. Nah. She's too smart for that. Right?)

Hearing that Bow is a Rebel makes Catra think of all the horror stories the Horde rumor mill told; the members of the Great Rebellion, who dominated big chunks of Plumeria, were the closest thing to bogeyman that Horde soldiers had. Catra had never been particularly frightened of those tales- her childhood monster was raising her, after all, not lurking out in the woods- but a lot of the soldiers swore the Rebels were terrifying

monsters. Troopers taken in the dead of night, their corpses displayed in the morning to be found by their cadet class, supplies poisoned, explosive traps along roads and bridges... the Rebels were a small, but horrifyingly elite, force.

Imagining *Bow* as one of those nightmare forces is completely hilarious, but Catra can... kind of see it? He's a deadly archer and a genius tech master; how many times has Bow pulled their bacon out of the fire with some clever shot or some bit of technological wizardry? He hasn't had to save Catra, of course- she's too amazing and too good to need it- but he's kept the others alive.

(She quietly ignores the part of her that pointedly remembers Bow assisting her in combat sometimes.)

Huh. Soft as he is, Bow's got strength, too... it makes her opinion of the sweet archer go up considerably. Bow the Rebel...

Still, even though not having Bow there feels a bit like missing an arm- it's amazing how fast someone can become part of your life, especially when you're not used to having *anyone* there- the trip's not that bad, though stil lboring. Catra hangs out with the soldiers and shows off as She-Ra, the soldiers praising her; and that's... good. They like how tough she is, they love her stories of fighting the Horde, they admire her. It's... it's nice.

It's nice enough that when one expresses gratitude that “the She-Ra is one of us”, she doesn't bother correcting him. One even tells her “you're pure Silver”, and that means something, apparently, it must be kind of a big deal, given how he says it. Soft, reverent.

He says it so genuinely that Catra can do nothing but softly demur, when she has never been soft in all her life before, is hard-edged and spiky. She takes the compliment with little grace... but much joy.

The common folk they pass treat her much the same. They stop for rest at major inns along the road- half of which have a laughing swan design, for some reason, must be a symbol of a safe place to stay- and everywhere they go, people ask to see the She-Ra, or to thank her. A few claim she's defended their villages; the places Catra has fought for blend together in her head these days, it's been months of warfare after all... but she's glad, anyway, and asks the soldiers to let the people through when they want to talk with her. It's... nice.

(The food's not great, though- except the cheese, which is excellent, and she learns to mostly eat cheese and bread on the journey north. Brightmoon food is apparently sugary, but she can't even taste that, so to her the whole nation is kind of bland.)

They journey for about two weeks, land travel slower than water, especially when one is in a large group and deliberately taking it slow. Angella's being extra cautious with her only child; stories among the soldiers tell Catra that when Micah died, it destroyed her, ruined her so utterly that even now she is just barely recovering. Angella will not take unnecessary risk with the last thing of her husband she has left.

(Apparently Angella even withdrew from the Alliance and the War both... and lost most of her troops to desertion? Stuff they're not talking about, only mentioned sideways- Catra can't help but admit to being curious.)

The countryside changes as they travel, leaving the forest behind. The north of Brightmoon gets colder and dryer as they go away from the Whispering Woods that dominate so much of the country's south; this area has few trees, but many grasses, and impossible bounties of wildflowers, all covering gently rolling hills for miles and miles.

It's *gorgeous,* and Glimmer tells her it's called the Patchwork Hills; so named because the competition among the flowers is so fierce in summer that only one color will cover each hill, fighting with root and poison against all comers. The resulting patches of contrasting colors make the whole area look like a threaded quilt, and tourists from Plumeria used to be regular during summer.

It is gently trending towards fall now, and so the area is alive with wildlife, doing its best to eat before winter; here in Brightmoon's north, winter has real bite, does more harm than it does further south. Fat and fur are the only defenses the animals have, and so they are busily bulking up; farmers, too, are busy, herding their cows about, or gathering up wheat for winter. Bundas cows graze peacefully and, as they get farther north, they see a single herd of wild mammoths, the great beasts striding serenely across the plains. Brightmoon mammoths are smaller than the ones the Snows have, Glimmer claims, but Catra can't see how that could be; they are so huge that they fascinate her, and a part of her reflects on how much of the world she's seen since she left the Fright Zone.

Getting kidnapped might have been the best thing to ever happen to me, Catra thinks, and she is in such a good mood that she forgets to temper the thought in any way.

(Admittedly, that might be because, after seeing how fascinated Catra got with the mammoths, Swift Wind suffered a fit of jealousy and she had to spend a good hour calming him down- and also got her distracted imagining what he'd be like as a mammoth, which was simultaneously hilarious and horrifying.)

Eventually the hills get bigger and bigger, until they finally turn into the Talon Mountains, which divide the Snows and Brightmoon. Brightmoon once owned more land on the other side of those mountains, as the Snows owned some land on *this* side, Glimmer explains; but as the fighting between them settled down, they ended up stabilizing with the Talons as a natural border.

" Why are they called the Talons?" Catra asks as they reach Castle Antares, the massive fortification that guards the pass they're about to enter- one that is, hilariously, named Big Ditch Canyon, a name Catra laughed about for a good five minutes after Bow told her the name.

" Oh, that'd be because of all the Krytis Condors," Glimmer says, a bit offhandedly.

" Condors?" Catra asks with quirked eyebrow.

" Birds with huge wingspans that fly around here," Glimmer replies. " Big enough to hunt Bundas cows and people, and a flock can pick up a mammoth. Though they tend to go after kids, since they seem to have a hankering for something bite-sized. It's one reason archery's practiced so extensively up here. They usually

won't attack a group, but hey, we might get lucky and a flock'll pick a fight!”

“ That would be awesome, actually,” Catra says, excited to fight something. Sure, the trip's not been *bad* but it sure as fuck has been *boring.* And clearing out baby-eating giant birds sounds like a good thing for the people here; and doing good stuff, well, it's not so bad. Catra could kind of get into being a hero, if it means people will keep praising her.

“ Flying creatures that kill babies?!?” Swift Wind says, scandalized. “ We must protect the air for all good-thinking creatures with wings!”

Sadly, they are not attacked by giant birds. Fuck. This trip has been *so* bereft of violence that it feels weird after literal months at war.

But in unfortunate peace, they pass through Castle Antares and Big Ditch Canyon- which is much nicer than the name suggests- though it takes a while to get through. Castle Antares is one of Brightmoon's most fortified locations, maybe *the* most fortified outside of Castle Brightmoon itself, and the guards double-check everything before letting their group pass. Crystal Falls might be catching up in terms of security, but historically war in Brightmoon has most commonly come down this specific canyon, and Castle Antares remained ready for anyone who wanted to try their luck.

Still, when all is said and done, the Castle's commander comes to greet them personally. He's a Twigget named Scout, which feels

incongruous for someone who has the rank of Lieutenant General. Glimmer makes the same comment, but out loud, which makes Catra want to reach over and smack her; thankfully the older Twigget just laughs. Apparently he'd been a pathfinder before he went into the officer corps, and he'd kept the name, since it reminded him of all the times he'd grown frustrated when his own commanders hadn't listened to him.

" It'll keep me from doing the same to my own soldiers," the man claimed before waving them through. " Good luck up in the Snows! Be careful; we'll have to break through Chill to get to you, so once you're out of this pass, your safety is in your own hands. And things aren't safe up there right now; the Snows have had a *hell* of a brigand problem since they lost to Galacia. Lot of soldiers from that campaign never went home, and it's not because they're decorating the battlefield with their corpses. They went brigand instead of going home to face humiliation, and the hunger and desperation have made them lean and *mean*. We've even heard rumors of cannibalism, and I can't discount them, much as I'd like to- so be *careful.* It'd be just like the Snows to send a group to take you out and pretend it was the bandits."

After that rather unnerving update on the affairs of the Snows, they're set free, continuing on. Big Ditch Canyon is nice, and they openly debate amongst themselves how the hell it got that name.

(Angella's fault, actually, though none of them know it; she'd written the name as a joke to a friend on a map she'd sent him, referencing what he'd called it in one of the war meetings, and one of his subordinates thought that was the name and ran with it, to her embarrassed amusement.)

At the other end of the several miles long pass is the Snows' answer to Antares, Castle Chill. It's the Snows' southernmost fort on land; Grim Beach was further south, but it was far to the east, dwelling on the coast heading towards Salineas, and its defenses consisted of the Snows' biggest navy and considerable coastal weaponry. There was no need to defend themselves by land, given that the enemy they fought over the centuries was Salineas, and the waveriders had a shit record on land. Salineas had even lost to a Crownless power in a land battle, the first Runestone Kingdom to suffer such a humiliation, apparently.

(The Snows had been the second, fairly recently- to Galacia, a land up north, which answered Catra's questions about what Scout had been talking about. Apparently Octopus Cove, who'd been the ones to beat Salineas, had sent them a gift basket afterwards, and the walrus-like Selkies of that land still favored pirate hats to this day, the two nations getting along swimmingly.)

So when it came to war on land, Castle Chill was the best the Snows had, and Catra had to admit, she was impressed. The place was huge, everyone was heavily armed, and things seemed entirely efficient and functional as they enter the gate. The guards glare at all of them, of course, a few even turning their noses up at them- but Catra's seen much worse, and she's mostly amused, even as Glimmer fumes. Given how the Brightmoon soldiers talk about the Snows, she figured it would bel ike this.

Still, the cold shoulder- *heh, accidental pun*- goes no further than that, though. Apparently their officer runs a tight ship, and the Snows' soldiers keep to a high standard of professionalism. They even meet the commander and his accompanying priest, because that's apparently a thing in the Snows military; some guy named Captain Silver Storm, the warpriest a red-skinned guy named Modulok. Glimmer *swears* she knows who he is, that he's someone important, but she can't remember precisely; her

political lessons more or less stopped after her dad died, her mom collapsing in on herself so hard that even now she's struggling to reclaim the full of herself. Whatever Glimmer knows now, she learned on her own; her mom has been in no position to teach her anything in the last ten years.

" She must have really loved my dad," Glimmer says, with an air of wistfulness; Catra feels an urge to reach out a hand that she just barely stops... and then feels bad for not offering comfort, things she pushes past as quickly as possible. She's not sure what to say to someone who has lost a parent; she has too many complicated feelings wrapped up in her own commanding officer, in her own upbringing, to even *begin* to figure out how to help.

Thankfully, they leave the awkward situation behind them, along with Castle Chill. The Snows give them no guards, but Captain Silver Storm does, in fact, warn them of the roving bandits- and when Glimmer mentions the cannibalism, he bluntly admits to it, saying they've found the evidence. Apparently the deserters have formed an army of their own and have been preying on the local villages, sometimes horrifically literally. The red guy doesn't seem super happy that the Captain warned them about the Polar Beasts, as the bandits are calling themselves, named after one of the big predators in the Snows' western reaches.

" I'd go after them," Captain Silver Storm tells them, " but I can't get anyone back home to give me dispensation to do so."

" We must keep forces here," Modulok says. " Let the capital send a different force; we have an enemy to our south, after all."

Well, Catra will give Modulok credit, the dude's got balls. He says it right in front of her and Glimmer both.

" Yeah, the Horde!" Glimmer says, rolling her eyes. " We haven't fought each other in years!"

Captain Silver Storm, perhaps wisely, ends the meeting there, and sends them on their way. A shame; he looked like he knew what he was about, Catra would have liked to fight him.

But she's happy to fight cannibals, too. There was just something fucked up about trying to eat people. Glimmer agrees, and so do the Brightmoon soldiers, because Brightmoon folk are big on heroism, and cannibals make life simple- they're almost prototypical bad guys. You don't have to feel bad about killing a cannibal.

Nothing happens, of course, to the frustration of literally everybody. The Snows is huge, but kinda boring; this side of it looks like the Patchwork Hills, but it gets flat as they go further north and east, towards the coast. They *could* have set sail from Crystal Falls to get here, but Angella feared Horde attacks; Salineas was slowly retaking the waves, but they hadn't managed it yet. Land travel had been judged safer, despite everything- and so far, it *had* been safe, and boringly so.

The big thing Catra notices is how... empty the countryside is. There are few inns, and those are run-down, even as new fortifications have sprung up around them, the effect not unlike a sick man armoring himself. What people and buildings she *does*

see are dilapidated, and that includes the road, which looks like no one has maintained it in a long while. The locals are unfriendly, and don't much like Brightmoon silver; still, they *will* take it, and it's better than camping outside. They eat mostly their own rations instead of trusting that the food isn't poisoned, and somebody stands guard even in the inns, to make sure there are no knives in the dark.

Despite all this, they reach the city and the castle without incident. It's... impressive, Catra will admit, and shows no sign of the general decay. Catra sees a lot of snowflake designs- apparently it's a religious symbol up here- as they enter, Catra warping the Sword into a trinket instead of giving it up. Like *fuck* she's putting the Sword down, even for a moment.

(It's *hers,* the first thing the world gave her that wasn't Adora's first, and she'll kill everyone here before she gives it up.)

****

New orders cut through the smoke of Adora's ruin. She's not entirely sure how she manages to lie to Shadow Weaver, that she is ready and able; she hasn't felt... herself... since the village.

(Since she... oh, what has she done? What has she *done?*)

The Princess Prom. Catra will be attending- of course she will be, she's a Princess. Scorpia, too, got an invite- she's a Princess, apparently, or at least, the Snows assumes she is one. She has been addressed as “the Fright Zone Princess.” She has no

connection to her Runestone, the brute claims, and Adora knows that to be true.

(If it wasn't, Shadow Weaver would have already killed her.)

Adora... doesn't much like Scorpia, not anymore. They got along *great* when they first met, Scorpia's cheerfulness- and big muscles, which Adora approves of- mingled well with Adora's... idealism, she supposed, was what you had to call it? With her... innocence. Her certainty.

Her faith.

That faith is gone, burned up, taken away not just by Shadow Weaver's cold hands but by Adora's own burning ones, gone with the fire that ate the village, gone with her orders. Adora has... she has *sinned,* but the *original* sin was that of the Horde's, she has been betrayed by her own God. She has lived all her life knowing the Horde were the good guys, chastising Catra for her heresies... and oh, how that *burns,* now, to remember. Her memories are all full of fire like that, they all *burn* when she recalls them, because every memory looks... looks *awful* in the face of the truth, she feels so awful, she feels so awful, she feels so awful.

But orders are orders. And... Catra... Catra will be at the Princess Prom.

If she can get Catra back...

She wants her back. She wants her Catra. She *needs* her. Adora has lost her faith, and that was one of the most fundamental parts of her soul; without it, she is directionless, lost. She has lost all her bearings and she has no idea what to do, or what to want, can only obey like a clockwork doll for fear of Shadow Weaver's fingers at her temples...

But even am dist all this, even as lost as she is... there is one thing left. She still knows one thing, one thing only: she wants Catra. Catra... Catra can help her. She can bring Catra *back,* and then they can work out what is between them, and what to do, in a world where the Horde are the bad guys, where Adora is the bad guy...

(*But will she come with me? Heroes and villains don't mingle...* shut up shut up shut up)

If Catra will have her. If Adora is worthy of having her. If Adora can somehow convince her to look past a burned village and atrocity to...

(*To what? Love a monster? This is what I am...*)

Adora, godless, bereft, betrayed, boarded a ship heading to the Princess Prom, and wondered what she would find when she got there.

(*If I'm a monster and Catra is the hero, then can we ever be together? Would I deserve her presence... or just her contempt?*)

Chapter End Notes

The Laughing Swan is a symbol in Brightmoon for inns; the most famous inn in Brightmoon was the Laughing Swan Inn,

located in Brightmoon's capital, and the symbol has become embedded in the culture. It's a reference to the Laughing Swan Inn of the original, which showed up in a bunch of episodes.

Big Ditch Canyon was in the original She-Ra; Antares was a planet that a person in that episode was from, and is the name of a real-world star, so it's quite appropriate for Brightmoon. Antares means “opponent of Ares”, which, as a fortification designed to defend rather than attack, makes it RIDICULOUSLY appropriate. Castle Chill was Frosta's home castle in the original series; I haven't heard a name for her capital in SPOP, or if I have, I don't remember it, so I repurposed it here for this fort. I don't think I ever settled on a good name for the capital of the Snows in this fic; if I did mention it somewhere, I'd love for anyone to point it out to me. :) I'm leaning towards the capital itself being Silver Fall, while the castle is the Fractal Palace. Silver Fall was alluded to in She-Ra's german audio plays, while Grim Beach was in the UK POP comic magazines.

Grim Beach is by far the most important city in the Snows; its cosmopolitan nature, high commerce, and relative wealth and prosperity compared to the rest of the Snows means that it strains under the Church of the Distant God's leadership, and fears run high in the Snows that resistance to the current government will have its start in Grim Beach.

Captain Silver Storm is named for Catra's steed from the toyline, Silver Storm, who was eventually replaced by the amazingly named CLAWDEEN, a pink lion who is one of the two characters from the original series that Melog from the later series references (the other being, well, Melog). Modulok is a villain of the original. Scout takes his name from a Bibbet of the original series; all Bibbet characters are Twiggets here, since I prefer to keep the number of sentient species down.
(Fun fact: due to the magic, Etheria has the single highest number of native intelligent species of any planet in the

universe, even if you cut out First Ones and Magicats as alien immigrants.)

Antares here is named after the guy who first defended the pass back during the Most Serene's rule; the area is the oldest military posting in all Brightmoon, the area having been consistently defended since before Angella took the throne. It's a very honorable posting; Lieutenant General is the second highest rank in the Brightmoon military, meaning Scout reports directly to General Juliet. The only other posting that merits a Lieutenant General is Mally down in Crystal Falls, which is a much newer posting.

Krytis Condors are based on Krytis Birds, who were not native to Etheria in the original series; they're still not native to Etheria here, either. They're actually an invasive species the First Ones brought with them, though their release was a total accident; they were using them for lab experiments, since Krytis Condors have magic and they were seeing how the magic of Krytis interacted with Etherian magic. A screw-up by a drone released a whole flock of them, which rapidly spread into the Talons. They've settled into a role as apex predators, but they DID wipe out a bunch of indigenous species first; it was pretty devastating to the area's wildlife, as invasive species tend to be.

Their release was not intended by the First Ones in any way. The Eternians were generally quite careful to not fuck up the ecosystems of worlds they wanted to take over- they were ruthless conquerors, not stupid ones- and so were preparing to wipe the Krytis Condors out, though they hadn't gotten around to it before Mara ended up having to shunt the planet into Despondos to save the universe. Fun fact: Krytis Condor magic works just fine on Etheria, which is what lets them fly despite their huge size, and allows them to go after such big prey. There are a few other animal species on Etheria that are extraterrestrial in origin, but they tend to be small- insects, small reptiles, tiny rodents, etc.- and none have had the impact or success of the Krytis Condors.

The Condors' very existence has led to most of Brightmoon's north having a strong tradition of archery; it was from just such a Rebel that Bow picked up his archery skills. He's actually from southern Brightmoon- I based this on his dads' home in the series, which is clearly located in the Whispering Woods- and while his dad was a soldier, Bow was afraid to ask him for training because he worried his dad would figure out that Bow had joined the Great Rebellion. Bow has actually spent a year down in the Rebel-held parts of Plumeria, primarily working in tech but also learning how to fight; he never met Netossa or Spinnerella, but he DID work in a warcamp that had ties to them, and fought under their white-web-on-purple flag.

A Choice of Honors (for what will you raise your sword)

Chapter Notes

Catra, before the choice.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A Choice of Honors

(for what will you raise your sword?)

The sea at noon on Etheria was... beautiful, Adora supposed, but she was *not* fond of it.

The endless water, stretching out forever...

All it did was give her time to... reflect.

Scorpia had tried to stick with her; Adora had distracted her with paperwork, delegation, other tasks. Anything, anything at all, to spend less time with the girl, whose general pleasantness and brainless idealism scraped like sandpaper on Adora's heart, rubbing the wet red muscle raw.

It *ached,* to be around Scorpia, to see in her blithely friendly face the same niceness Adora had once had, the same genial

friendliness.

The same false *goodness.*

Because it was false, wasn't it?

Adora, alone, leaned over the rail of the Horde destroyer, and looked at the vast, awful emptiness of the sea, the great wild wet that would drown her if the tiny ship sank into its fathomless bottoms. The seas of Etheria held all kinds of things, though it was hard to separate out the truth from the lies; fishermen, as all coastal nations knew, had a tendency to exaggerate the size of their catch, and that went double for the beasts of the endless blue. All kinds of stories, beautiful and horrible both, that she'd caught the sailors trading on slow shifts as she wandered the ship, trying to stay away from Scorpia or... well, anyone, really. Tales of hot people with fish tails, which led to endless arguments about how one was supposed to have sex with them; supposedly they liked tobacco, smoking being a pleasure they rarely enjoyed. Tales of ugly-faced horrors with gentle lights above their heads, like a fishing rod's hook, that would surface at night and guide lost sailors home, returning to the darkness beneath the sea as the sun rose high. Tales of vast beasts that could swallow a ship whole, and ways to stave them off; fire was a perpetual favorite in those stories, for everyone knew that waterbeasts could not abide the touch of their opposite.

All lies, most likely- though how would Adora know? It wasn't like she'd seen the lies she'd lived in all her life.

(How would she ever know what was true again?)

There was nothing about her as she stood on the ship's deck; just the sea. The ship traveled alone, which was a sign of how unimportant this little side trip was; the Horde navy had recently suffered serious defeats, and so Octavia had pulled everyone back into tight formation, had reorganized things around bigger fleets that were harder to defeat in detail than the old system had been. And Adora was no longer Shadow Weaver's favorite; she was just the youngest and least capable of the Force Captains, now. Octavia hadn't had ships to spare to protect someone that unimportant on a mere diplomatic mission, entered into primarily in hopes of, perhaps, convincing the Snows to stay out of the War. Diplomacy was... not the Horde's strong suit.

So Adora just had to hope, on her way up to the Princess Prom, that a flag of parley was honored by any Salinean vessels that happened to meet them.

Or any Seaworthy or Octopus Cove vessels, Adora thought bitterly. The pirates of the Cove and the wealthy elite of Seaworthy had both started cautiously assailing Horde ships, mostly joining in like vultures when the depots were wrecked- attacks of opportunity. Octavia was turning back to the west from Unicorn Isle, the farthest point the Horde had taken, to try and tighten control of those areas before continuing the push east. Salineas itself had not attacked, so it was judged safe to turn the back to it, to remind Seaworthy and Octopus Cove who the biggest beast in the waters was, before turning around to pursue the biggest fish in the sea.

(Unbeknownst to Adora at this time, Admiral Hunga, with Mermista's help, was at that very moment launching an attack on the fleet at Unicorn Island- on a fleet that was underprepped, undersupplied, and turned the wrong way. It would be Salineas'

first great victory against the Horde, and the moment where Salineas paid the rent they claimed they had on the seas.)

Catra had been fighting down there. Catra, and her... her new friends, and why *wouldn't* she make new friends? She'd only ever had Adora before, surely she'd be eager to get some new ones. The few reports Adora had managed to get her hands on said she had four friends now- she'd quadrupled her numbers.

The idea of it ached, especially the number- five. Five of them, like the cadet class... but better, because in Catra's *real* cadet class, only Adora gave a shit about her.

But this new group... they were *all* her friends, weren't they?

They *all* loved her.

(Is that what this is? Has Catra found a cadet class of her own, is that who these people are for her? A new, *better* family?)

...They must know the truth, too. That Catra is... Good.

The way Adora is not.

(that village, the fire, she sits upon the sea and all she can see is the *fire*)

The others hated Catra because she was Good and they were Not, the way Adora is Not, they were... Evil, and so they hated her. It was... natural. A thing was not its opposite; Up was not Down, Left was not Right, White was not Black.

Good was not Evil.

And if Adora has done Evil, so *much* Evil...

Well.

Now she knows what she is, finally.

(She cries two soft tears, all alone on that deck, seen by no one, the last of her hope dissipating down her cheeks into the wind.)

Her own love of Catra was easily enough explained- Adora herself is delusional and... and *stupid,* she must admit it to herself, as much as it hurts her to do so. She is such an *idiot* and she is *so stupid,* Catra has called her those things for years and she's right, she's always been right. Adora is an *idiot.*

She's not any better or more Good than the other Horde soldiers; she's just dumber.

(So dumb that she dared dream an impossible dream- that someone as Good as Catra could ever love someone as awful as her.)

That's why Scorpia feels like nails in her skull; Scorpia is the same as she is... *was*, no, was is appropriate. Adora's a lot of things, and she is proud of none of them... but she always *was* a fast learner. She has learned better.

She no longer has the innocence Scorpia wields like a knife against her, her clumsy pincers nevertheless cutting Adora's heart so skillfully. She no longer has that blind faith, that... that *trust.* Seeing it hurts, because it reminds Adora of how she once was.

But Adora has learned. She knows the truth, now. There was good, and there was evil. It was like left and right. Up and down. One thing was not another. There was nowhere in the middle where they met. There was no point at which one and zero were the same number, the same thing, could meet, hold hands; just a point at which zero stopped being one, and one stopped being zero; a binary.

And Adora thinks she knows which side of that divide she sits on.

With her thoughts catching fire, Adora turned to watch the cold, dark sea, and prayed she was wrong, prayed that the world was not so cruel, that there existed a place where she and Catra could still love one another.

(But even as she thinks the thought, hysterical laughter echoes in the back of her mind, and it is hot as hellfire.)

****

The party, after all that journey... is *also* boring, holy fuck. Catra looks around, sees a bunch of people she doesn't know, and she doesn't like that, it feels too much like meeting other cadet classes, all of whom seemed to have heard of Catra long before they met each other.

So she clings to Glimmer, who does the same in turn, and honestly, they mostly just kinda mope around, leaning against the walls, and complain to each other about doing so. Catra gets a moment's excitement when they chat with Entrapta as she runs about eating tiny food and engaging in “social sciences”, as she refers to it, treating the whole Prom as a social experiment. Neither Sea Hawk nor Mermista, sadly, were going to be here; with the Best Friend Squad's actions pushing the balance in Salineas' favor, Mermista and her on-again off-again boyfriend had redoubled their efforts to turn the tides.

Shame, Catra liked her, and Sea Hawk... well, he'd grown on her, like a fungus.

(Maybe she missed his exuberance. Just a little.)

So Catra and Glimmer are stuck holding the walls up by leaning on them. It's dull as fuck, and when the duo are introduced to Frosta- who is a *tiny* baby, she can't be older than like, twelve- Catra almost insults her just to stay awake before common sense kicks in. Frosta wouldn't pay any attention, anyway; she was spending all her time staring at Glimmer. Apparently that vitriolic

relationship between the Snows and Brightmoon applied even to the young'uns.

(Unbeknownst to her, Frosta thought Glimmer was cool as shit from first meeting- albeit she'd not let her fascination show on her face, channeling instead into her imperious glare.)

Afterwards, Catra keeps an eye out for Bow.

Not because she's worried about him!

She's not.

It's just... good sense to pay attention to where your fellow cadets are in hostile territory.

That's why she's sticking with Glimmer. Same idea.

(Catra resolutely refuses to think about Glimmer and Bow being fellow cadets, about what that really means, to consider them that way.)

He arrives with... damn, Perfuma looks good. Bow does too, given how Glimmer's eyes seem nailed to him when he walks in. Him and Perfuma are matching, as Glimmer states with an air of despair and loss so poignant it would be funny if it weren't so *sad.*

Catra moves to get closer to him, but ends up staying back, both because Glimmer seems nervous to come forward and because Bow's clearly safe with Perfuma. Perfuma, as a Plumerian, is given a bit more leeway and attention by the Snows nobility and church higher-ups, who outnumber everyone else at the Prom; the Snows has historically admired the general strength of Plumerian Princesses, as Glimmer tells her sadly, and worked with them to counter Brightmoon's influence, so they're making an effort to befriend her.

According to Glimmer- well, according to what she's overheard, anyway- it's mostly a case of "hey, we're both regional rivals of Brightmoon, how about we become friends?" more than anything else; but greater alliances have had humbler beginnings. It's frayed in recent years, as so much in the Snows has, but it's still there.

Bow meanwhile is sailing through the party, his general affability and friendly demeanor quickly overwhelming anyone still reluctant to get to know a Brightmoon citizen; maybe it helps that he's wearing a pin of the old Rebel flag, the rainbow design they used to use before the various warbands starting flying their own flags (or, more commonly, Netossa's white web on purple.) Rebels have a lot of respect in the Snows, with a general sense of toughness applied; this is more information Glimmer tells her with despair. The Snows sends few Rebels, but they are held in high esteem for their toughness.

So Bow's doing great while Catra and Glimmer are just stuck watching, and it feels quite a bit like how Adora used to make Catra feel, kind of envious and a little reluctant to be *too* mad about it because the person is someone she cares about; and that fucking sucks, so Catra tries to focus on Glimmer. Glimmer is

straight up getting gloomy as the party goes on; seeing Perfuma laughing at something Bow said seems to stab her directly in the heart, and words keep falling out of the Brightmoon royal's mouth, seemingly entirely without her intent.

In the flood, Catra plucks out the relevant information. Bow's from the southern parts of Brightmoon, or at least, Glimmer *thinks* he is- he's always been tight-lipped about his past, but there's a hint of an accent in his Orgel, one that Catra's not good enough with the language to pick up on. Southern Brightmoon has a border with the plantlords, and decades of shared land trade routes means that they have some cultural sharing, too- so of *course* Bow would like Perfuma, and get along with her.

" He probably likes flowers, tooooooo..." Glimmer says with so much suffering in her voice that Catra just can't take it anymore.

I'll have to kill her, Catra thinks, smiling inside at the joke... but seriously, this needs to stop, it's giving her a headache. And since killing Glimmer would be so difficult in these circumstances, maybe she could... you know. Help. *Like I failed to do back at Castle Chill.*

Catra has never comforted anyone before- save Adora, always the exception- so she does her best to mimic others instead. She does her best imitation of how Adora made her feel better, and when that's not enough, she tries to copy what she's seen Bow do. She tells Glimmer the story of her and Adora, emphasizing that she knows how Glimmer feels; like she'd said back during the sea campaign, she's only ever had one friend, too. She understands.

Glimmer gives her a pair of sad tears at the idea of being ripped so far from her one friend- and maybe she hears the emphasis Catra puts on “friend”, the way Catra hears the emphasis Glimmer puts on the word when she talks of Bow. Maybe she understands, when she tells Catra that no one should have to fight their... *friend,* and reiterates her promise, that someday Adora will come to Brightmoon to live with Catra, the way they should.

It makes Catra feel rather close to Glimmer, that promise, and this shared thing they have, of having a *friend.*

So she tells Glimmer to buck up- she's better than Perfuma any day of the week. Glimmer cheers and heads off to get some drinks, and that's good, because before she goes, Glimmer punches her in the shoulder in a friendly way, and smiles.

Catra doesn't know what to do with that- there are too many things like that, these days, all terrible in their sweetness- so it's good that Glimmer leaves, so that Catra can just... process.

She says nothing as Glimmer leaves, lets it kind of wash over her, her mind busy doing calculations in numbers she does not know, but feels. Too much of her is trembling, now, her mind, heart and soul just about ready to... jump. To find out if she can survive the fall, and find out what is waiting for her on the other end of that collapse, this thing she can just barely comprehend.

Thankfully, before she must work up the courage to leap, before she must think about what she does not want to think about,

distraction appears... in the form of Adora, showing up as the scorpion princess' plus one, in a smart, fitting Captain's uniform.

A *very* smart, *very* fitting Captains' uniform. Catra tugs at the collar of her own suit, forgetting things she doesn't know what to do with, and all the terrible sweetness burned away by the hot spice of Adora's muscular form in that fabric.

Then Adora asks her to dance, setting her heart ablaze.

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" We've got a plan to save you," Adora says. " To get you back home."

" Well," Catra replies, determined to look cool in the face of all this. Adora is so serious, and so determined, and so beautiful. Catra would die a thousand deaths to dance this dance once. " That's good."

Adora flashes her a smile as big as the world. It is jagged around the edges, there is something... off about that smile, but it has been so long since Catra has seen it that she chooses not to question it. Seeing her is good enough, and maybe their time apart has worn on Adora as much as it has on Catra.

(But has it worn at her at all? With the good food and the good company and...)

“ Good,” Adora says, distracting Catra from her thoughts. “ Yes.”

She giggles a little at that, as if the word itself is kind of funny- but it sounds off.

Catra shrugs it off again. It's still good to be here, dancing with her. For a moment, she forgets all that has happened, and she is as she once was, before the skiff, again, a Hordesman proper.

“ Hey, have you tried to get Frosta on our side?” she asks. “ I think she'd be amenable.”

“ That's... not going to happen,” Adora says, shaking her head. “ The plan is going to ruin any moves made in that direction.”

But then her gaze hardens.

“ But you matter more... taking you back... that matters more to me than... anything else.”

Catra gulps under that gaze that takes her all in, and does not find her wanting; has anyone ever looked at her like this before? It takes her breath away, to see Adora be... *this.* So hard-edged, so strong, she thinks that if Adora did turn out to be the sword's

wielder after all that it would not be so bad, not if Adora would just look at her like that, forever.

(She almost offers it to her, something between a wedding dowry and an engagement ring; and it would not be so bad, to lose the She-Ra, if it means she will be loved forever by the one she loves. There are things worth more than power.)

But before she can do anything but be entranced, the explosions start.

It's pure screaming chaos, people hurt, wounded, *dying*- and a single glance at Adora tells her who has done it. Adora tries to tug her away, but the spell is broken by the sound of screams, because *Glimmer and Bow* are in there, along with the Brightmoon soldiers who thought she was so cool, and... and just random people, random people, whom Catra does not know.

But Catra is the She-Ra, and so a few of them turn to her, begging for help.

Begging *her*- Catra, whom no one in the Fright Zone ever loved, save one. Catra, whom no one would have trusted so very, very much.

And to be looked at, not just with hope but with *expectation* of rescue, with the idea that this is what she *does*...

There is only a moment's hesitation before she turns from Adora.

(Through her mind, a sea of souls- the faces of the Plumerians, who believe in her- the people of that village she'd defended- of Mermista and Sea Hawk, her new comrades- the Brightmoon soldiers, who admire her and love her; and above all, Glimmer and Bow, who treat her so much better than anyone save Adora ever had in the Horde- her *friends*, who might die if she does not act *now.*)

When Adora tugs on her hand, Catra tugs back.

" What have you done?" she asks Adora, and something like... *understanding* lights in Adora's eyes.

" So much," Adora says... and lets go of her hand, running away.

Catra wants to follow, but the room is still collapsing, and Glimmer and Bow are still in there.

So off she runs, into the chaos.

The first thing she sees is a pillar falling to collapse onto an innocent couple, and the Sword is in her hand and the words in her mouth by pure instinct, running forward as a giant to catch the falling sky, and save their lives.

It goes like that, from that moment on, the couple's grateful words washing over her as she moves to the next crisis, the future emergency, ever acting, doing what she can to stem the tide. She catches chunks of the ceiling, and she puts them where they will do no harm; she catches those who are falling through cracks in the floor that now lead to the basement, tossing them to safety on still-standing chunks of the floor. When the sea of the crowd washes up against the shore of the doors, which have somehow been barred from outside, she dashes over to a nearby wall and punches a new exit, bursting the dam to let the flood through.

(Adora watches from nearby, even as the world collapses around her; watches as Catra pits her strength against disaster, the oldest and most beautiful role of a hero, of those who are Good- and Adora laughs as her theory is confirmed, laughs a crooked laugh with bitter tears falling down her face. Catra is *so Good*- and Adora, who is the source of all this disaster, now knows what she is, too.)

In the aftermath, Catra finds that Glimmer and Bow are gone.

Somewhere in the chaos, Catra managed to save the Brightmoon soldiers who'd accompanied them, but Adora and Scorpia had jumped the other two members of the Best Friend Squad in the confusion and taken them out. Adora had even...

She'd even *taunted* her.

(Who is this person, who is wearing her Adora's face? Adora didn't... didn't do that kind of thing. Shadow Weaver must have done something...)

Frosta is furious, and promises that the Snows will join the Alliance; Catra accepts, and shakes hands with her, which feels solemn and serious in the wake of the devastation Adora unleashed. Not much of the castle is left standing; Catra would have used fewer explosions if this had been her mission, but apparently Adora had more... apocalyptic inclinations.

(*Not Adora,* Catra thinks. *She couldn't have. Shadow Weaver... it has to be Shadow Weaver, she did something, I just know it.*)

After that, Catra, bereft of ideas, and with a group of soldiers in hostile territory, does the only thing she can- she gets them home. Even with the Snows joining the Alliance, the history between them and Brightmoon remains, and she does not want to risk the lives she just so recently rescued. And that was ignoring the supposed cannibal army running around.

(Not actually cannibals, as no one on Etheria would ever find out; the bandits had faked the evidence to give themselves a terrifying reputation, scaring local villages into giving the deserters supplise without the need for a fight. PR is important for villains as well as heroes.)

So home Catra and her despondent troops go; no one talks, no one is cheerful now, there is no happiness here. There is only the urge to get home quickly and figure out how to save her friends, and that urge means Catra puts her troops' feet to work; she pushes them at a near breakneck pace. No one complains of the brutal schedule, for they all feel that they have failed their Queen in letting her daughter be taken; and a few whispers worry that Angella will bail on the Alliance again. The loss of her husband shattered her; will the loss of her daughter do the same?

The news reaches Brightmoon before they do- of course it does, messengers always outpace armies, even small ones like Catra's current forces that are on double-time- and the castle is in an uproar when Catra arrives, completing the return journey in half the time it took to go to the Snows in the first place.

The Queen is... the Queen is ruined.

There is no other word for it, for the wings that curl without conscious thought to defend herself, for her tears, for her shattered heart. Angella can barely bring herself to sit in her throne, and cannot take on the normal duties of court; these she delegates to General Juliet, and to seneschals, and othes, preferring instead to weep in her rooms.

When Catra asks to speak with her, the haunted woman tells Catra that the Horde have made an offer- Glimmer and Bow for She-Ra, that's the deal they want to cut.

But Angella knows that they will never honor it, and so she simply waves Catra away. She has lost her daughter, and has no hope of recovering her.

It sickens Catra, to know her friends are in Horde hands- and that gives her so many conflicted feelings, the Horde is home and she's not a traitor, but... but...

Glimmer. Bow.

They saved her when she was weak and sick in Dryl, have been her friends, and while there was a time when Catra would have stolen the kindness and given nothing back... she doesn't think she's that person anymore.

Somehow, it surprises her, despite everything.

...She can't let them stay in the Fright Zone, getting hurt. It would... it would hurt her *worse,* to leave them there, than it would to go to the Fright Zone and fight all of the Horde at once.

It is not courage, precisely, though Catra has never lacked for that.

It is...

It is being more scared at the idea of never seeing them again.

That is worse than death.

(She's never felt this way for anyone but Adora before... but now... now she can't let them be hurt. Even by her own people.)

And that might be the end of it- Catra has swallowed her moral qualms before, has thrown away absolutely anything that was not

conducive to her survival without a second thought- except...

Except for Angella.

Because when Catra sees the worry and fear on the Queen's face, the way Shadow Weaver never would have worried or feared, something in her just... *aches.*

Queen Angella is not Shadow Weaver. She has finally realized this fact; and Catra wonders what it would be like, for someone to be so worried for her, to be so sick to their guts with love of her. Angella loves her daughter and having her gone has ruined one of the most powerful people on Etheria...

Catra wants to help.

She wants... she wants to make that better, she wants to reward the Queen for being a good mother, silly as that thought is. She has never had a mother's love, and somehow she finds it impossibly precious, it is worth more than gold, to see this woman who loves her daughter.

So Catra, to her own surprise, offers to lead a rescue attempt.

The Queen allows it, having to cling to the one hope she has, even as she comments bitterly that she *knows* that Catra isn't entirely on-board, that Catra might yet betray them all.

Weirdly, it increases Catra's admiration of the woman; Angella is not stupid, even pressed to her furthest extent like this.

But desperation is enough that Angella authorizes it, and Catra reaches out to the others. Mermista answers the call first, of course, along with Sea Hawk, and Catra hates how reassured she feels when they arrive.

(She's not used to relying on others. It feels like... like a good kind of hurt.)

Perfuma comes, too, ready to beat the shit out of... everyone, apparently. Entrapta shows up, ready to repay Glimmer and Bow for helping her out in the Crypto Castle, and Frosta is eager and raring to go.

She's got an army together, and now...

Now it is time to go home.

(*It's not home,* she thinks, and her soul trembles.)

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The plan's pretty simple. This is a smash-and-grab, a raid, not a conquest; they're going to go in the front door by kicking it in, bust up anyone in the way, and grab the prisoners. She's not interested in stealth, because stealth is expected in the Fright

Zone, it is designed to catch infiltrators; but a full-on assault by someone who knows it like the back of her hand, *that* the Fright Zone is not prepared for.

Catra knows, because she has hidden in more places than anyone, dodging Shadow Weaver; she doubts even Hordak knows the place as well as she does. The Fright Zone is not impregnable, it just *looks* that way; Hordak relies on the Horde's reputation to keep opponents away, and doesn't actually have that many troops on hand. He *can't* keep them nearby, since Horde armies are out conquering places most of the time- a simple affair of math.

Ever since the Princess Alliance broke the last time, they haven't had an opponent who could mount that kind of assault anyway, so he thinks it's safe; but Hordak doesn't know the Alliance is reborn, and it's got even more strength now that Catra has joined them, now that she is She-Ra, Princess of Power.

At least, that's what she tells them, that's the plan she sells them.

(It could work.)

She wrestles with herself, as it starts. She... she's not a traitor. She *can't* be. This... this is some trick of hers, some plan to betray them, to give Hordak all the Princesses at once and win the war in one fell swoop.

She could... she could rise high, on the back of such a betrayal. She could rise high enough that Hordak could order Shadow Weaver to...

(*Love me, look at me like Angella does Glimmer,* but no, that is madness, the most she might be able to do would be to get her sent to Beast Island, the most terrifying fate the Horde had. And that's... why does Catra want Shadow Weaver to love her?)

She could be Catra of the Horde, She-Ra of the Fright Zone.

She *could.*

It'd be the smart thing to do. She'd have Adora in her arms. Shadow Weaver would be... proud of her, maybe. She'd be on the winning side. Better to reign in the Horde than serve in Brightmoon.

...Right?

(She trembles. Some part of her did not design this plan as a suicide run. This plan would work, if she *did* give the signal. Some part of her is giving her an out, a chance... a choice. She has no idea which Catra is going to win, she has no idea what choice she will make. She trembles.)

Unaware of her doubts, the other Princesses follow orders, and the entire group falls on them like thunder. Mermista forces sewer flows out of manholes to drown enemies in their own filth and Sea Hawk deftly stabs people, both as good as she'd known they were. Perfuma proves surprisingly capable, even if half of her job is just keeping Entrapta in line- and Entrapta is worth any three Princesses, even with the trouble she causes. Catra has nothing but admiration for the goggle-eyed tech genius, who figures out

Horde tech as soon as she looks at it, and tosses cheerful praise to her as the assault continues.

This... this is good.

(She will hate herself for this, if she goes through with it, if she betrays them. She... she doesn't have to kill them... she can give the signal then stay behind, right? Then she's not a traitor, not... not all the way. Right?)

This is good.

(What does she *want*? For the first time in her life, Catra has no answer to that question, just a bundle of assumptions and wordless wants. A fine pillow. Good meals. That look on the Queen's face. Sleeping in the sun with friends to watch her. Adora. And the Fright Zone only gave her the last of these things...)

She is separated from the group right after they find Bow, almost like she'd planned to do- as she has, in her own half-ass way, kind of planned to do, making this... this thing, this plan, that might lead to her being made Hordak's second in command...

And all it will cost her is...

(Everything.)

Maybe it'll wear off in time, once she's Force Captain and Hordak's right hand.

(Maybe it'll give her nightmares for the rest of her life.)

She tears off, to find Glimmer, exactly where she was going to be- Black Garnet room- with Shadow Weaver standing over her.

****

These princesses- with all their powers- are more than most can take. Lohnnie and Rogelio and Kyle keep up as best they can- which isn't much in Kyle's case- but mostly it's just Adora, Adora and sheer bitter spiteful willpower that keeps her going.

It's all Adora has, now that Catra has left her behind.

(a jealousy, in her heart, that Catra is Good and Adora is Not, a green spark that lights a red, red fire inside, her rage eating her pain and confusion both and providing sanctuary...)

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" Catra," Shadow Weaver says, in a voice that she never uses on Catra, but always on Adora- again, she is using the Adora voice on her." I notice you aren't swinging your sword."

" No," Catra says, and some part of her grows disgusted as she sees Glimmer's face fall. What is she doing?

“ Have you come to your senses, finally?” Shadow Weaver asked. “ Come to rejoin us?”

“ Yes,” Catra says, with confidence she does not feel, hating herself with the look of betrayed horror on Glimmer's face. “ I've brought you the Sword, all my new power, and the princesses in the bargain. They'll wait for a signal to retreat I'll never send- get stuck in and overwhelmed. Hordak's gonna... gonna have a field day.”

“ A fine Force Captain you'll make,” Shadow Weaver says, and while Catra has wanted to hear that from her for so long, it is tainted, tainted with Glimmer's hurt, with this... Catra feels *shame,* now, deep and wrong inside herself, this feels not like a victory but a mistake... “ I've a gift for you, in honor of your achievements. Princess Glimmer herself- take her head. When we send it back to Angella, it will shatter her willpower and Brightmoon can be eliminated with ease.”

Brightmoon, eliminated. Where the food is good, the beds are changed to fit her, where the soldiers who admire her live.

...Brightmoon.

“ Okay,” she says. She does not shiver when Shadow Weaver puts a hand on her arm in something like comfort and friendship, a thing she has wanted for so very, very long.

It is the hardest thing she has ever done. All she can think of is that hand clenched as a fist, threatening to kill her, that hand pointing at her, willing to slay her simply because she had irritated the sorceress.

She wants to be loved. She cannot trust her. She wants to be loved. She cannot trust her.

Her heart spins whirlygig, and she feels sick with it- motion sickness, emotion sickness, all the same.

Glimmer is bent by the witch's might into a kneeling position in a radiant cage of red energy, and she looks... hurt. Catra's heart pumps, pulses, aches. *Glimmer.* Glimmer should never look so hurt. Glimmer, who is so driven, Glimmer, who is a pretty princess with a punch. Glimmer should never be so... down.

Glimmer glances up at Catra as she draws the Sword.

" It was nice being friends with you while it lasted," Glimmer murmurs, as she closes her eyes. The words are soft, and quiet, and they are so loud in Catra's ears that they drown out all else.

And it's funny, but those words cinch a thought that has been been building in Catra for so long now, the thought that constitutes the precipice inside her, the thought that makes her insides tremble, even as the spell fades and Catra is free again.

Glimmer is not weak.

None of them are. This... this kindness, this unbearable kindness they display to her, takes more strength than all the Fright Zone's cruelty. Glimmer, in the face of death, can still compliment her, say that she is glad they were friends. A last gift to her very executioner.

That... that took *strength.*

They are strong, not weak, and that... if they are strong, then that means they... they might not be wrong. And if they are not wrong, then they might be right, and Catra might be wrong, and maybe... maybe she can have this sweetness, this terrible sweetness, maybe she does not have to be cold and hard and brilliant inside. Maybe what she has seen in Brightmoon can be hers, friends who care, people who care, a people and a home to call her own. Maybe they really are her friends, or can be.

(And somewhere, so quiet, in the back of her head, the voice of Catra the child, the part of her that has never recovered from Shadow Weaver- *maybe a mother who cares.* A fantasy, but she would pay any price to have Queen Angella look at her the way she looks at Glimmer, to be *loved* like that by her mother.)

That trembling part takes over all of her, and she has to choose. Her future is Horde or Brightmoon, and... and has she ever had a *choice* before? No wonder she trembles on the inside, she has never had a *choice* in all her life. There was simply survival, and

then things kind of happened and she was working for the Rebels, and things just... kept happening.

But now... she is free. Cold and clear and sober. Whatever comes next, it will be her decision. All the responsibility of it will be on her, with no shield of survival or circumstance to hide behind. It will be all her fault, for good and ill.

She trembles.

Glimmer never opens her eyes, unable to look at her killer. Shadow Weaver's eyes never leave Catra, and they cannot help but narrow in contempt at the delay.

She trembles.

She was wrong before. *This* is the hardest thing she has ever done. Her guts feel ready to spill out of her, she trembles so much, her breath comes in two short, quick pants.

But... but... she wants. She wants.

For the first time in forever, she wants, and has a choice, to take it or not.

Thus, Catra, free, Catra of the Horde, Catra who at this very moment has all the freedom she will ever have, who stands before what may be the only choice she will ever have to make... turns and draws her sword, swinging it at Shadow Weaver in the same motion, forcing the surprised and stumbling sorceress back.

Catra, who has chosen, Catra of nowhere but hoping in this moment to be Catra of Brightmoon, *She-Ra* of Brightmoon, hoists her sword up.

(She chooses. She chooses life. She chooses Glimmer and Bow and the Princess Alliance. She chooses this... this *happiness*, that is the name of the terrible sweetness that has haunted her, that is the name of terrible sweetness. Happiness. She chooses happiness.)

Standing between Glimmer and their mutual tormentor, Catra does not say but *shouts* the words, and for the first time, she feels not silly... not stupid... but right.

(The crown and the cloak feel like a righteousness.)

Chapter End Notes

Catra's choice is still to this day my favorite part of this series.

One more chapter and that'll be it for this!

The Battle of Brightmoon (Catra vs. Adora)

Chapter Notes

IT. IS. DONE.

I count this as a Friday upload because I HAVEN'T SLEPT KIDS. As far as I'm concerned it's not early Saturday morning, it's late Friday night!

The last of the reformatted chapters! I'll go back to updating Catra of Etheria after this; I'm not redoing the other stories, much as I'd like to.

Onwards and upwards, as they say!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Battle of Brightmoon

(Catra vs. Adora)

Escape is simple, after all that.

It takes a bit of luck, but the Sword has always held all of Catra's luck; with it in her good right hand, Glimmer's hurt form curled up under her good strong left, she's more than able to carve a path out. Shadow Weaver is so surprised that she panics, runs for it, afraid of the Sword and of Catra, and it hurts Catra's heart even as it makes it sing, always of two minds when it came to her commanding officer.

(*To my mother,* she thinks, and hates it.)

But there is little time even for Catra's most conflicted heart; she must escape, and she must save the others. She stops in a corridor to send the signal, the signal that, once, she had thought she would never send- but send it she does, and blesses her past self, who'd set it up so that she *could* send the signal, so that she could make a choice at all.

So they retreat, the rolling ball of devastation on the way out- but triumph is poisoned. Entrapta does not make it with them; she is lost at the very last moment, and Catra is haunted by that image, of Entrapta right before the doors slammed shut and the flames roared.

Entrapta, whom she owes a debt for saving her in the Crypto Castle... and whom she will now never be able to repay.

Catra is horrified by it, but her eyes do not sting with tears. She is too much Hordesman to cry, even now; even with her decision made, some part of her will always be that kid in the Fright Zone, afraid to show emotion.

There's nothing to be done for Entrapta, it happened too fast... but still, that last image haunts her.

(Catra wishes briefly that she was a religious girl, that she could pray to something to watch over Entrapta; but bereft of that, she only hopes that something in the universe is kind.)

The reborn Alliance, successful in its goals, shatters anyway with Entrapta's death. Frosta is clearly uncomfortable with knowing they got Entrapta killed, more the child she truly is for a few moments, and Perfuma blames herself for Entrapta's loss; both leave, unable to stay, unable to accept that a single death in the accomplishment of the impossible- a *volunteer's* death, at that, and thus, someone who *chose* to be there- is a better price than they might have been excepted to pay.

Catra rages at them both for cowards, for abandoning the fight because Entrapta died; it offends her down to her bones. When a fellow soldier dies, you don't quit, you don't dishonor the dead that way; you redouble your efforts, you strike back, you make your enemy *pay.* Entrapta was the best of the Princesses in terms of her combat worth, and Catra owes her a debt she can now never repay; they are under an obligation to fight in Entrapta's name, to honor the dead by carving out their pound of flesh *for* them, and in honor of them.

That's how the Horde would do it, anyway.

(It's strange, but somehow, in deciding to become of Brightmoon, Catra bizarrely feels her Hordesman self rising up, as if trying to reassert itself. Catra's not sure what to do with that, so puts it away- something to examine later, in less dire circumstances.)

Catra's anger means she almost starts a fight until Bow puts a hand to her shoulder, and urges her to let it be; maybe they'll come around once they've had time to process. Glimmer adds the weight of her words, asking Catra to let it be; and so Catra relents, snorting as she lets it go. The two Princesses scatter off into the Woods, Frosta sticking with Perfuma as she makes her way through the Woods.

(Perfuma, unknown to any, planning a memorial for the woman she failed- a gift to the dead, to honor Entrapta in the Plumerian way, a decision whose impact on all Etheria could never be guessed at this point in time.)

Mermista and Sea Hawk, of course, do not shatter- and Catra's esteem for the woman, already high, goes up another notch, as does her reluctant admiration of the fire-obsessed sailor- but they must leave, too, albeit for better reason and on better terms. Salineas gave Mermista and Sea Hawk permission to go on this raid for many reasons, and they and their government are both glad to have helped their old friends in Brightmoon... but now they must run back and help their own people again. Things are still in flux on the waters; if Salineas is to turn their current advantage into victory, they must press forward, and Mermista must be there.

(Sea Hawk will also help, and after fighting alongside him, Catra cannot claim that the man is a small asset; for all his over-the-top quirkiness, Sea Hawk was *almost* as cool as he thought he was, and that meant he was a damn good fighter.)

Still, the waveriders promise to return if Brightmoon ever needs help. Catra knows they will- they had been the first to answer her call, after all- and she is struck by the odd urge to... to say something, to make some gesture to let them know how important they are to her, how much she... she trusts them.

She suppresses it- she's not emotional like that, not soft, even if she's not a Hordesman anymore- but the urge is still there.

(One of her best friends is a water witch... and she's also friends with her boat-burning boyfriend. If so much of her life wasn't so damn strange already, Catra might marvel more at that.)

So the Best Friend Squad return home alone by themselves, splitting off from Mermista and Sea Hawk when they reach a river, Mermista riding it somewhere safe to sea as Sea Hawk dramatically poses behind her on a makeshift set of skis, made from fallen trees. The journey back is... not unpleasant, even with Entrapta's death weighing on all of them; the two are too happy to be rescued. Glimmer keeps hugging Catra, and apologizing for thinking she'd betray her, of *course* she should have known Catra was just playing along so Shadow Weaver would drop her guard; Bow, impossibly, says he knew she'd pick them, in a quiet kind of way and with a quiet kind of smile that tells Catra that she has the archer's absolute trust.

She demurs Glimmer's apologies and brushes off Bow's sentiment... but she keeps both their loud and quiet affirmations of their faith in her inside herself, as precious treasures to keep.

(She has chosen. She has chosen. It catches her, sometimes, this revelation that she had a choice and... and she thinks she made the right one. She has no experience with choices, but she thinks that this feeling of joy- this happiness- cannot be wrong, that it is *the* sign that her inexperienced hands have nonetheless chosen to do the right thing.)

****

In Brightmoon, Catra returns to a surprised and shocked Kingdom to return a daughter to her mother's side.

The Queen's disbelieving joy is a reward so sweet; too sweet, it will poison Catra with its loveliness. She is crying and she is happy and she is *so glad* to have her daughter back and...

And it hurts, in the most beautiful way, to see a mother that truly loves her daughter.

But when the weeping is done, Angella takes Catra aside for a personal talk.

" I... I have no words," the Queen said, and she smiles, broad and unburdened and happy. " I apologize for doubting you, Catra."

An apology, and from a mother. Not *the* apology, and not from the right person... but it is close enough that this hurts in a beautiful way, too.

It compels Catra to the truth.

" You... you weren't wrong," she says, because some part of her wants to... open up, to talk to this woman, wants desperately for there to be someone older she can *trust*. She has never had that, and the lack of it keens in her, cuts her wide open. " I wasn't... a very good person. I'm still not."

" More than good enough," the Queen- Angella- says, and her smile is so good to see, it sews up some wound that Catra has

always carried, it is salve and cleansing of infection. " You saved my daughter, after all."

Catra feels ashamed, has to admit the truth to her.

" I almost-," she says, and chokes. She can't admit how close she was to *not* saving Glimmer, how her daughter is saved only by that thinnest of razor's edges, that thing called choice. Hot embarrassment and shame fill her, almost spill out her eyes- but she is saved that last indignity by her inner strength. " I almost..."

And the Queen, hearing the truth Catra cannot speak, does not reject her, as she so fears, but embraces her. Hugs her.

Catra has never been hugged like this before, big and comforting, the wings like little downy pillows. No one has ever hugged her before but Adora, and that had a different edge to it. This... this is... comforting... and safe.

(*I have never been safe before,* Catra realizes, and that almost breaks her right there.)

" But you didn't," the Queen murmurs into her hair, so soft and sweet. " You didn't. That's what matters. Not what you might have done, no matter how close you came... but what you *did*. Never forget that."

Catra sniffles- just a little. Just barely. She doesn't cry.

But it is an awfully close thing, and when she looks up at the Queen as the hug ends, her eyes shine a little.

" I'll remember that," she manages to croak out, and the Queen rewards her with another big smile.

(The Queen looks at her, sees how incredibly young she is, sees that for all her bravado and battle experience she is just a child, and one that has been badly hurt at that- but a child who did the right thing, who has saved her daughter and fought for her people; and she resolves, then and there, to support this girl, in whatever way she needs, from this moment on. Angella pays her debts.)

****

When Catra has recovered- when she is steady, and the gentleness of Angella's hug no longer tears at her insides with sharp-edged softness- she asks to pledge herself to Brightmoon, to be no longer Catra of the Horde nor Catra of Nowhere at All.

Catra fears, irrationally, that she will be told no, that she will have no place here in this land she has come- despite herself, despite all of herself- to love, this place where the food is good, where they change her bed when she complains, where they give her a room of her own...

Where she has friends that she loves, and who love her.

(a brief flash, *Adora,* the one thing that Brightmoon did not give her... but the love of her life, heavy as a mountain, cannot compete with the deluge of good things she has gained in this gently-strong land. Against all that Brightmoon has given her, against *Glimmer* and *Bow,* against being a hero beloved... even *Adora,* who weighs so much in her calculations, cannot be the heavier side of that scale, not alone.)

General Juliet argues against it, pointing out that they still knew little of Catra, and her heart seizes up in her chest; but Angella, recovered and able to reign on her throne with her daughter brought home alive, brushes the General's worries away with a wave of her hand.

" She has earned the whole of my trust," Angella says to the gathered court, and that makes Catra's heart not seize, but soar. " If she wishes to be one of us..."

She gives Catra a gentle smile.

" Then she shall be Catra of Brightmoon."

It is the loveliest sounding set of words Catra has ever heard, and the stinging of wet in her eyes comes back.

" Do you, Catra, once of the Horde, wish to change your flag, and become a citizen of Brightmoon?" Angella asks her, the words formal and formalized; a ritual, this is, and Catra doesn't know

what to do, she's going to fuck this up, she doesn't know what the call-and-response of this format is.

But she doesn't have to.

" Kneel on one knee and say *I accept,*" Bow stage-whispers to her, because no matter what, the heartseeker has her back. The relief washing over Catra is almost painful in its strength.

(*Is this what a real cadet class would feel like? People you could trust, forever- is this my true cadet class, my kith and kin, Bow and Glimmer and... and Brightmoon? All of these people, who love me...*)

" I accept," Catra says through a throat thick with feeling, as one knee touches the ground.

" Hey, let me do it!" Glimmer insists perkily, and General Juliet- with a shrug after the Queen's nodding assent- hands her the scar-faced woman's own personal sword.

" It only requires that a royal do it," Angella says, with some dry amusement in her tones. " My daughter counts."

" Damn right I do," Glimmer says, as she descends the steps with the General's blade in her hands.

“ She'll tap you on both shoulders with it, then you rise afterwards,” Bow stage-whispers again, and Catra is grateful once more, that she is not alone in this ritual, that she has a guide. She is no longer that little girl who had to figure out everything on her own; she has help, now.

(She'll never be alone again; she has friends, now, plural, and not just Adora alone...)

Glimmer approaches, and her friend is grinning as she hoists the sword.

“ I dub thee a citizen of Brightmoon!” Glimmer announces cheerfully, striking her with the flat of the sword on both shoulders, and both strikes remind her of Glimmer punching her in the arm in her usual friendly way, which had no hidden malice behind it; that was just how Glimmer was, all fists and glitter even with friends, a bruiser at heart. “ Rise under your new flag, She-Ra!”

Glimmer's laughter sounds bold and brave and beautiful as she finishes. Catra stands up as the court claps- some enthusiastically, some politely, but all are clapping, even General Juliet- but all she can see is the throne, and the woman on it who gave her a hug, and who loves her daughter.

“ Welcome home, Catra,” Angella says, and Catra barely has a moment to let that burn in her heart before she is buried in the hugs of Glimmer and Bow, who are cheering and shouting and full of joy.

She tolerates them for a long, long moment, luxuriating- just for a second- in the sensation of coming *home.*

(And so Catra is no longer Catra of the Horde, nor Catra of nowhere at all... but Catra of Brightmoon, *She-Ra* of Brightmoon.)

****

Entrapta is awful enthusiastic and perky, despite hanging off of a wall.

" So all the tech you have is fascinating!" she says, as if unaware of the danger she's in.

(Adora remembers being that oblivious, once; and some part of her hates Entrapta, just a little, for her cheerfulness, for being... for being *happy*, a thing Adora is dimly afraid she will never be again.)

Adora considers Entrapta carefully. She doesn't know what to *do,* save that she must do something, fast. The aftermath of the Raid on the Fright Zone has led to all kinds of complications; Hordak's in a state of almost apoplectic fury, and Shadow Weaver rages, too, helpless as Hordak orders a review of the troops and defenses. *No one* had expected the assault, and Shadow Weaver's stupidity had directly led to the loss of the Brightmoon Princess, Glimmer; she's suffered a titanic loss of prestige, and Hordak has taken over some of her duties temporarily, demoting her unofficially. Shadow Weaver is still too valuable to be removed,

and she'll be restored to her position of second-in-command soon enough, but for now...

Well, for now, Adora feels confident to ignore the messengers claiming that Shadow Weaver wants to see her. It's not coming down official channels, and temporarily, Shadow Weaver has no right to command a Force Captain- something Hordak made *very* clear in his broadcast to the entire Zone. For now... just for now... Adora does not have to risk going back there, does not have to deal with

(cold fingers at the corners of her temples)

She shivers, despite the heat of the Fright Zone.

She has never disobeyed before, not like this, still feels that inbuilt urge to be a good little girl and go to Shadow Weaver anyway... but she resists, with more spine than she'd thought she had. Given everything that's happened, it doesn't even feel all that important, to... disobey.

(*and if I'd had this strength at the village, then it would not have burned*- but she puts that thought away, because it hurts far too much to hold.)

She must do something, but it's hard to think under her overwhelming terror; Hordak scares the hell out of her. She wasn't even smart enough to deal with Shadow Weaver, not smart enough to see the truth about the Horde; how the hell will she deal with the guy who runs the place?

But none of that feels important, either.

This feels important:

Catra is gone.

Because... the Princesses were right. Catra...

Catra picked *them.*

Catra has made her choice. Catra isn't a slave or a servant; Catra's free.

And has freely chosen the Alliance.

(She has freely chosen *not* to choose Adora.)

Catra won't come back. She'd had her chance and blew it, ran off. Claiming she'd come back... she was lying then, at the dance. When Adora had felt like they were so close to talking about what they had never named, the thing between them...

Just more lies. Everything, everywhere, it was all *lies,* and Adora was just too damn stupid to see it. Too dumb to realize the

Horde's truth, too blind to realize that Shadow Weaver was a monster, too foolish to realize that what she felt for Catra was...

Was not reciprocated.

Catra is a Princess, now, and has went where Princesses go; away. Away from the Horde. Away from...

(*from me*)

For all Adora knows, she's with one of the two she is always with, or maybe both, who knew? Adora didn't.

Catra had never needed Adora... not the way Adora needed her.

It makes Adora see *red.*

(a flame, hatred, it feels so good, it hurts in an addictive kind of way; it distracts her, cauterizes her wounds. Hurt, but her own hurt, chosen, and not the hurt Catra has dealt her, and so it is better hurt...)

So Catra's the big hero, and Adora's a bad guy, right?

Well, if she's the villain, if she's the monster...

It's high time she played the part.

(Something furious and jealous and, above all things, *hurt* propels her forward.)

" Entrapta," Adora finally says in the interrogation room, voice a low, doglike growl. Seduction and cleverness were Catra's trademarks, and Adora only has the blunt force of her own personality... oh, but the beauty of brute force is that, if you have enough of it, it always suffices.

" Whoa, Adora, you sound scary," Scorpia says, but Adora ignores her, as she has ignored her all this time.

" Yes?" the bright-eyed engineer asks, all happy and *friendly* and Adora hates her, hates her *so much.*

But she needs minions, servants, help, if she is to be the savage to Catra's savior; so she mollifies her words, lies.

(She's surrounded by so many lies already; what's one more? From her own lips, no less! What a novel idea! The world lies to her so much, why not lie right back?)

" Your friends left you to die," Adora growls. " They chose to sacrifice you. Probably because you're good with technology. The rest are elementals. They don't traditionally like tech."

" That's not true!" Entrapta replies, full of trust.

It's familiar to Adora... and thus, she knows what to do about it. She had faith once, too.

" Are you sure about that?" Adora responds.

It takes time, and more lies, but not much more time and not many more lies. Faith in others is something Adora has a lot of familiarity with, and having that faith *destroyed* is something she is even *more* intimately familiar with lately; this is not new territory to her, but a retread of old ground.

It takes her but an hour before Entrapta, worn down, cries, admitting that no one is coming to rescue her, that those she loved and trusted have left her to die. This is faster than Adora expects; it seems that there is a wound in Entrapta, some sneaking suspicion that others will not like her, an old fear that Adora finds fertile kindling to stoke the fire of doubt and betrayal.

Adora cannot help but think it is a sign from whatever forces in the universe exist; this is the right path. Lying, being a monster, hurting people, *this...* this is what she was always meant to be.

So in service to whatever powers she has always served unknowingly, Adora leans in to make the crying girl an offer.

“ You can get revenge,” Adora says to her. Revenge is a beautiful thing, after all; just thinking about it cauterizes Adora's broken heart back together. Her heart cannot bleed when it is covered, every inch, in shiny burn scars. “ They left you to die on purpose. So why not pay them *back?*”

It takes a little more time; to Entrapta's credit, despite Adora's bullying, despite Adora stabbing her directly in her deepest insecurities, Entrapta is not naturally predisposed to anger or vengeance.

But as Scorpia watches in almost mute horror, barely able to offer rebuttal, Adora sends all Entrapta's arguments up in smoke.

(It is good that Scorpia speaks little; Adora sees so much of her old self in the big Force Captain that she cannot help but hate her, hate her, *hate her,* and she's not sure she could control it if Scorpia were to speak up. When the big girl doodles them as friends, Adora is torn between hysterical, disbelieving laughter and the sudden, almost overwhelming urge to put a sword through the Scorpioni's guts.)

Adora rather enjoys what she's doing. She's never been so angry before, so cruel, so sadistic... but it... it helps.

It helps because she hurts, everything *hurts,* and it's been hurting for a long, long time. She wakes up every morning and Catra is not at her feet. She wakes up every morning and Catra is not there at her side. She wakes up every morning to the knowledge that her mother, the only mother she has ever had, has been stealing memories out of her brain, and editing the ones she leaves behind.

She wakes up every day to a world gone *wrong,* to a world where Catra is the hero, and she is the villain.

(the fire in the village and the sound of it burning down, the screams, what has she done?)

It hurts, it hurts, *she hurts*.

But this... rage, this all-consuming fury, that drives her to hurt Entrapta, to lie to her, that wants to grab Scorpia by the head and shake her until she screams... this hellhound thing inside her, that howls for blood and vengeance, it *doesn't* hurt. It's the only thing in her skin that *isn't* pain.

It is gloriously basic, brutally physical, gratification immediate and pure; and she doesn't have to worry that it's fake, because Shadow Weaver is so cold that she would never implant such fire in Adora's veins. It's *real.*

It might be the only thing inside her that's real at all.

So she does the only thing she can: she feeds the one thing she can trust, lets it grow fat and strong, takes this Fenrir inside and does not chain her up, but sets her free.

When Entrapta finally signs on, she gives her two orders.

First, poke around the one crystal they have, see if her theories- which she'd rambled about before Adora started in on her- have merit...

And second, build her a suit.

She needs something, if she's gonna take on the She-Ra.

(If she doesn't call her Catra, it makes it a little easier.)

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There's a big lull in the fighting after the Raid on the Fright Zone, as it's being called by others. Hordak is drawing troops back home, and it doesn't help that Salineas is beginning to lock down its victory at sea; for all Octavia's apparent ability, she can't hold out. Salineas' claim that they alone rented the seas was proving less boast and more truth, these days.

(The Best Friend Squad got some letters from Salineas' leadership, thanking them for the critical role they'd played in weakening Octavia's forces- and a few gifts, because the ever-pragmatic Salinean mindset dictated that all gratitude be accompanied by something physical. Catra wasn't going to argue- she'd gotten a big packet of Salinean seasonings she'd grown fond of on campaign! She'd given them to the castle cooks and been enjoying them since.)

With the free time, Catra eventually seeks answers to her powers, to help Glimmer- who is still suffering from side-effects of whatever Shadow Weaver did to her- and her search leads her into the Woods. A strange place, a place that is... different. A Castle of Crystal, in the middle of the Woods...

She is joined by Adora, shortly thereafter, who comes at the beck and call of electronic devices. Catra's eyes light up at seeing her, even with the weird armor Adora's wearing- bulky, and huge, with a shield thick as a marble column. The helmet's a snarling dog, which is a bit weirder than it needs to be; it makes Catra think of cats, and dogs, and all the sayings thereof, and it makes her... uneasy.

But then Adora pops that scary helmet off, retracting it back into the suit, and she grins when she sees her. Adora, who smiles at her, and Catra forgets the Prom, forgets everything except how much she loves this girl, when she sees that smile.

(Still, some distant part of her- some part not full of the bright fire of Adora's smile- idly wonders who the hell built the armor for her; it almost looks like Hordak's get-up, if bulkier. Maybe Adora got it for good service, or something?)

" Hey Catra! Or, err, is it She-Ra? What's appropriate?" Adora asks in Mountainflower. " Probably should have asked that last time we got to talk."

" Catra," the Princess of Power replies, honestly, and in the Horde's Perfect Speech. She-Ra she is proud to be... but from Adora's lips, she only ever wants to be called Catra.

(Catra doesn't even notice herself slipping back into the language of her childhood, that she and Adora spent their youth in; but Adora does, and switches to it as well.)

" I guess She-Ra's a title, really," Adora muses before nodding at the Crystal Castle." So what's all this? Brightmoon didn't build this..."

" Some kind of tech support for this Sword," Catra says, brandishing it, showing off- just a little. She likes showing off to Adora, she likes impressing her; she always has, and it feels easy to slip back into old habits, now. It's just like old times- just her and Adora. It's... easy, to forget the last few months, here with Adora. " Learning new powers."

She smiles at Adora, who smiles back.

" Yeah, I've been trying out new stuff, too," Adora says, and stretches in her suit; and oh, has anyone ever looked so good?

" What's that you're wearing?" Catra asks, feeling her cheeks heat up. " ...Looks good on you."

" Something I stole from the Fright Zone," Adora says smugly. " Let's explore, shall we?"

And for just a little while, for all that Catra is now two foot taller than usual, for all that Adora is wearing her gigantic suit... somehow, despite everything, they are the way they used to be, two girls against the world, fighting monsters and saving each other.

And finally, *finally,* Catra can repay Adora all her kindnesses; she rescues her, shows her how much stronger she's gotten, leads the way deeper into the Castle. She can be of a standing with Adora, now, their partnership, their *relationship* does not have to be so unbalanced; she does not have to be a burden on Adora, nor a weight dragging her down.

It is... *wonderful.*

(Catra misses the flare of rage on Adora's face when she steals her kill, misses that Adora sees her leadership as a taunt- *I do not need you, Adora, I only needed you when I was weak.* Communications misunderstood, and so much damage from it.)

But then the memories start, and she loses sight of Adora. Memories drown Catra...

It hurts.

(it hurts it hurts it hurts)

But something stays the hand of nightmare for a minute, and gives Catra a chance for breathing room.

(the pressure of a planet in chains, pulsing from the Sword; the Sword is the biggest chain, but as Etheria was linked to it, so is it linked to Etheria- and the planet pushes, pushes, striving to save one it hopes will save it in turn)

Catra uses that moment to fight back, as best she can. She has new memories now, and happiness to combat them, and these old ones... they hurt, they hurt so much, but she struggles on through.

For every memory of Shadow Weaver, she wields one of Queen Angella, of her joy and her smile at Glimmer's safe return; for every memory of her cadet class keeping her outside, away, separate, apart, she thinks of Bow, Glimmer, of firesides with Mermista and Sea Hawk. For every glimpse of the Horde, she thinks of the Alliance- of Perfuma with blood on her face, of Frosta and her cheerful brutality, of the soldiers who follow her, believe in her, *love* her.

It is just barely enough... but there is no set of words that can render "enough" into "too little." Catra squeaks past the storm of memories with her sense of self intact, by the thinnest of margins- but who wins by an inch, wins by a mile, and she is free.

Adora follows a moment after, and Catra wonders what she saw in her own skull, in those awful moments.

(Adora sees a life she once lived, and rejects the obvious conclusion, that Catra cares for her; because if that is true, if she admits that, then her whole life falls apart *again.* Adora, once the golden child, has rebuilt herself as the would-be villain to Catra's

hero- and she *must* be that, because if she *isn't,* then who is she?)

But Adora brushes the question aside, simply saying, " Nightmares."

(And it hurt so much to fall apart the once that Adora runs from revelation, turns away from the cold hard truth to the burning soft lie- chooses to actively misinterpret Catra's actions as smug superiority, all to protect her newfound sense of self.)

Catra does not press. She didn't want to think about it either.

(And so Adora refuses to acknowledge that once upon a time, there were two girls who only had each other.)

They go deeper, deeper, into the Castle... until they come upon a trap. A sudden opening of the ground beneath Catra's feet; she falls, dropping the Sword in her desperate attempt to save herself- though admittedly it almost felt like something was *tugging* her Sword away.

(Light Hope, seeing a Magicat and a First One, and hoping to force rejection, using powerful magnets to move the Sword out of an unworthy wielder's grip, watching eagerly to see Adora take up her rightful blade)

" Hey, pull me up!," Catra says when she sees the blonde head peer over the canyon's side- but the look Adora shoots her...

Adora's never looked at her like *that* before.

(Unbidden, she makes the comparison- *Shadow Weaver looks at me like that.* It sickens her down to her guts, a thought ugly and fever-forge hot.)

Adora bends down, but not to pull up Catra.

The Sword gleams dully in her hands.

" Shadow Weaver thought I'd have this," she says, quietly. Catra looks at her in bewilderment. Where was this coming from?

(her mind recalls the dance, Adora's looks, all the things she has deliberately forgotten in this Castle, all the things she now cannot help but think of- but this isn't her Adora, *it can't be*)

" She raised me all my life to pick up this sword," Adora continues quietly, ignoring Catra hanging in the mechanical webbing. " She only left you alive to give me a pet, something to keep me company. A way to keep track of me when I wasn't present- because she made it clear what she'd do to you if I got hurt, right? My whole life, I've been shepherded to this point- to this Sword."

Adora glanced down on her.

" But then you took up the sword, instead."

Adora sighs, and sounds so terribly old, old as ashes.

" I wonder if it was just another lie, " Adora asks no one at all, as she stands above Catra and holds the Sword, and Catra still can't respond, she is stopped dead, this isn't her Adora as she knows her and she has no idea what to say what to do what to *think.* " But maybe it's true, maybe it's not *all* lies..."

She swings the Sword up, and she looks so *perfect* standing there, like she was meant to be, and Catra's worst fears clench up in her throat as Adora roars, " For the honor of Grayskull!"

And for just one second, Catra *knows*, knows way down deep in her bones, that Adora is the true She-Ra, and she herself was just a pretender. Catra, as always, has the wrong of it; she was just keeping the handle warm. Adora is the true She-Ra and Catra will go down in history in her shadow.

For one awful, awful second, which lasts all eternity, every single thing Shadow Weaver ever said about her is true.

She is worthless, and Adora is the one that matters.

(The Sword wants to comply. But in linking the Sword with Etheria, Etheria, too, was linked to the Sword; and the weight of a planet in chains is thrown, for just one second, onto one side of the spinning coin, and in that infinite moment when Catra fears

that she is truly unloved, an entire world is giving its all to tilt the scales in her favor... and after a moment...)

But the second, as all things must, finally passes... and reality tears the nightmare down, for Adora yet stands before Catra as Adora alone, not a She-Ra. Adora, the golden child, given so many things, is denied this last and mightiest of all gifts; the Sword is not hers.

(it almost kills the soul of the world, to do this, to press so *hard* on its chains- but it works. The coin lands on tails- on the child of silver medals and second places, on the unloved and unwanted, on Catra, who having not been perfect has still and yet *become* perfect.)

What is Catra's is yet hers, and Adora cannot take it from her. Two solitary tears flow from her eyes, gone with a blink, barely wetting her fur, unnoticed in the heat of the thundering joy tearing through her heart.

(There had been a diamond in the rough stuff of Catra, something that was not ready that stil land yet could *become* ready, and Catra has chosen to do so, has chosen heroism and hope, the task of She-Ras all down the centuries. Etheria will take a single tempered choice over a thousand untested hopefuls; and the choice that was made in extremity it now makes permanent, despite all the wishes of alien overlords. Come what may, the world places its faith and its future in Catra's hands.)

She really *is* the She-Ra, and Adora is not. Some small, hot coal of doubt inside is struck cold and dead at last by the thunderbolt of this revelation.

(Etheria *believes* in her.)

Adora, though, simply grins as if she'd expected this.

" Just another lie, then," she says, quietly... and then chucks the Sword down past Catra.

" No!" Catra yells, lunging for it, nearly falling again before catching herself once more.

" Guess it's just you," Adora says, laughing- but in that quiet, nothing-is-funny way, heartbreaking chuckles, sounds that kept rising up at the end as if they wanted to ripsaw into hysterical laughter. It is the unhappiest sound Catra has ever heard. " It was always you. Makes sense. You never fit into the Horde at all- not really. I think... Shadow Weaver saw that in you... saw how different you were... and didn't put two and two together. Thought the She-Ra would be like her, even when, as we now know... the She-Ra is like *you*."

" Adora- why?" Catra asks, but she is ignored, as Adora keeps going, saying things that, perhaps, they should have said to each other, before now, before it became... all this.

" And you know what's funny?" Adora chuckles, even giggles, like her words are catching her brain on fire with fevered delusion. " I always... I always thought you were more like her than you were like anyone else! Ha ha! Can you believe? I thought... I thought the She-Ra was... was like Shadow Weaver."

Adora hiccups, as if stifling a sob, still laughing- but there are tears shining in her eyes.

" But I've been wrong about so much, haven't I?" Adora says, with those tears dripping down her face. " I was a good little Horde soldier, but you weren't, and I... I thought that meant..."

" I thought that meant so much."

Adora grins at her, but it is small and shattered and it hurts, it hurts Catra because she knows that Adora herself must ache, or she would never smile like *that.*

" But I guess that was just another lie, too. Just like... I was the good kid, you were the bad kid... but that wasn't true either, was it? I've seen you out there, Catra. So... so beautiful, so wonderful, defender of the people... the thing I wanted to be. But now I've... I've killed... the innocent, burned their homes... and it's all gone wrong, hasn't it?"

She makes that sobbing hiccup sound again.

" Adora," Catra whispers, all she can say in the face of Adora's tears.

" But now that I know the truth... I can't very well go back to lying to myself about it, can I? I can lie about everything, but not about this. I'm not the hero. *You're the hero.* And that means... that I am..."

And then Adora pulls out her gun and shoots her.

****

Something in Adora is breaking.

(She thinks it might be her heart.)

She replays it, over and over again, that last moment- her hands that shot Catra, and she cannot forgive any part of that, she wants to die, she wants to leap after Catra and fall down the valley and die with her unworthy bones broken next to Catra's shattered form.

But...

But she can't.

That's not what the bad guy in a story does.

And Adora is so tired of lying to herself about who she is.

She forces herself to escape the Castle, to dedicate herself to destroying the Princesses, to ruling the world in the name of the Horde.

She can do this.

(She has believed so many lies, she can believe one more.)

****

Catra does not clearly remember much, after the fall.

Too many emotions, too many revelations. Revelations and that stupid horse- who is her friend, who she apologizes to. She is new at this stuff, at this making of friends, at goodness and politeness, and she is at her absolute lowest point at this moment, at the bottom of the valley... but she recognizes when she goes too far, and she clumsily apologizes.

Her gesture is accepted, despite its crudeness, and she is forgiven; is this not a wonder, that she can say she is sorry, and it is worth something? That would never have happened before, in the Horde; it was why Catra learned not to apologize, it would never be accepted.

But her tongue must have grown more clever as it picked up Brightmoon's language; Swift Wind forgives her the harsh words, so long as she accompanies them with a scritch behind the ears that she freely gives.

(Maybe she'll make a half-decent princess after all.)

Swift Wind is her ride out, and she goes to it with a heavy heart. Adora... she has to save her. Shadow Weaver has done something to her...

Thinking this thought as they fly, she brings her hand to the hilt of the Sword, and she finds its presence a tremendous comfort; she feels so bizarrely *grateful*, so terribly *overwhelmed*, by the loyalty of the Sword. A stupid thought, maybe- it's a Sword, not a person- but...

Still. It did not abandon her. It did not pick Adora.

Catra is still the She-Ra.

And as the Princess of Power, she can save Adora from what was done to her.

(She flies into Etheria's skies, carrying the hopes of a world entire on her unaware shoulders, an unknowing Atlas.)

****

Adora, back in the Fright Zone- with all she has done pushed onto a pyre in her mind, so she can *focus*- tells Hordak of a plan Entrapta has cooked up. With the Garnet in their control, they can throw all Etheria out of whack; they can devastate the Woods, and weaken Brightmoon's protections. Brightmoon is the westernmost lynchpin of the Alliance forces; they should be able to give it a knockout blow. Capture the Moonstone, capture the Castle- kill the Queen and her Princess, all in one fell swoop.

Entrapta is eager to do science and get revenge, in that order; Scorpia alone seems to have doubts, but she is spineless, and easily cowed. She'll go along with anything Adora tells her. She may even make a good minion, in time- if Adora can overcome her disgust with the girl.

(She has her doubts.)

The plan Adora has cooked up isn't *just* to attack Brightmoon, of course. It involves the Garnet, and taking power *away* from any other use for the Runestone... and given that Shadow Weaver sucks power from it like a leech, well.

She won't take that sitting down, and Adora is *counting* on it.

They aren't an hour into the work before Shadow Weaver comes running in to interfere. Her precious gem; she's furious, but her stance is defensive. *Scared.* She knows she's on the backfoot here, that all her power depends on outside factors- she has no power of her own. Even when Hordak intervenes, Shadow Weaver *still* tries to stop them.

(Adora wonders how she ever respected this... this *thing*, this incompetent beast, which rants and raves at someone who could crush her with a thought.)

Shadow Weaver tries to disobey Hordak, because of course she does; she never *could* handle being denied.

But Adora had been hoping for this exact result.

(She cannot be Catra's greatest enemy while Shadow Weaver yet lives, after all; the position was occupied until the current owner was removed... and perhaps some part of Adora wants to do this for Catra's suffering and her own, all the confused feelings in her heart in regards to the dark monster that raised them both.)

Adora has a moment of furious glory when she slams her shield into Shadow Weaver's head- onto her gem, the source of her power, a thing Adora had been studying all her life without knowing it. The gem had always flickered when Shadow Weaver did her magic, and if Adora is right...

She is, when it shatters to pieces. Shadow Weaver is left with nothing to weave; she is nothing but a bitter old woman, now.

Adora sends her away, to be imprisoned, and is personally glad that her send-off to Beast Island will occur in a few days instead of immediately. There is a sadistic cruelty in letting her live, there is a joyous hatred there, and it distracts Adora from... other feelings.

(*Catra how could you hurt Catra*)

She embraces the beast inside willingly as Shadow Weaver moans in pain and horror both, lead away by Lonnie and Kyle, who take their own joy in transporting their mutual childhood bogeyman to a prison cell.

" Lord Hordak," Adora says, ignoring her mother-figure as she is dragged out, facing Hordak's face on the screen instead. Shadow Weaver is not important, anymore. " With your permission, we will continue after this little interruption."

Hordak actually grins at her.

" Good," he says. " I have long thought that Shadow Weaver had outlived all usefulness; given her... habits... I see no reason to delay her transport to Beast Island. It has been a long time coming."

As Shadow Weaver- as her mother, as she must admit to herself- is dragged away in chains, Adora can feel nothing but joy.

No hurt. She would kill, to live her life without hurt; and she thinks that, very soon, she will.

" Indeed, my lord," she answers her master, and the hellhound inside her *howls.*

****

Catra arrives back at Brightmoon on the cusp of a terrible event- the darkening of the skies. Darkness over everything.

That wouldn't be so bad- but the Woods are being breached, and Rebel scouts report that an army approaches. The Horde has cut through the Woods, ignoring the Plumerian remnants and the Great Rebellion both, sending a long tendril up north to secure Castle Brightmoon.

Word is sent immediately, of course, but the Alliance is no more, in either first or second incarnation; they can expect no help from most. Mermista swears she will come, but she will not be able to arrive in time, it is believed; Spinnerella and Netossa swear to come, too, but again, there is no time.

No Alliance to save them.

Just Catra alone.

She will be enough. She will have to be. The soldiers are terrified, but ready; having one's own home attacked has a way of stiffening the spine. Glimmer and Bow are counting on her- especially Glimmer, who is still weak and aching.

The Queen is counting on her, most of all; the Queen, who at last gives her the same sad smile she gives her own soldiers, accepts her as one of her own whom she sends out to war and death.

She thinks about that sad smile, as she stands before Brightmoon, and the Horde comes to take it all.

(She may well die for that smile. It doesn't... it doesn't feel so bad, when she thinks of it that way.)

Catra, standing there, ready to make a wall of her own with her might, observes the army as it approaches. It's mostly robots... very *familiar* robots. Her clever, cunning mind thinks *Entrapta*, and realizes the hairslinging technopath must not be dead, but alive- and captive. Captured, and forced to make machines for the enemy; like Adora, she thinks, trapped and forced into slavery.

Rage filters through Catra's thoughts. Another person violated, and it's Entrapta, who had saved her, so long ago, when she was sick and hurt in her castle.

And now, now that Catra's in the princess business, now that she has *chosen* this, she intends to be the *best* Princess that has ever been.

She'll save her.

Right after she solos the entire Horde.

The fight begins; an impossible task. There are far too many, no matter how strong and fast she is, no matter her power. She dodges and cuts, fights and swings. Brightmoon's troops fall in from the sides, outriders, trying to destroy vital equipment, delay the siege of the castle as long as they can.

They are the women who drain the sea with a thimble; they are the women who sweep the beaches clear of sand. The task is impossible.

But Catra survived being raised by *Shadow Weaver*.

That was an impossible task, too.

But she did it.

The impossible *can* be done, and she wasn't even *She-Ra* when she did *that*.

So she gives everything she has. She hits the front line and she makes it *break,* Horde soldiers fleeing before her assault; and she dives in to save fellow soldiers under attack while they do their saboteur's work, transforming the Sword into a Shield when it is needed. She spurs them on, even as the enemy comes.

The Sword flashes, brilliant lightning, and she crashes into the ranks of the enemy like a thunderbolt.

But then Adora comes, and their battle takes precedence, as the two exit the main stage to have that most personal of things, a duel.

****

Adora's suit evens the playing field. She was always better at a straight fight than Catra was, and now, the suit negates most of Catra's advantages; Catra is faster, but even the power boost of being She-Ra can't compete with whatever mighty technology the Horde has forced Entrapta to build into this suit.

Catra tries to talk, to get Adora to speak to her, but she gets nothing back; just angry barks, as if the hellhound helmet really *is* Adora's face. She attacks singlemindedly, hyperfocused on Catra, using her shield- her sole piece of equipment- as a bulldozer. Catra spends most of the fight dodging, trying to talk to the person who *has* to be inside that suit and all that incoherent rage...

But Adora just keeps attacking, slamming the shield down like a titan, shaking the ground they are fighting on.

(Who uses a shield as a weapon? It's like everything in Adora has been inverted; from the wise Force Captain who used proper weapons to this... thundering brute, who treats her shield like a club.)

The suit was built to take the She-Ra down, Catra realizes; slower than her, Adora didn't try to keep up, didn't try to match that speed, but simply to focus on her own strengths and overpower her. It will be hard for Adora to catch her in a blow, Catra can dodge for days... but given how much damage Adora's doing to the surrounding terrain, all it will take is one blow to knock Catra senseless, and no one ever won a fight with dodging alone.

But... but she can't attack her. It's *Adora*. And something bad has happened to her. She's got to save her.

Catra's a Princess, right? And not just any Princess, but the girl who's going to be the *best* Princess. She'll save her.

But as they fight, Adora's own newfound strength works against her. She slams where Catra had been a moment before, and the ground gives way; she begins to fall.

Catra dashes over to save her.

She doesn't see the gleam of the blade in Adora's hand.

As she pulls Adora back to safety, saving her, Adora slips the knife between her ribs, going deep.

(It's so gentle it feels like a kiss.)

“ Adora?” Catra whispers, betrayed. Adora's helmet reveals nothing, but she can hear Adora sobbing through the canine's snarl, even as Catra's blood spills out, stains the ground red.

“ I'm sorry,” Adora sobs, “ I'm so sorry, but everything's wrong... everything's wrong... I'm the bad guy... I'm so sorry...”

She backs away, hands held up as if to defend herself, even though she is the one who has sliced open Catra. Her hands drop the knife and Adora flees, running away, even though she is the victor in their fight, as she has always been.

Catra stumbles, and almost falls unconscious, for a moment- but then catches herself. It is... it is a *deep* wound. But... she could survive.

(She had to. Brightmoon- this place with its good food and good beds and good... good *people,* it is counting on her...)

She just needed a minute to heal. That was all.

She observes the battlefield from her raised position for a few moments- in the midst of her duel with Adora, they'd entered the mountain behind the castle proper, climbed it as they fought. She watches as the Brightmoon forces are pushed back without her presence, bots swarming, killing, sees the Queen flying, fighting...

Sees a tank, aiming for Angella as she lashes out with her light, a tank getting ready to kill the Queen of Brightmoon.

Catra's mind fills with memories.

(a hug, and a small, sad smile; and a bed changed at her request, made as a joke. Food and kindness and a mother who loves her daughter.)

Catra... Catra doesn't want... doesn't want the Queen to die. She wants the Queen to live, so she can be near her and Glimmer, just to bask in mother's love reflected sideways.

Not to have it- that is not even a dream of hers, not yet- but just to *see* it, to be near it, and take deep comfort from the presence of this thing she had not believed in, not until she came to Brightmoon.

So seeing the tank, prepared to fire, and wipe the terrible sweetness that Catra chose from the face of Etheria...

No.

She doesn't plan out the next moment. She just does it. She staggers to her feet, and gathers her power, jumps despite her wound, which screams and screams.

She jumps right in front of the Queen, and she takes the shot.

The pain is so intense that it blurs itself; this is it, she realizes, she is going to die here.

It doesn't seem so bad, under her shock. She raised the Sword for the honor of Grayskull, yes- but also for the Queen of Brightmoon, who has sad smiles.

For Glimmer, who has loved her and fought beside her, and made her laugh.

For Bow, who has saved her, and guided her, and been there when she needed him.

For Mermista and Sea Hawk, and... and everyone.

For all the people who have taught her how to be happy.

That's why she lifted her Sword, and that's why she's going to die.

And as she falls heavy and dying onto the Castle below, she realizes that it doesn't... doesn't sound so bad.

That doesn't sound so bad at all.

(she fades into the dark to the sound of Angella screaming.)

****

Cats, it is said, have nine lives; Catra would swear she used all of them in simply surviving Shadow Weaver, but apparently she had one in reserve, for she draws in an aching breath.

She lives, and cannot stop her own stunned surprise. She draws in a second breath she cannot believe she is taking, and looks up-

Glimmer?

Glimmer, whose eyes are full of unshed tears, magic pouring forth from her hands that heals her wounds. Some dim part of Catra wonders if that's not really all that odd; Glimmer's powers are all about movement, after all, and so maybe she can move one from death and towards life, protect one from the Reaper whom Glimmer loves daring, so very much.

(*Or maybe the Reaper likes her,* some small part of Catra thinks, under her addled disbelief. *Maybe he lets her get away with things, sometimes.*)

But the fight is ongoing, and so Catra staggers upright. The Queen hugs her, and Catra luxuriates in it for the brief moment of contact; it is the quick hug of a soldier in battle, that must

acknowledge something too big for words fast, for the enemy comes.

And for all that, that brief moment was still good, still comforting, still worth dying for.

" Thank you," Angella says, and Catra soaks up maternal affection from that embrace and those words she has never gotten before.

" You're welcome," she says, and means it. " And... Glimmer. Thanks."

" You saved my mom," Glimmer says, with a little hiccup of swallowed sobs. " And you're my friend, you idiot. You *can't* die."

Friendship is no shield against death; but violence is, and so Catra leaps up to get back to the work. The war is ongoing, and she charges forth to lead the way.

(She has already chosen to die for these people once; it is easy to risk her life again. What fear does death hold for her now?)

But to her surprise, she is not alone.

Water floods the field; Mermista, best friend outside Bow and Glimmer, storms the field, and Sea Hawk has- of course- somehow

set a boat on fire, because he is somehow the weirdest person Catra knows.

But others, too. Perfuma and Frosta, no longer fleeing as cowards, returning to wage war as they can; and they can wage mighty war indeed. Spinnerella and Netossa, too, and even a small band of their Rebels, white-web-on-purple fluttering in the wind as they descened on Spinnerella's tornadoes and begin kicking twice their weight in ass.

And with the other Princesses there, She-Ra raises her Sword, and there is something *incredible, impossible,* as golden light flows through her- and a rainbow of magic flows out of her like the hammer of mighty gods, washing away everything it touches in a flood of glorious light.

(*Of course it's a rainbow,* she thinks with amusement as the spray blasts her foes back. *Something pretty for the best Princess.*)

All is right with the world.

Then Catra almost passes out again, because while her wounds are healed, she's still down a quart or two of blood. Maybe more.

So the aftermath goes without her involvement, recuperating in a medical tent at first before being moved to her room; they cannot transfuse her, there is no blood like Catra's in Brightmoon the doctors say, but healers can compensate somewhat, and she sees the best healers Brightmoon has.

(She dimly hears- through her magically-induced sleep- them say something about Magicats... but she doesn't remember it when she wakes up.)

She is in no danger of death. She-Ra's impossible endurance has saved her life, though even that prodigious power has its limits. She needs time to recover... but time they will have. Other forces of the reborn Alliance are pushing the Horde's over-extended army back south, into their own lands; while Brightmoon's own troops recover, the Snows and the Plumerians engage in a joint operation, the cold northerners showing the placid southerners how to wage a war.

Catra's room is turned into a lovely little hospital wing, because Glimmer told everyone that she likes her privacy; it warms Catra's heart, to have her needs attended to like that, and she likes having a room of her own, a place that nobody can enter but her, unless she wants them there.

But, even as it hurts to admit... she tells Glimmer and Bow to visit often, because while she likes being alone, she hates being lonely. She doesn't like to admit to it, it feels like a weakness- not all the Hordesman is out of her, and she suspects it never will be- but the admission brings them in, so Catra calls it fair.

(It is the smallest and best of miracles, that she has people whose presence she finds comforting, people whom she has trusted with her life and not found wanting; there had only been Adora before, but now, she has *more.*)

She also invites Mermista, who comes, and they enjoy each other's company, two grumpy souls enjoying grumping together.

She does *not* invite the others... but they ask to come, too, to see her, and she feels cheerful enough to allow it. They come in, and she finds herself enjoying their company more than she expected to, laughing at Frosta's over-exaggerated stories of battle and Sea Hawk's dramatics. Perfuma, too, she rather admires, particularly when the plant princess tells Catra of a topiary statue she made of Entrapta, to honor the dead; Catra shares her own beliefs about Entrapta's survival, and Perfuma hugs her, swears to save the scientist while she recuperates.

(Catra believes her. The others came when Catra had no hope they would; the paranoid little girl of the Fright Zone, impossibly... *trusts* them.)

Catra thanks her for that oath, and jokes that she's glad someone is picking up the slack; Catra is Best Princess, as she reminds them, but she's glad to see the others are finally putting in some effort. Mermista straight-up cackles at her words, cracks up, while Perfuma looks simultaneously offended *and* amused, which is adorable on the tall girl. Glimmer argues with her, Frosta comes in on Glimmer's side, and Bow laughs, too, amused despite himself.

(Sea Hawk just looks at Mermista laughing like it's his whole world, and for once, Catra understands what her friend sees in him.)

It's... nice. Nobody ever laughed before when she made jokes, except Adora.

So Catra recovers in he room, surrounded by fluff and friends, sleeps deep in this healing nest; for the first time in her life, she is perfectly safe.

But she does not sleep so deep she cannot hear the soldiers, as they talk around her room, as they argue and fight over who gets to watch over their protector as she sleeps. There is no doubt in Brightmoon now; whatever lingering questions remained have been struck dead by Catra's actions. None who saw her knee-deep in the water, fighting and dying for them, leaping before the Queen to take the hit so she might live, have any doubts at all.

And the words they say heal her more than the medicines and tonics do, heal a wound far older than the one in her side.

She's one of us.

Catra saved me! Jumped right in front of one of them bots, kept it off me!

The She-Ra was dying, but she only thought of the Queen...

That's what my grandpa used to call grit. Integrity.

Loyalty.

She's one of us! I won't lie, I doubted her, but she- she could have died. Hell, did die, if rumors right! But she did it anyway. That's pure Silver, that is.

Catra's Silver, all right. Purest Silver.

It reminds me of old stories my mom told me from her time as a soldier... of people sacrificing themselves to save others. The She-Ra would have died to save the Queen...

I'm gonna go buy a tuxedo; the Princess of Power wore them, they must be great!

Shit, you're right, me too.

I want one in her colors!

She saved us all. We wouldn't have lasted a minute without her out there.

Catra's the only reason Brightmoon's still standing.

She brought the Alliance back!

Catra's a hero!

We owe her so much. I feel like an asshole for doubting her.

She's one of us.

There is a hole in her heart that these words sew up tight; she has never been so loved before, not by a people. She has...

She has never *belonged.* She was never a true Hordesman, no matter her own personal feelings; in the Horde, she was the pet of Shadow Weaver's pet, lower than low.

But now...

Now, she's one of them.

She is, finally, at the last and at last, *home.*

There is a place that *wants* her, where she can go and be among those who know her, who love her, a people she chose who have chosen her in turn.

Where she can be *happy*, and partake of this terrible sweetness, that was worth dying for, that makes life worth *living* for.

She is Catra of Brightmoon, *She-Ra* of Brightmoon... and it is a reward beyond all her ability to measure.

Catra, starved of praise and love, eats their words with both hands, stuffs herself to bursting on this feast after all her years of famine.

She falls asleep to the sound of her name spoken of lovingly on the lips of others, and she does it with a smile.

****

Glimmer and Bow meet with her on the day she is to be released; and she finally feels safe enough with them to tell them one of her deepest secrets, one of the many things hidden in her heart of hearts.

She tells them of Adora.

She tells them not... not everything. She's not capable of that, just yet. She may never be.

But she tells them that she loves Adora, which she is finally able to admit; almost dying has broken some locks in her soul, makes some things smaller, and now they fit in her mouth.

She tells of the strangeness she saw in her, how she has... changed.

She tells them she has to save her.

It hurts, to say these things; each word is jagged glass in her jaws. But she does not cry, even as Bow and Glimmer do, their soft hearts breaking at the idea of Catra's beloved being warped into a monster.

But then she has the thought that undoes her:

If I cried, they wouldn't mock me, or judge me... they'd comfort me. They'd give me a hug.

I could cry, and they wouldn't hurt me.

It is too much.

She breaks, her innermost dam collapses, and she sobs in their arms; she cries, cries the way she hasn't since she was a child, cries out a mountain of hurt.

She cries, and they hold her, and hug her, comfort her, just as she thought they would; they do not hurt her.

(And she knows now that the three of them will always be one, that somehow, no matter what awaits them, they will be a trio forever after this moment.)

Afterwards- when eyes are dry, and she asks them to tell no one, a thing they promise solemnly- she knows what she must do.

She must save Adora, from Shadow Weaver- or herself, as Bow cautiously offers, though Catra knows he must be wrong. Adora wouldn't... it wouldn't be her own doing. Bow knows hearts so well, but he *must* be wrong on this point.

So she swears to herself; and from her sickbed, she goes to meet the Queen, who invites her to eat meals with her, to sit at her right hand, and serve as Catra of Brightmoon, *She-Ra* of Brightmoon.

(And the first inkling goes through Catra's head at Angella's constant care and concern for her wellbeing, *I wish she was my mother,* a bright and happy thought that she keeps as a treasure in her innermost heart.)

****

Hordak promotes Adora, despite the failure.

She has come closer to victory than anyone else, and he is a practical man, so he rewards that ambition in her. Say what you will, but Hordak has excellent management skills, and a good sense for people.

It makes him far more dangerous than Shadow Weaver; she'll have to be careful when she kills him.

And kill him Adora must, if she wants to take over the Horde.

She *must* take over the Horde, because she cannot be Catra's true villain if she is somebody else's subordinate. If Catra is Etheria's greatest hero, then Adora knows no other way forward than to be its greatest villain.

There is nothing left for her, after all.

(*not after the knife not after the hate not after all I have done*)

Hordak is thus an obstacle; but for now, she will move slowly, plan her next moves out. She will obey. Whatever makes the Horde stronger improves her own position, after all; any strengthening of

the Horde means strength for her when she seizes the title of Lord for herself.

It was always going to end here. She has always been Catra's opposite; and a thing is not its opposite. If Catra is Good...

Well.

Adora knows what she is.

And if she simply focuses on that, she can ignore how much she hurts inside.

(And somewhere in the back of Adora's mind, some piece of herself desperately wants to go back, to be forgiven, to stop all this.)

Chapter End Notes

Nothing much to add; see you in the next tale, space cowboy! :D

Works inspired by this one

Knights of Etheria: The Rewrite by HarrumphISay

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